A DISSERTATION

DEAD BY DAWN

Kandarian Automatism, the Groovy Sublime, and the Liturgy of Dismemberment in the Evil Dead Cycle

1978 – 2026



That is not dead which can eternal lie,
And with strange aeons even death may die.

THE COUPLET OF ABDUL ALHAZRED

H. P. Lovecraft, "The Nameless City" (1921)

ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that the *Evil Dead* cycle — from Sam Raimi's prototype short *Within the Woods* (1978) through *The Evil Dead* (1981), *Evil Dead II* (1987), *Army of Darkness* (1992), Fede Álvarez's *Evil Dead* (2013), the Starz series *Ash vs Evil Dead* (2015–2018), Lee Cronin's *Evil Dead Rise* (2023), and the franchise's 2026 theatrical continuation — constitutes neither a horror franchise with incidental comic inflections nor a postmodern pastiche of genre conventions, but an unsystematic yet internally coherent metaphysics of the dead, which I designate **Kandarian Automatism**. Its founding proposition is that the dead return not as souls but as mechanisms: that what the Book summons is not a personal adversary situated within a theological economy of sin, grace, and redemption, but an impersonal and plenary force for which the human body is merely a vacancy awaiting occupation. Evil, in this cosmos, is not Augustinian privation but positivity, fullness, pressure; the human is the hollow it fills.

The franchise articulates this proposition across four orders of automatism, each the subject of a chapter. The **automatic word** — the *Naturom Demonto* / *Necronomicon Ex-Mortis* and the phonographic and magnetic media that voice it — is read through Austin's and Derrida's theories of the performative, Plato's *pharmakon*, Kittler's archaeology of the recorded dead, and the Mesopotamian incantation corpora *Utukkū Lemnūtu* and *Maqlû*. The **automatic eye** — the unseen "Force" whose camera-borne rush constitutes the cycle's signature image — is theorised through Otto's numinous, Vertov's kino-eye, Deleuze's "gaseous" perception, Clover's assaultive gaze, and Fisher's eerie, yielding the claim that the cinematic apparatus is itself the franchise's demon. The **automatic body** — the Deadite — is situated between Descartes's animal-machine and Kleist's marionette, between Freud's uncanny severed hand and Lacan's interval "between two deaths," and within the comparative demonology of the Mesopotamian *eṭemmu*, the unfed and improperly buried ghost. The **augmented body** — Ash Williams — is read as a parodic synthesis of Freud's "prosthetic God," McLuhan's auto-amputation, Stiegler's Epimethean default, Canetti's survivor, and Frazer's King of the Wood, whose sovereignty is inaugurated, with exquisite precision, by a mispronounced word.

Against the critical commonplace that the cycle's migration from horror into slapstick constitutes a tonal dilution, the dissertation contends that horror and laughter are two apprehensions of a single revelation: that the human is, in Bergson's formula, "something mechanical encrusted upon the living," perceived under the sign of threat in the one case and under the sign of survival in the other. The aesthetic-ethical posture the franchise elaborates in response is named here the **Groovy Sublime**: a comic-ecstatic affirmation of mechanical recurrence that refracts Nietzschean *amor fati* through Bakhtinian carnival, whose mythic template is the Mesopotamian nocturnal exorcistic vigil, whose ritual form is a **liturgy of dismemberment** that substitutes prosthesis for prayer and repetition for redemption, and whose social form is the midnight cult screening. A final movement traces

the franchise's **matrilineal turn** (2013–2026), in which the sovereign male survivor yields to female inheritors — the addict, the sister turned guardian, the wife — whose survival recasts Canetti's sovereignty-by-survival as an ethics of inheritance and care in the ruins of the family.

Comparative readings situate the cycle within a constellation running from the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, Euripides' *Bacchae*, Dante's *Inferno*, and Milton's *Paradise Lost*, through Poe, M. R. James, Machen, Blackwood, Lovecraft, Twain, and Borges, to Eco's *The Name of the Rose*, Stephenson's *Snow Crash*, and the cinematic lineage linking Méliès to Romero, Fulci, Carpenter, and Cronenberg. The dissertation's contributions are fourfold: (i) a unified theory of horror-comedy grounded in automatism rather than incongruity alone; (ii) a sustained reading of the franchise against Mesopotamian demonology and ritual practice, a comparative horizon largely absent from existing scholarship; (iii) a media-theoretical account of the franchise's recording devices as instruments of necromancy; and (iv) a model of franchise-as-philosophy in which the remake is not a commercial afterthought but the formal enactment of eternal return.

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INTRODUCTION

The Book, the Cabin, and the Problem of the Laughing Corpse

I.1 The Laughing Room

Midway through *Evil Dead II* (1987), in a sequence that has become a minor locus classicus of horror-comedy, the furnishings of the Knowby cabin begin to laugh. A desk lamp convulses on its stand; the mounted head of a deer throws back its jaw; the bookshelf rocks; and Ash Williams — alone, maimed, freshly bereaved — joins the chorus, his laughter indistinguishable in pitch and rhythm from that of the objects around him, while the camera wheels about him in a widening gyre. Then the laughter stops, simultaneously and without transition, as though a switch had been thrown. The sequence admits of no stable affective classification. It is not comic relief, since nothing is relieved; nor is it horror leavened by humour, since the humour is the horror's very substance. It is rather the emblem of a cosmos in which laughter has detached itself from any subject who laughs — a laughter that circulates through matter as current circulates through a circuit, animating lamp, trophy, and man alike. What kind of world is it in which the furniture laughs, and in which the human being's laughter is merely one more mechanical convulsion passing through things? This dissertation takes that question as its point of departure and proposes that the *Evil Dead* cycle, across nearly half a century and every medium available to it, has returned obsessively to a single answer.

The scene should be read alongside a formal antecedent and a formal companion. Its antecedent is the closing movement of *The Evil Dead* (1981), in which the unseen "Force" — rendered not as an image but as a velocity, the camera itself hurtling through woods, doorways, and corridors — overtakes Ash at dawn, so that the film ends upon the identification of the spectator's gaze with the demon's. Its companion is the possessed hand that, in the same sequel, strikes, strangles, and mocks its owner before he severs it with a chainsaw, imprisons it beneath a bucket weighted by a copy of Hemingway's *A Farewell to Arms*, and taunts it in turn. Gaze without a seer, laughter without a laugher, gesture without an agent: the cycle's privileged images are images of automatism, of operations that persist after the subject has been subtracted from them. The claim of this dissertation is that these images are not merely the stylistic signatures of a virtuoso director but the elements of a metaphysics.

I.2 The State of the Question

Critical writing on the cycle has clustered around three emphases, each indispensable and each, taken alone, insufficient. The first is auteurist: the films as the crucible of Raimi's kinetic style, from the improvised rigs by which a camera was carried, slid, or rammed through the Tennessee location to the comic-book compositional grammar later deployed in *Darkman* (1990), the *Spider-Man* trilogy (2002–2007), and *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness* (2022) (Warren 2000; Muir 2004). The second is reception-historical: *The Evil Dead* as cult object, midnight-movie staple, and exemplary "video nasty," prosecuted under the United Kingdom's Obscene Publications Act during the moral panic that issued in the Video Recordings Act 1984 (Barker

1984; Egan 2007; Egan 2011). The third is generic: the cycle as paradigm of "splatstick," of the gleeful corporeal destruction that Philip Brophy diagnosed in 1986 under the name "horrality" — a portmanteau of horror, morality, and hilarity naming a cinema less invested in what it shows than in the aggressive act of showing (Brophy 1986; McCarty 1984; Pinedo 1997).

What none of these approaches undertakes is to take the cycle at its word: to treat its recurrent figures — the Book bound in flesh, the tape that speaks after its speaker's death, the trees that see, the corpse that dances, the hand that rebels, the man who replaces it with a machine — as propositions about the dead, the body, language, and the world. The methodological wager of this study is that a popular franchise can philosophise, not by illustrating theses formulated elsewhere, but by working through, in the medium of moving images, problems that philosophy has posed in its own idiom. The precedent is Stephen Mulhall's *On Film* (2002), which reads the *Alien* quartet as a sustained meditation on embodiment and on the condition of sequelhood itself; behind Mulhall stands Stanley Cavell's insistence that film is a medium in which the skeptical problematic of modern philosophy is not represented but undergone (Cavell 1979 [1971]; Wartenberg 2007). The *Evil Dead* cycle is the horror genre's counterpart to Mulhall's *Alien*: a franchise whose very structure — remake, sequel, reboot, recurrence — forms part of what it thinks.

1.3 Corpus, Variants, and the Lévi-Straussian Principle

The corpus comprises a primary series of theatrical features and a television serial, a set of prototypes and paratexts, and a penumbra of works in which the cycle's figures migrate beyond it. Its continuity is notoriously unstable. *Evil Dead II* opens by retelling the first film in compressed and contradictory form, eliminating three of its five protagonists; *Army of Darkness* survives in two endings that deliver its hero to incompatible futures; *Ash vs Evil Dead* proceeds largely as though the medieval film had never occurred; the 2013 feature leaves its relation to its predecessors deliberately indeterminate, admitting Ash only in a post-credits coda; and *Evil Dead Rise* multiplies the Book itself, revealing it to be one of three volumes where earlier entries had imagined one. Rather than adjudicate among these versions, the dissertation adopts the principle Claude Lévi-Strauss formulated in "The Structural Study of Myth": that a myth consists of the totality of its variants, that no version enjoys the status of an original against which the others are measured, and that later interpretations — Freud's *Oedipus* included — belong to the myth they interpret (Lévi-Strauss 1963 [1955]). The cycle's contradictions are accordingly treated not as lapses of continuity but as the very form in which the mythos exists: a palimpsest, like the Book at its centre, perpetually overwritten by its users.

Lévi-Strauss supplies a second figure apposite to the corpus: the *bricoleur*, who builds with whatever lies to hand, repurposing the debris of prior constructions (Lévi-Strauss 1966 [1962]). The cycle was bricolage at its origin — a feature financed by Detroit-area professionals and family acquaintances, shot in a derelict Tennessee farmhouse with equipment hauled in by its young

crew, its blood compounded from corn syrup and dye, its departed cast members replaced by "Fake Shemps," body doubles filmed from behind and named after the stand-in who completed the Three Stooges' shorts after Shemp Howard's death (Campbell 2001). And bricolage is its protagonist's mode of being: Ash fashions a chainsaw into a forearm, a metal gauntlet from medieval scrap, a war machine from an Oldsmobile, and an arsenal from a chemistry textbook. The coincidence between the economy of production and the economy of the diegesis recurs throughout this study as a methodological clue: in the *Evil Dead* cycle, the manner in which the films are made is part of what they mean.

1.4 Method: Sources, Inheritances, Affinities

Three relations between the cycle and its intertexts must be distinguished, lest comparison collapse into the facile assertion of influence. The first is documented derivation: the *Necronomicon* borrowed from H. P. Lovecraft; the slapstick lineage of the Three Stooges; the stop-motion skeletons of Ray Harryhausen; the incantation "Klaatu barada nikto," lifted from Robert Wise's *The Day the Earth Stood Still* (1951); the time-displaced technologist of Mark Twain's *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* (1889); the Lilliputian multiplication of Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726); and the mock-hostile exchange of props with Wes Craven, which runs from a torn *Hills Have Eyes* poster in the first film's cellar, through a broadcast of *The Evil Dead* on a bedroom television in *A Nightmare on Elm Street* (1984), to Freddy Krueger's glove hanging in the sequel's tool shed. The second relation is generic inheritance: the siege of George A. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968), the possession of William Friedkin's *The Exorcist* (1973), the backwoods ordeal of Tobe Hooper's *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974). The third relation, in which the originality of this dissertation principally lies, is what Goethe named and Max Weber made a term of sociological art: *elective affinity* (*Wahlverwandtschaft*), a structural correspondence between formations that share no line of descent but answer to a common problem. When Ash mumbles the last word of an incantation in a fourteenth-century graveyard, he alludes to nothing in the legend of Titivillus, the medieval demon believed to gather every syllable of the liturgy slurred or dropped by careless clergy; yet the correspondence illuminates both terms. Comparison here aims not at genealogy but at the double vision Wendy Doniger ascribes to the comparatist, for whom the minute and the cosmic must be held within a single frame (Doniger 1998).

Four instruments are accordingly brought to bear. Close formal analysis attends to framing, movement, sound, editing, and effects as the cycle's primary means of argument. Philosophical reconstruction extracts from the films' immanent logic — not from authorial intention, which the cycle's makers have consistently deflected toward the vocabulary of craft and fun — the propositions that this logic presupposes. Media archaeology, after Friedrich Kittler and Jeffrey Sconce, reads the cycle's recording technologies as historically specific apparatuses of communication with the dead (Kittler 1999 [1986]; Sconce 2000). Comparative mythology, disciplined by Assyriological scholarship on Mesopotamian demonology and ritual (Geller 2007; Scurlock

2006; Abusch 2015), tests the franchise's pseudo-Sumerian mythography against the ancient Near Eastern materials toward which it gestures without ever consulting them.

I.5 The Argument in Brief

The central thesis admits of statement in a single sentence: *the* Evil Dead *cycle elaborates a metaphysics of automatism — Kandarian Automatism — in which word, gaze, body, and self are each revealed as mechanisms operating in the absence of a subject, and it answers this revelation not with theodicy or despair but with a comic-ecstatic affirmation of recurrence, the Groovy Sublime, enacted as a liturgy of dismemberment.* The four orders of automatism, their franchise figures, and their principal genealogies may be tabulated as follows.

ORDER	FRANCHISE FIGURE	PHILOSOPHICAL LINEAGE	MYTHIC AND LITERARY ANTECEDENTS	COMIC INVERSION
Automatic word	The Book and its recordings	Plato's *pharmakon*; Austin; Derrida; Kittler	*Utukkū Lemnūtu*; *Maqlû*; Lovecraft's *Necronomicon*; M. R. James	The flubbed incantation
Automatic eye	The unseen Force	Otto; Vertov; Deleuze; Metz; Fisher	Dante's *selva oscura*; Blackwood; Machen; Frazer's Nemi	The camera as stooge
Automatic body	The Deadite	Descartes; Spinoza; Kleist; Freud; Lacan	The *eṭemmu*; Ishtar's threat; the danse macabre	The dancing corpse
Augmented body	Ash Williams and his heirs	Freud's prosthetic God; McLuhan; Stiegler; Canetti	Frazer's King of the Wood; the Sumerian King List; Twain's Yankee	"Groovy"

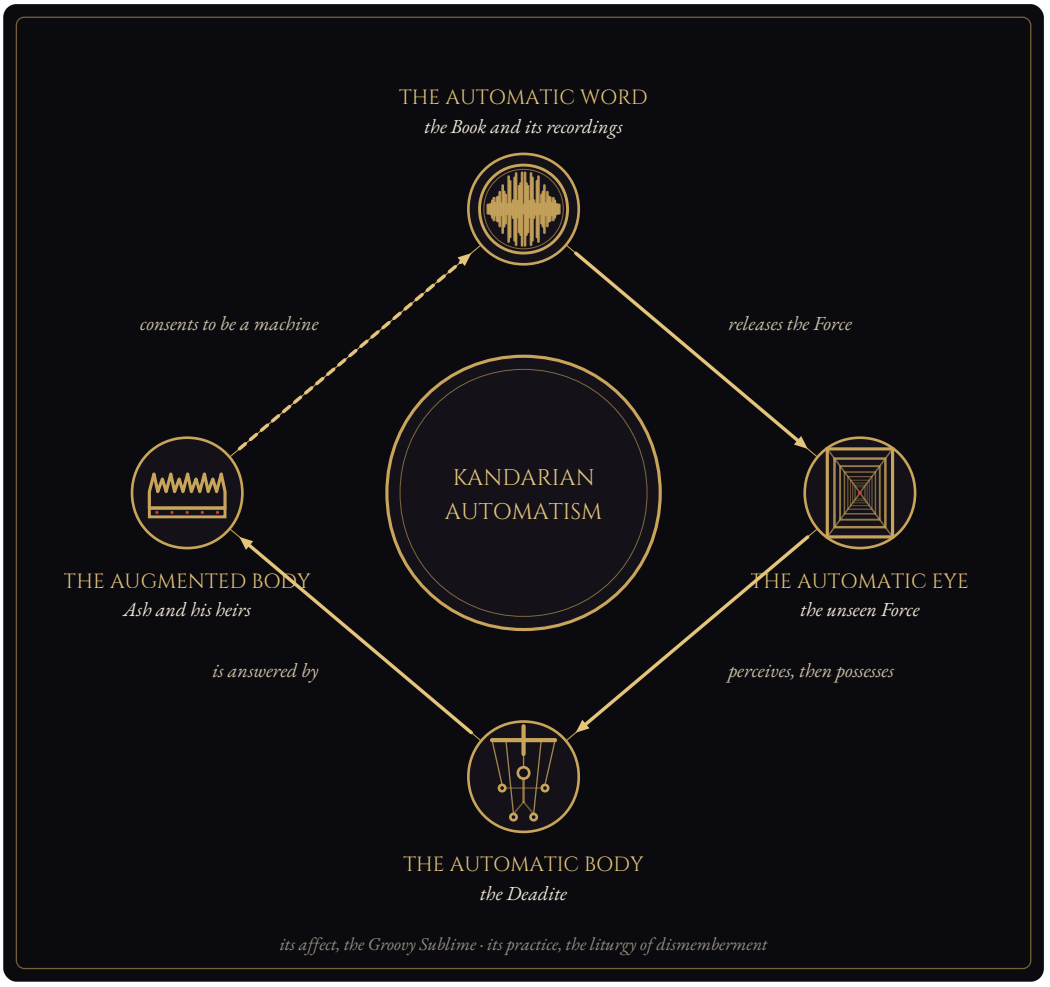


FIGURE 1 *The Kandarian tetrad: four orders of automatism as phases of a single dialectic (Introduction, §I.5).*

The four orders are phases of a single dialectic. The automatic word releases the force; the automatic eye is its mode of perception; the automatic body is its mode of incarnation; and the augmented body is the human answer — not a restoration of the subject the force has evacuated, but its replacement by a prosthetic, technical, and comic sovereignty that consents to be a machine among machines. The Groovy Sublime names the affect of that consent; the liturgy of dismemberment names its practice.

I.6 Chapter Map

Chapter One reconstructs the corpus and its provenance, identifying the originators of the ideas upon which the cycle draws and the production practices through which those ideas were transformed. Chapter Two analyses the Book and its recordings as the cycle's theory of language: writ-

ing as testament, the performative as machine, the incantation as a speech act whose felicity requires no intention. Chapter Three examines the Force and the hostile wood, arguing that the cycle's demon is finally indistinguishable from its camera. Chapter Four theorises the Deadite as a body suspended between two deaths and as the return of the improperly mourned. Chapter Five reads Ash Williams as a prosthetic sovereign whose kingship parodies, with unexpected precision, the Sumerian descent of kingship from heaven. Chapter Six treats remake and recurrence as the franchise's formal metaphysics, reading the cabin through Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Freud, Heidegger, and Bachelard. Chapter Seven follows the matrilineal turn, in which addiction, maternity, and marriage recast the meaning of survival. Chapter Eight assembles these findings into a necrocomic metaphysics and defines the Groovy Sublime against the traditions of the sublime, the carnivalesque, and philosophical pessimism. The Conclusion weighs the implications of the argument for horror studies, the philosophy of film, and comparative religion.

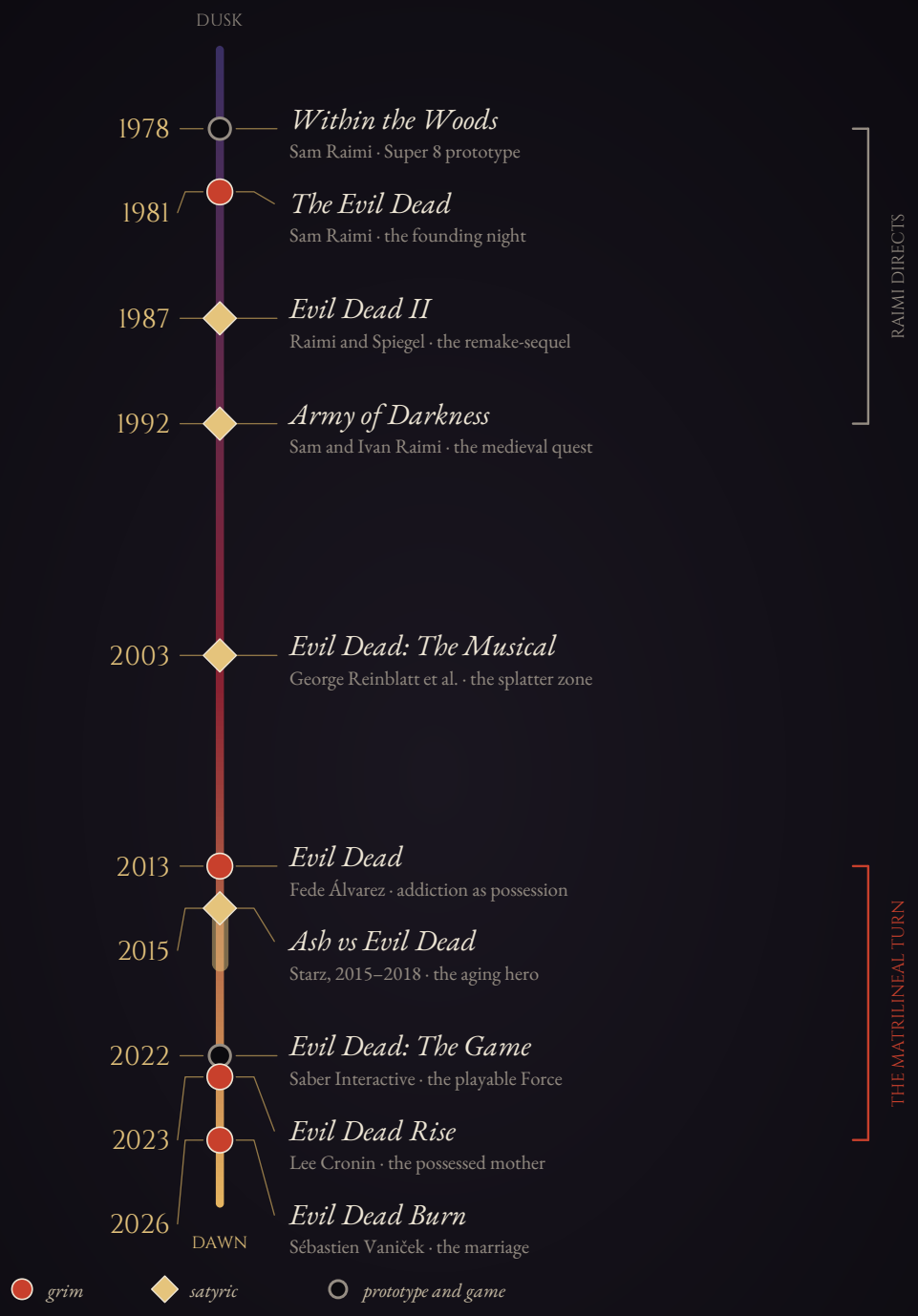
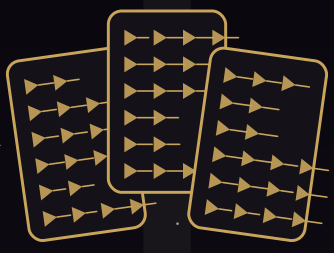


FIGURE 2 *The corpus, 1978–2026. Grim and satyric entries alternate, as Chapter Eight argues; the matrilineal turn begins in 2013.*



CHAPTER ONE

Archive of the Dead

Corpus, Provenance, and the Genealogy of a Mythos

The *Evil Dead* mythos was conceived as a funerary text and has persisted as a funerary institution. Its founding object was modelled on a book for conducting the dead out of the world; its narrative engine is the catastrophic misuse of that book to call them back; and its history as a franchise is a succession of officiants — Raimi, Álvarez, Cronin, Vaniček — each of whom reperforms the same nocturnal rite for a new congregation. This chapter reconstructs the corpus, traces the provenance of its central object, identifies the originators of the ideas on which it draws, and proposes a morphology of the rite that every entry re-enacts.

1.1 The Corpus

The primary corpus, with its prototype and principal paratexts, is listed below in order of release, since the argument traces a development.

Year	Title	Principal creative credit	Form	Position in the mythos
1978	*Within the Woods*	Sam Raimi	Super 8 short	Prototype: a desecrated burial ground; Campbell as the possessed, a woman left standing, her fate left open
1981	*The Evil Dead*	Sam Raimi	Feature	The founding night: five students, the *Naturom Demonto*, the tape, the dawn
1987	*Evil Dead II*	Sam Raimi (co-written with Scott Spiegel)	Feature	Remake-sequel: the rebel hand, the laughing room, the vortex to 1300
1992	*Army of Darkness*	Sam Raimi (co-written with Ivan Raimi)	Feature	Medieval quest, the flubbed incantation, two incompatible endings
2003	*Evil Dead: The Musical*	George Reinblatt et al.	Stage	Parodic recapitulation; the blood-drenched "splatter zone"
2013	*Evil Dead*	Fede Álvarez (co-written with Rodo Sayagues)	Feature	Addiction as possession; rites of purification; the Abomination
2015–2018	*Ash vs Evil Dead*	Developed by Sam Raimi, Ivan Raimi, Tom Spezialy	Television, three seasons	The aging hero; the Book's claimed author; the hometown; apocalypse
2022	*Evil Dead: The Game*	Saber Interactive	Video game	The demon as a playable position; the respawning survivor
2023	*Evil Dead Rise*	Lee Cronin	Feature	The condemned high-rise; vinyl recordings; the possessed mother
2026	*Evil Dead Burn*	Sébastien Vaniček (co-written with Florent Bernard)	Feature	Marriage, in-laws, the crematorium; reel-to-reel recordings; the Kandarian dagger

Around this primary series lies a penumbra of works in which the cycle's figures migrate: Raimi's *Crimewave* (1985), co-written with Joel and Ethan Coen (Joel having served as an assistant editor on *The Evil Dead*); the hospital massacre in *Spider-Man 2* (2004), shot in the first film's idiom of rushing point-of-view and chainsaw; *Drag Me to Hell* (2009), a reworking of M. R. James's "Casting the Runes" (1911) in the cycle's comic-grotesque register; and *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness* (2022), whose grimoire of corruption and reanimated sorcerer import the

cycle's mythology into a corporate cinematic universe. Comics from Dark Horse and Dynamite, licensed games from 2000 onward, and the incorporation of Ash's catchphrases into the vocabulary of the first-person shooter complete a transmedial ecology in Henry Jenkins's sense, in which no single text contains the mythos and each is a portal into it (Jenkins 2006).

1.2 Provenance: The Book Before the Book

The mythos begins in a classroom. Accounts of the production locate the genesis of the Book in Raimi's study of the Egyptian *Book of the Dead* in an ancient-history course at Michigan State University; the screenplay, originally entitled *Book of the Dead*, was written as a credited independent-study project, and *Within the Woods* was shot as a proof of concept for investors (Eisenberg 2023). In the finished film, however, the Egyptian frame has given way to a Mesopotamian one. Professor Knowby's recorded voice describes the volume as a compendium of ancient Sumerian burial practices and funerary incantations, whose title, *Naturom Demonto*, he glosses as "Book of the Dead."

This migration from Egypt to Sumer is more consequential than its casualness suggests. The Egyptian corpus to which the title alludes — the *pr.t m hrw*, "Coming Forth by Day" — is a compilation of spells that equip the deceased to traverse the Duat, pass the judgment of the weighing of the heart, and achieve transfigured existence in the beyond. It is a technology of *departure*: a set of instructions that sees the dead safely out of the world of the living. The Book of the *Evil Dead* inverts that function precisely. It remains, by its own account, a manual of burial — of funerary practice and incantation — but in the hands of the living it becomes a technology of *return*. The conceptual kernel of the mythos is therefore not "forbidden knowledge" in the Faustian sense but *misapplied funerary technique*: a rite designed to manage the boundary between the living and the dead, performed wrongly, by the wrong people, in the wrong place. Chapter Four will argue that this kernel governs the entire demonology of the cycle, whose Deadites are, in structural terms, the improperly buried.

The Egyptian association carried a further, specifically American resonance. By the 1970s, "Book of the Dead" designated not only the Egyptian funerary corpus but the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol*, rendered into English by W. Y. Evans-Wentz in 1927 and repurposed in 1964 by Timothy Leary, Ralph Metzner, and Richard Alpert as *The Psychedelic Experience*, a manual for the dissolution of ego under hallucinogens. The "Book of the Dead" thus arrived in the counterculture already freighted with the promise of a self dissolved and a consciousness invaded. *Ash vs Evil Dead* makes the association literal: its catastrophe begins when Ash, high on marijuana, reads from the Book to impress a woman he is trying to seduce — the Book of the Dead consulted, once more, as a recreational manual of altered states.

The name *Necronomicon*, by contrast, is Lovecraft's. It first appears in "The Hound" (1924), and its pseudo-history was codified in a short text written in 1927 and published posthumously in 1938, which attributes the book to the "mad Arab" Abdul Alhazred and gives its original title

as *Al Azif* — glossed by Lovecraft as the nocturnal sound of insects that was taken for the howling of demons (Lovecraft 1938). In a letter of late February 1937 to a young correspondent, Harry O. Fischer, written weeks before his death, Lovecraft said the name had come to him in a dream and offered an etymology — *nekros*, corpse; *nomos*, law; *eikon*, image — yielding "an image of the law of the dead" (Lovecraft 2017). Classicists have long noted the derivation's irregularity, but its content is precisely to the point: the *Necronomicon* is the *law* of the dead made visible, a juridical text binding the living. Lovecraft's most famous couplet, attributed to Alhazred in "The Nameless City" (1921), supplies the whole cycle with its epigraph: *That is not dead which can eternal lie, / And with strange aeons even death may die.*

Lovecraft's book has a peculiar ontological status: it exists only as citation. Lovecraft never wrote it; he wrote around it, quoting fragments, describing editions, tracing provenance, until the citational aura generated by his stories, and those of Clark Ashton Smith, Robert E. Howard, and August Derleth, acquired the density of an artifact. In the late 1970s that aura condensed into objects. The so-called Simon *Necronomicon* (1977) presented itself as a translation of a Mesopotamian grimoire, populated by Tiamat, Marduk, and Ereshkigal; a rival volume, *The Necronomicon: The Book of Dead Names* (1978), edited by George Hay, followed within a year. Without asserting a line of influence, one may observe that *Within the Woods* and *The Evil Dead* were conceived precisely in the years in which Lovecraft's phantom book was being *Sumerianized* in popular occultism. The cycle's relocation of its Book from Egypt to Sumer belongs to that moment.

The Book's titles, finally, are themselves corrupt. *Naturom Demonto* is not Latin; *Necronomicon Ex-Mortis*, the designation adopted in *Evil Dead II* and *Army of Darkness*, joins a Greek coinage to a solecism, the preposition *ex* governing a genitive where Latin requires the ablative *ex morte*. The Book of the Dead announces itself through a grammatical error. Chapter Two will take this error seriously, as the first instance of the cycle's insistence that its magic operates through the corruption, mispronunciation, and mechanical misfire of language.

1.3 Originators: A Genealogy of Ideas

The cycle's documented intellectual and artistic sources fall into six lineages, each transformed in transmission.

The first is **Lovecraft's cosmic horror**, which supplies the forbidden book, the pre-human entities (the "Dark Ones" to whom *Evil Dead II* attributes authorship of the Book), and the scholar destroyed by his discovery. Yet Raimi's cosmos departs from Lovecraft's at its foundation. Lovecraft's entities are indifferent to humanity; their horror lies in a scale of being for which the human does not register. Raimi's demons are the opposite of indifferent. They are intimate, attentive, theatrical, and sadistic; they mimic the voices of the beloved, sing nursery rhymes, mock, bargain, and laugh. Where Lovecraft offers what Eugene Thacker calls the *world-without-us*, the cycle offers a world *against* us, in which the cosmos takes a personal and malicious interest in

each human being it encounters (Thacker 2011). The Lovecraftian sublime of scale is replaced by a sublime of intimacy.

The second lineage is **American slapstick**, above all the Three Stooges, whose economy of pain without consequence — the eye-poke, the face-slap, the hammer to the skull — furnishes the cycle's grammar of violence, and whose production history furnished its term for the substitutable body, the "Fake Shemp" (Campbell 2001). To this one must add the animated cartoon, whose indestructible bodies, elastic limbs, and physics-defying impacts license the cycle's treatment of flesh as infinitely deformable.

The third lineage is **mid-century fantasy cinema**: Ray Harryhausen's stop-motion skeletons in *The 7th Voyage of Sinbad* (1958) and *Jason and the Argonauts* (1963), which *Army of Darkness* multiplies into an army; and the science-fiction of the Cold War, from which the cycle borrows its single most famous incantation. In Robert Wise's *The Day the Earth Stood Still*, "Klaatu barada nikto" is a command that halts a machine's destruction of humanity; in *Army of Darkness* it becomes the password that must be spoken to retrieve the Book safely. A phrase invented for a robot thus becomes the cycle's paradigm of magical speech — a conversion of code into spell that anticipates the argument of the next chapter.

The fourth lineage is **the literature of the displaced modern**: Twain's *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court*, in which a nineteenth-century machinist conquers Camelot with technical knowledge and ends among the corpses his technology has produced; Swift's *Gulliver's Travels*, whose Lilliputians are reborn as the miniature Ashes that torment their original; and, behind both, the Arthurian matter of Malory, whose sleeping king and questing knights *Army of Darkness* reduces to a squabble over a book.

The fifth lineage is **the American independent horror of the 1970s**: Romero's siege, Friedkin's possession, Hooper's chainsaw, Craven's backwoods. The cycle's relation to these films is at once filial and agonistic, as the exchange of posters and props with Craven attests. Its formal innovation was to remove the human antagonist altogether — no cannibal family, no masked killer — and to give the violence no author but the Force and the survivor.

European horror of the same moment offers the closest contemporary analogue. Lucio Fulci's *The Beyond* (*L'aldilà*), released in 1981, also turns on a book: its Louisiana hotel stands over one of the seven gates of hell, whose lore is recorded in the Book of Eibon, a volume borrowed from Clark Ashton Smith's contributions to the Lovecraftian mythos. Its dead rise, and its survivors end, blinded, on an endless grey plain strewn with corpses. The two films of 1981 divide the possibilities of the occult book between them. Fulci's book opens a landscape, in the oneiric idiom of Italian horror; Raimi's opens a body, in the kinetic idiom of American slapstick.

The sixth lineage is **the patronage of Stephen King**, who saw the film at Cannes in 1982 and pronounced it, in *Twilight Zone Magazine*, "the most ferociously original horror film of 1982" (Eisenberg 2023), and who, on learning that the sequel could not find backers, persuaded his own producer, Dino De Laurentiis, to finance it. King's own *Danse Macabre*, published in 1981, the year of the film's completion, offers a near-contemporary theory of what the film was

doing: King's hierarchy of terror, horror, and revulsion, in which the writer descends from the first to the third when the higher registers fail, is precisely the hierarchy that *The Evil Dead* collapses, delivering all three registers simultaneously and without preference (King 1981).

One further genealogy is not a source but a suppression. *Within the Woods* located the origin of its evil in a desecrated Native American burial ground — a trope through which, as Renée Bergland has shown, American literature has long figured the haunting of the nation by the peoples it dispossessed (Bergland 2000). The feature removed this origin and replaced it with an imagined Mesopotamian ruin, the "Kandarian" site from which Knowby recovers the Book. The substitution displaces the national uncanny onto an Orient that, as Edward Said argued, the Western imagination has long constituted as the repository of ancient and irrational powers (Said 1978). *The Exorcist* had performed the same displacement eight years earlier, opening at an excavation in northern Iraq. The cycle's demons are, in this sense, refugees from an American guilt reassigned to a Near Eastern antiquity. The present study's recourse to genuine Mesopotamian materials is intended partly as a corrective to that displacement: to read the franchise's pseudo-Sumerian mythology against the actual demonology and ritual practice it borrows without acknowledgment.

The prototype also contains two of the cycle's later signatures in embryo. Bruce, possessed after taking a dagger from a grave, is finally stopped when Ellen seizes his own mutilated hand, still clutching that dagger, and stabs him with it: before the hand rebelled against Ash in 1987, it was turned against its owner in 1978. And the short refuses its survivor safety. As Ellen recovers, Scotty's corpse rises behind her and the image cuts to black — the ending the feature would give Ash three years later, when the Force rushes upon him at dawn.

1.4 The Economy of the Ordeal

The production of *The Evil Dead* has acquired the status of legend, and the legend is philosophically relevant. The producers sought a budget of $150,000 by offering two percent stakes for $10,000 investments and raised an initial $85,000 from a miscellany of sources (the final cost, as the shoot overran, is variously given as $350,000 to $375,000), among them a man Raimi met at a K-Mart while having film developed (Eisenberg 2023). A shoot planned for six weeks in the Tennessee woods extended to twelve; the cabin had to be cleared of manure before filming; the white contact lenses worn by the possessed caused acute pain; tools were stolen; exhaustion was such that crew members fell asleep at the camera. The ordeal of the characters was reproduced, in attenuated but real form, upon the bodies of the cast and crew, and Campbell's memoir records a director whose relation to his star was one of cheerful and inventive cruelty (Campbell 2001).

Three observations follow. First, the production was an initiatory ordeal in Arnold van Gennep's sense — a separation from ordinary life, a liminal period of suffering in an isolated place, and an aggregation into a new status, here that of professional filmmakers (van Gennep 1960 [1909]). The rite that the film depicts was the rite through which its makers passed. Second, the

store at which an investor was found returns, transfigured, as "S-Mart," the big-box retailer in whose housewares department Ash works and to which *Army of Darkness*'s theatrical ending restores him. The commodity form that underwrote the demon's first appearance becomes the frame within which the hero is finally enclosed. Third, the director's assault on his actor — the camera that pursues, strikes, and drenches Campbell — is formally continuous with the Force's assault on Ash. Chapter Three will argue that the cycle's demon and its camera are one; the production history suggests that its demon and its director are, at least figuratively, one as well.

The film's distribution constituted a second ordeal. The veteran sales agent Irvin Shapiro changed its title to *The Evil Dead* and placed it with Palace Pictures in Britain, which released it theatrically and on video simultaneously; New Line Cinema distributed it in the United States in 1983 (Eisenberg 2023). In Britain it became one of the paradigmatic "video nasties," subjected to prosecution under the Obscene Publications Act; Raimi travelled to testify on its behalf, the court declined his testimony, and the charges were eventually dismissed. The moral panic, analysed by Martin Barker in its own moment and by Kate Egan in retrospect, constructed the videocassette as what Stanley Cohen had called a folk devil: a foreign body that entered the home and possessed the young (Cohen 1972; Barker 1984; Egan 2007). The film was thus treated by the British state exactly as the Deadite is treated by the survivor — as a contaminated body to be sequestered, cut, and if possible destroyed. Its subsequent canonisation, its uncut release, and its reception as a classic complete the pattern of the rite: the demonised object, having survived the night, is readmitted at dawn.

The agents of that panic can be named. Mary Whitehouse, whose National Viewers' and Listeners' Association led the campaign against the cassettes, declared *The Evil Dead* "the number one video nasty," and the film's video release was banned not only in the United Kingdom but in Ireland, Iceland, Sweden, and Finland (Sims 2021). The criticism of the film that has proved most durable, however, came not from the campaigners but, as Chapter Three records, from its own director, who conceded that its rape scene had been a misjudgement.

Evil Dead II was financed by Dino De Laurentiis — at King's urging, for about $3.6 million, and on condition that it resemble its predecessor rather than Raimi's pitch for a medieval time-travel sequel, which was deferred to *Army of Darkness* — and, because De Laurentiis's own company was bound to the ratings system, it was released unrated in March 1987 through Rosebud Releasing, a one-off distributor created for the purpose (Warren 2000; Campbell 2001); *Army of Darkness* was made for Universal amid disputes over its tone and its ending, the studio's preferred conclusion in S-Mart displacing Raimi's apocalyptic coda. Each entry thus bears the marks of the institution that financed it, and each ending is a negotiation between the mythos and its patrons.

1.5 After Raimi: The Mythos as Institution

From 2013 the cycle passed to new officiants, Raimi, Robert Tapert, and Campbell remaining as producers through Ghost House Pictures — a company whose name is itself an emblem of the franchise's institutional afterlife. The successive directors form a geographical and generic itinerary: the Uruguayan Fede Álvarez, whose viral short *Ataque de Pánico!* (2009) brought him to Hollywood's attention; the Irish Lee Cronin, whose *The Hole in the Ground* (2019) had already explored the replacement of a child by an uncanny double; and the French Sébastien Vaniček, whose *Infested* (*Vermines*, 2023) placed him in the lineage of what James Quandt named the New French Extremity (Quandt 2004). The mythos has become a portable rite, transmitted from its American hierophant to officiants across three continents, each obliged to reperform its fixed sequence while inflecting it with a national and generic accent.

Evil Dead Burn (2026), released in the United States on 10 July 2026, carries the rite into the institution of marriage. Its protagonist, Alice, is a Frenchwoman in an unhappy and, as flashbacks reveal, abusive marriage to William Price, a volatile chef; William's younger brother Joseph plays the reel-to-reel recordings of his grandfather, Professor Benjamin Price, on battling demonic forces and recovers the Kandarian dagger described in an accompanying volume. A Deadite surviving from *Evil Dead Rise* emerges from a lake in response; William, fleeing a quarrel while drunk, collides with her, and the possession passes to him in the burning wreck. He rises from his coffin at the crematorium, and the surviving family — a matriarch, her embittered husband, and a grandmother with dementia and a wooden prosthetic foot — returns to a decaying mansion where its members fall, one by one, to the dead husband and the demons that ride him (Li 2026). Early criticism divided over the film's unrelenting brutality and its comedy: one reviewer found it lacking the goofiness of the Raimi films (Li 2026), while a survey of the wider reception reported critics who saw brutal slapstick and comic interludes built around the grandmother (Chan 2026). Chapter Seven will read *Burn* as the culmination of the matrilineal turn: a film in which the vow "till death us do part" is shown to persist beyond death as a form of possession, and in which a wife must dismember the marriage that has outlived her husband.

1.6 A Morphology of the Kandarian Rite

Vladimir Propp demonstrated that the Russian wonder tale, beneath its variety of personnel and setting, executes a fixed sequence of functions (Propp 1968 [1928]). The *Evil Dead* cycle submits to the same analysis. Every entry, comic or grim, Raimi's or another's, performs some subset of twelve functions in an invariant order.

1. **Isolation.** A dwelling severed from the social order: cabin, castle, condemned tower, decaying mansion.
2. **Discovery.** The Book is found together with a recorded commentary by a dead or absent scholar.

3. **Interdiction.** A warning, inscribed, recorded, or implied, that is necessarily ignored.
4. **Voicing.** The incantation is actualised by a living voice or by mechanical playback.
5. **Awakening.** The Force makes its first rush across the threshold of the dwelling.
6. **First possession.** A beloved — sister, lover, mother, husband — is taken.
7. **Taunt.** The possessed speaks in the voice of the Other: mocking, chanting, inviting the living to join it.
8. **Misreading and sequestration.** The possessed is mistaken for the ill, the hysterical, or the addicted, and confined below or behind a door.
9. **Serial possession.** The group is taken "one by one."
10. **Dismemberment.** The survivor must destroy the body of the beloved.
11. **Mutilation and arming.** The survivor loses a part of the body and gains a weapon or prosthesis.
12. **Counter-rite and dawn.** The Book is burned or closed, the body purified, the incantation reversed; daylight arrives and resolves nothing.

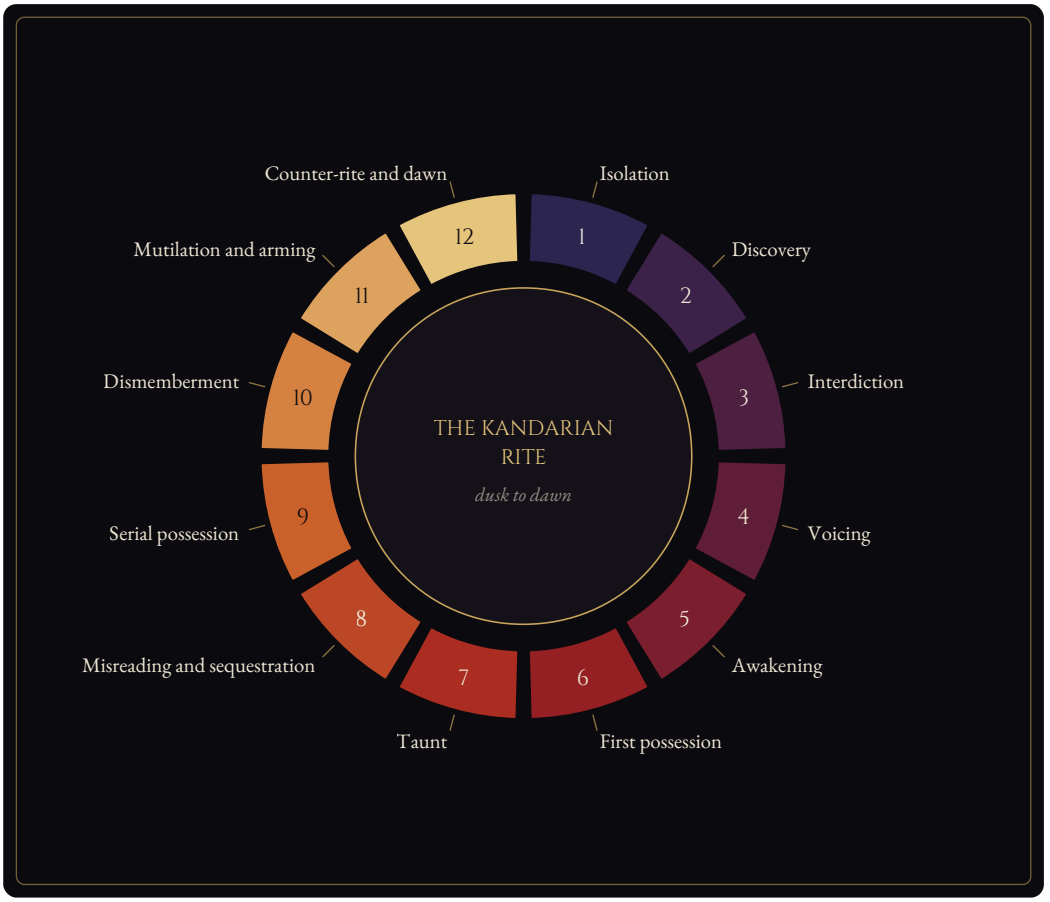


FIGURE 3 *A morphology of the Kandarian rite: twelve functions, from isolation at dusk to the counter-rite at dawn (§1.6).*

The comic entries do not abandon this morphology; they invert its functions in place. In *Evil Dead II* the taunt becomes the laughing room; in *Army of Darkness* the voicing becomes the flub; in *Ash vs Evil Dead* the interdiction is ignored not out of curiosity but out of vanity and intoxication. The morphology is the rite's liturgy, and its persistence across nearly five decades is the first and most basic evidence for this dissertation's claim that the franchise is best understood as a ritual institution rather than a sequence of narratives. The chapters that follow examine the rite's elements in the order in which it deploys them: the word that voices it, the eye that perceives it, the body that incarnates it, and the survivor who outlasts it.



1981	 REEL-TO-REEL	A student plays the dead professor's tape as a diversion.
1987	 REEL-TO-REEL	Ash replays the tape out of idle curiosity.
2013	 THE BOOK, ALOUD	A schoolteacher reads aloud because he wants to understand what he has found.
2015	 THE BOOK, ALOUD	Ash reads from it while high, to impress a woman he is trying to seduce.
2023	 GRAMOPHONE · CUT 1923	A teenage would-be disc jockey plays a cache of old records.
2026	 REEL-TO-REEL	A struggling writer plays his grandfather's reels.

None of the speakers knows the procedure, holds the office, intends the act, or understands the words. Every utterance works.

FIGURE 4 *Six voicings of the Book. No speaker understands what is said; in every case the words work (§2.2).*



CHAPTER TWO

The Automatic Word

Necronomicon, Recording, and the Infelicitous Performative

Kandarian Automatism begins in language. In the *Evil Dead* cycle the incantation works irrespective of the speaker's understanding, intention, sincerity, or even presence; it works when read by the bored, the curious, the intoxicated, and the dead; it works when played back from magnetic tape and vinyl; and it works, most scandalously, when it is botched. The cycle thereby stages, with a literalism no philosopher could permit himself, the thesis that the efficacy of the sign is independent of the living subject who utters it — the thesis that Jacques Derrida identified as the essence of writing. This chapter reads the Book and its recordings as the cycle's philosophy of language, and argues that this philosophy is best described as *pan-performativity*: a world in which no utterance is inert, no citation safe, and no failure merely a failure.

2.1 Bound in Flesh, Inked in Blood

The Book is first of all a body. The founding film's recorded commentary specifies that it is bound in human flesh and inked in human blood, and Tom Sullivan's original prop gave its cover a distended, screaming face. The specification has a historical referent in anthropodermic bibliopegy, the binding of books in human skin practised chiefly by nineteenth-century physicians upon the remains of patients, a practice whose surviving artefacts have been catalogued and tested in recent decades (Rosenbloom 2020). In the cycle, however, the human binding is not a macabre curiosity but an ontological claim. *Army of Darkness* presents three candidate Books in a ruined graveyard, two of them traps — one bites, one swallows — and the authentic codex shrieks when seized. The 2013 Book arrives wrapped in barbed wire and plastic sheeting, its margins crowded with handwritten injunctions not to read, write, speak, or hear its words: a palimpsest of prior users' terror, like the scholia accumulated by a sacred text. The Book is not a representation of the dead; it is a dead thing that remains active, the first Deadite of the cycle and the template for all the others.

This convergence of law, text, and flesh has two distinguished antecedents. In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887), Nietzsche argued that human memory was manufactured through pain — that only what never ceases to hurt remains in memory — and that the history of punishment is the history of a mnemotechnics in which obligations were burned into the body. Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) gave that thesis its most terrible image: an apparatus that inscribes the commandment the condemned man has violated directly into his skin, so that he comes to know his sentence only by deciphering it with his wounds. Lovecraft's etymology, "an image of the law of the dead," completes the triangle. The Book of the *Evil Dead* is a law of the dead written upon the skin of the dead, and its incantations are commandments that inscribe themselves, in turn, upon the bodies of those who voice them. The Deadite's lacerated, discoloured, and contorted flesh — the cracked skin, the white eyes, the wounds that speak — is the Book's text transcribed onto a new surface. Possession is a form of publication.

2.2 The Incantation as Machine: Austin, Derrida, and the Felicity of Accident

J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished constative utterances, which describe states of affairs and may be true or false, from performatives, which accomplish what they name — to promise, to bequeath, to christen — and may be happy or unhappy, felicitous or infelicitous. Felicity, for Austin, requires an accepted conventional procedure, appropriate persons and circumstances, correct and complete execution, and, in many cases, the requisite thoughts and intentions. Austin also excluded from his analysis, as "parasitic" or "etiolated," utterances made on the stage, in a poem, or in soliloquy: language used not seriously but in quotation (Austin 1962).

The *Evil Dead* cycle is a sustained counterexample to that exclusion. Every voicing of the incantation in the corpus is "non-serious" in Austin's sense. In 1981 a student plays the professor's tape as a diversion; in 1987 Ash replays it out of idle curiosity; in 2013 a schoolteacher reads aloud from the Book because he wants to understand what he has found; in 2015 Ash reads from it while high, to impress a woman he is trying to seduce; in 2023 a teenage aspiring disc jockey plays a cache of old records on his turntable; in 2026 a struggling writer plays his grandfather's reels. None of these speakers knows the procedure, occupies the office, intends the act, or understands the words. Yet each utterance is perfectly efficacious. The parasitic utterance is fully performative.

Derrida's critique of Austin in "Signature Event Context" (1972) generalised precisely this point. A sign, Derrida argued, can function only if it is *iterable* — repeatable in the absence of its sender and of its intended receiver, citable, graftable into new contexts. Iterability is not an accident that befalls certain utterances but the condition of possibility of all of them; the "non-serious" citation that Austin excluded is therefore not parasitic upon the serious performative but structurally constitutive of it. Every sign is, in Derrida's phrase, testamentary: it must be able to function after the death of the one who produced it (Derrida 1988 [1972]).

The professor's tape is that testament made literal. Knowby is dead when his recording is played; his voice, detached from his body and preserved on magnetic tape, performs the summoning without him and against his will. The Book itself, whose authors are the immemorial "Dark Ones," is the absolute limit of iterability: a text whose sender is not merely absent but unknowable, and whose receivers are anyone at all. Where Austin sought to ground the performative in the presence of an intending subject, the cycle grounds it in the mechanism of repetition. The incantation is a machine that runs on whatever voice is fed into it.

Ash vs Evil Dead tests this claim against its strongest counterexample. The series introduces Ruby Knowby, who claims to have written the Book herself, restoring to the automatic word an author, an origin, and an intention. The series does not, however, let authorship alter how the Book works. Its catastrophe is set in motion not by Ruby but by Ash, reading while high, and the Book goes on acting upon whoever voices it, whatever its claimed author intends. Its second season makes the point bluntly: the demonic children Ruby bore have grown and turned on her,

hunting her for the Book. Authorship, in the cycle, is a claim about the past; efficacy is a property of the present utterance.

Austin's taxonomy of infelicity distinguished *misfires*, in which the act is purported but void because the procedure was misapplied or incompletely executed, from *abuses*, in which the act is achieved but insincerely. *Army of Darkness* contains the cycle's most celebrated linguistic event, and it is a misfire that does not misfire. Instructed to speak "Klaatu barada nikto" before lifting the Book from its resting place, Ash recalls the first two words, stalls on the third, coughs and mumbles a syllable that might be "necktie" or "nickel," and lifts the Book. In Austin's terms the execution is incomplete and the act should be void. In the cycle's terms there is no void act: the incomplete incantation performs a different act — it wakes the dead of the surrounding graveyard and inaugurates the Army of Darkness. The flub does not fail to do something; it does something else. Here lies the cycle's most radical linguistic proposition: *in the Kandarian universe there are no misfires, only misdirections.* Language is never inert. There is no position outside the operation of the sign — no metalanguage, in Lacan's dictum — from which one may safely mention an incantation without using it.

Freud had made the slip of the tongue the royal road to the unconscious, arguing in *The Psychopathology of Everyday Life* (1901) that parapraxes are not random failures but successful expressions of a suppressed intention. Ash's slip is diagnostically exact. Throughout *Army of Darkness* he treats the medieval world with impatience and contempt, desiring only to return to his own century; his garbling of the sacred words is the precise verbal form of that contempt, the refusal to take the ritual seriously that the ritual then takes seriously on his behalf.

The literary ancestor of the professor's tape is the antiquarian ghost story of M. R. James. In "Oh, Whistle, and I'll Come to You, My Lad" (1904), Parkins, a Cambridge professor, finds a bronze whistle in the ruins of a Templar preceptory, reads its Latin inscription — *Quis est iste qui venit*, "Who is this who is coming?" — and blows it, summoning a presence that pursues him. In "Canon Alberic's Scrap-Book" (1895), a scholar who buys an old album containing a drawing of a demon acquires the demon with it. James's scholars do not intend to summon anything. They read, translate, and sound out what they find out of professional curiosity, and the text does the rest. Knowby's recording is James's whistle in magnetic form: a found object whose inscription is enacted by sound, and whose finder is undone by his own competence (James 1904).

2.3 Titivillus, the Golem, and the Nam-shub

Three comparative figures illuminate the flub from different angles.

The first is **Titivillus**, the demon of medieval clerical lore who gathered into a sack every syllable of the Divine Office that was skipped, slurred, or mumbled by careless clergy, to be presented as evidence against them at the Last Judgment; attested from the late thirteenth century, he later became the patron demon of scribal error and a comic devil of the English morality play *Mankind* (c. 1470) and the Towneley *Judgment* (Jennings 1977). The setting of *Army of Dark-*

ness — the year 1300 — places Ash's mumble in exactly the era in which this demon of the dropped word first circulated. The legend presupposes an accountancy of speech: every omitted syllable is a debt recorded against the speaker. The Kandarian demon is Titivillus without the deferral of Judgment. It does not store the mumbled syllable for a final reckoning; it cashes it immediately, as an army.

The legend's chronology sharpens the parallel. The demon who gathers the clergy's dropped syllables into a sack appears in the 1220s in the sermons of Jacques de Vitry, and the name Titivillus first appears around 1285 in the *Tractatus de penitentia* of John of Wales (Jennings 1977). The medieval verse that summarises his labour — *Fragmina verborum Titivillus colligit horum*, "Titivillus collects the fragments of these words" — borrows its verb and noun from John 6:12, Christ's command after the feeding of the multitude to gather up the fragments that remain, so that nothing be lost (Vernet 1959). The demon of the dropped word is a collector of fragments. Chapter Six will find his heirs among the cycle's devotees.

The second is **the golem** of Jewish legend, animated by the combinatorial manipulation of Hebrew letters derived from the *Sefer Yetzirah*, and, in the most famous version, by the word *emet*, "truth," inscribed upon its forehead; erasing the initial aleph leaves *met*, "dead," and the creature returns to clay (Scholem 1965 [1960]). A single letter separates animation from death. The golem and the Deadite are twin products of a linguistic ontology in which letters act directly upon matter. In the golem tradition, however, the letter is wielded by a righteous adept within a theology that authorises it. In the *Evil Dead* cycle the letter is wielded by anyone, within a theology of no one.

The third is **Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash***, published in 1992, the year of *Army of Darkness*'s completion, whose conceit is that Sumerian functioned as a machine language for the human brainstem, and that the *nam-shub* of the god Enki — an incantation in the full Sumerian sense — was a neurolinguistic program capable of infecting and reprogramming those who heard it (Stephenson 1992). Stephenson's novel makes explicit what the cycle leaves implicit: that the incantation is executable code, that the human body is hardware, and that possession is the running of a program. The Kandarian incantation is a *nam-shub* in Stephenson's sense. Its output is not meaning but behaviour; its effect does not pass through comprehension at all. A neighbouring lineage — William S. Burroughs's figure of language as a virus, Bruce McDonald's *Pontypool* (2008), in which the English language becomes the vector of a contagion, and the cursed videotape of *Ringu* (1998), whose victim survives only by copying it — confirms that the late twentieth century repeatedly imagined language as a mechanism operating beneath, and against, the subject who speaks it.

2.4 Phonography as Necromancy

If the Book is writing in Derrida's generalised sense, the cycle's recording devices are writing in Friedrich Kittler's technical sense. *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) opens from the observa-

tion that the phonograph was, from its inception, imagined as a medium of the dead: Edison's own early prospectus for the invention listed, among its uses, the preservation of the voices and last words of the dying. Technical media, Kittler argued, extend the realm of the dead to the full capacity of a culture's storage and transmission; the voice preserved on wax or tape is a voice that survives its speaker and returns to the living on demand (Kittler 1999 [1986]). Jeffrey Sconce has traced the corresponding cultural imagination from the "spiritual telegraph" of nineteenth-century spiritualism, through the haunted radio and television, to the electronic presences of the late twentieth century (Sconce 2000).

The *Evil Dead* cycle stands at a precise point in this history. In 1959 the Swedish film producer Friedrich Jürgenson reported hearing the voices of the dead on his tape recordings, and the Latvian psychologist Konstantīns Raudive's *Breakthrough*, published in English in 1971, popularised "electronic voice phenomena" as a research programme in which magnetic tape served as the medium of communication with the departed. *The Evil Dead* inverts this programme exactly. Where the researchers of electronic voice phenomena sought to capture the voices of the dead on tape, Knowby's tape transmits the language of the dead to the living, and its playback is not a reception but a summons. The franchise's media sequence then rehearses the history of recorded sound backward and forward: reel-to-reel magnetic tape in 1981, 1987, and again in 2026; in 2023, the gramophone records of a priest cut a century earlier, in 1923, played by a boy who wishes to be a disc jockey; and, between them, the unmediated voice of reading in 2013 and 2015. In every case the recording device functions as what Michel Chion calls an *acousmêtre*: a voice whose source is not seen and which, precisely by its disembodiment, acquires powers of ubiquity, omniscience, and command (Chion 1999 [1982]). When *Evil Dead II* finally shows the professor, as an apparition urging his daughter to complete the counter-incantation, the deacousmatised Knowby is pitiable rather than powerful: once embodied, the voice loses its mastery, and the mechanism it set in motion runs on without him.

The first theorist of this necromancy was the phonograph's inventor. In "The Phonograph and Its Future" (1878), Edison listed among the machine's destined uses a "Family Record" of sayings and reminiscences in family members' own voices, "and of the last words of dying persons" (Edison 1878). Jonathan Sterne, in a chapter titled "A Resonant Tomb," places sound recording among the technologies of preservation that flourished after the American Civil War — canning, embalming, refrigeration — and argues that the voice preserved beyond death was a wish projected onto the machine rather than a property of it (Sterne 2003, 287–333). The cycle takes the wish literally and finds it a curse. *Evil Dead Rise* turns the franchise itself into such a record. Among the voices on its 1923 discs is an uncredited Bruce Campbell, shouting that the Book must be destroyed, and Lee Cronin has said in interviews that the voice may be a time-displaced Ash. The cycle's hero, whose story cannot end, survives as a recording older than himself: the founder of the rite preserved, like Knowby, as an *acousmêtre*.

The recorded voice thus dismantles what Derrida called phonocentrism, the Western privileging of speech as the medium of living presence (Derrida 1976 [1967]). The cycle's voices are

never present. They are stored, replayed, cited, sampled; they act precisely to the extent that they have become detached from any living throat. Mladen Dolar's analysis of the voice as an object irreducible to the subject who emits it — the uncanny remainder that circulates between bodies — finds its horror-film demonstration here (Dolar 2006). The Deadites themselves speak in this voice: a layered, pitch-shifted, mechanically uncanny utterance, the voice of the beloved replayed through a damaged device.

2.5 The Book as Pharmakon

In the *Phaedrus*, Socrates recounts the myth of Theuth, inventor of letters, who presents writing to King Thamus as a remedy for memory. Thamus replies that writing will rather produce forgetfulness, offering the semblance of wisdom without its substance; and Socrates adds that the written word, once set down, roams indiscriminately among those who understand it and those who do not, unable to choose its readers or to defend itself, forever needing its absent father's help (*Phaedrus* 274c–275e). Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) fastened upon Theuth's word for writing, *pharmakon*, which signifies at once remedy and poison, and showed that Plato's text cannot stabilise the distinction (Derrida 1981 [1968]).

The Book of the *Evil Dead* is the *pharmakon* realised. It is at once the cause of the catastrophe and the only means of ending it. In *Evil Dead II* its missing pages contain the incantation that dispels the evil and opens the rift through which it can be expelled; in *Army of Darkness* it is the object Ash must recover in order to return home; in the 2013 film it supplies the rites of purification by which a possessed body may be cleansed; in *Evil Dead Burn* its companion volume describes the Kandarian dagger with which the dead can be destroyed. The poison and the antidote are bound in the same skin. And the Book is the orphaned logos of the *Phaedrus* in its most extreme form: severed from its fathers, the Dark Ones, it speaks indifferently to anyone who opens or plays it and cannot defend itself against misuse.

Universal's *The Mummy* (1932) had already placed the reading aloud of an ancient text at the origin of a resurrection: an archaeologist's young assistant reads the Scroll of Thoth, and the mummified priest Imhotep rises. Stephen Sommers's remake (1999) divided the *pharmakon* into two volumes — a Book of the Dead that raises the mummy and a Book of Amun-Ra that can destroy him — dramatising as two objects the two faces that the *Evil Dead*'s single Book binds together. That the scroll which wakes Imhotep bears the name of Thoth, the scribe of the dead, anticipates the convergence traced in the next paragraph.

The myth has a further, unremarked convergence with the cycle's Egyptian origin. Theuth is Thoth, the ibis-headed god of writing, who in the Egyptian funerary corpus records the verdict when the heart of the deceased is weighed against the feather of Maat. Plato's myth of the invention of writing is thus a myth about the scribe of the dead. When Raimi's ancient-history course led him from the Egyptian *Book of the Dead* to the idea of a book that summons the dead, it re-

traced, unknowingly, the path by which Western philosophy's founding critique of writing had already linked letters to the judgment of the departed.

The burning of the Book at the end of *The Evil Dead* has its own genealogy. Marlowe's Faustus, in his final hour, cries out that he will burn his books, too late; Prospero renounces his art by promising to drown his book; and in the sixth chapter of the first part of *Don Quixote* the priest and the barber burn the knight's library of romances to cure the madness its reading has produced. In each case the destruction of the book ends an enchantment and restores the ordinary world. Ash succeeds where Faustus fails — he burns the Book in time — and his reward, like Quixote's, is not salvation but a disenchanted world that will not stay disenchanted: the Book is back on the table when the sequel begins.

A further lineage concerns books whose reading alters the world they describe. Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow* (1895) imagines a play whose second act drives its readers mad. Jorge Luis Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines an encyclopedia of an invented planet whose objects begin to appear in our own, and his "The Book of Sand" (1975) a book so dangerous that its owner can only lose it deliberately in a great library. John Carpenter's *In the Mouth of Madness* (1994) imagines a horror novelist whose books, read by enough people, rewrite reality. Clive Barker's *Hellraiser* (1987), released in the same year as *Evil Dead II*, replaced the book with a puzzle box whose solution summons its demons, but kept the essential structure: the operator need not understand what he operates. The *Necronomicon* belongs to this family with one decisive difference. These texts transform the world by being read, believed, or solved; the Book of the *Evil Dead* transforms the body by being voiced. Its efficacy requires neither a readership's faith nor a solver's skill, only a mouth or a loudspeaker.

2.6 Mesopotamian Counter-Texts: Authority and the "Not Mine" Formula

The cycle invokes Sumerian funerary incantation without consulting it. The actual corpus is instructive precisely in its divergence. The bilingual Sumerian-Akkadian series known as *Udug-hul* or *Utukkū Lemnūtu* — "Evil Demons" — comprises canonical incantations against the *utukku* and its congeners, including the *eṭemmu*, the ghost of the dead, which roam the steppe, slip into houses, and seize the bodies of the living (Geller 2007). Its incantations are apotropaic: they drive demons *out*. And their efficacy depends upon the exorcist's authority as the representative of the gods. A recurrent closing formula disclaims personal authorship altogether — the incantation is declared not the speaker's own but that of the gods Ea and Asalluhi — while a recurrent narrative frame has the young god report the patient's affliction to his divine father, who replies that whatever he himself knows, the son knows too.

The formulas are precise. One closing rubric declares the incantation "not mine but (rather) the spell of Ea and Asalluhi" (Geller 2016). The dialogue frame has Enki answer his son that there is nothing the son does not already know and nothing the father can add, since whatever he knows the son knows too, and sends him to recite the incantation of Eridu (Geller 2016). The

structure is extraordinarily durable. Graham Cunningham traced it to the Fara and Ebla incantations of the mid-third millennium, with Enlil and Ningirima in the roles later taken by Ea and Marduk (Cunningham 1997), and Geller follows it into the Hellenistic period. For some two thousand years, Mesopotamian exorcism defined the efficacious word as a citation whose authority lay elsewhere. The Kandarian incantation is the same citation with the elsewhere removed.

The Mesopotamian exorcist thus already understood the incantation as citation. He spoke words that were not his, iterated from a divine source. What grounded their efficacy was not his intention but the authority of the one he cited. The Kandarian incantation preserves the citational structure and removes the ground. It too is not the speaker's own; it too is iterated from a nonhuman source. But that source authorises nothing and protects no one, and the words function regardless of who speaks them. The passage from *Utukkū Lemnūtu* to the *Naturom Demonto* is thus the passage, in miniature, from sacred authority to mechanical efficacy — what Max Weber called the disenchantment of the world, inverted into a re-enchantment by machine. The modern incantation works not because a god stands behind it but because nothing does.

The second Mesopotamian counter-text supplies the cycle's temporal form. *Maqlû*, the Akkadian anti-witchcraft series whose title means "Burning," prescribes a ceremony in which figurines representing the witch are burned and her sorcery turned back upon her; in Tzvi Abusch's reconstruction it was performed in the course of a single night and the following morning, beginning with an appeal to the gods of the night and closing with rites of purification at daybreak (Abusch 2015). The *Evil Dead* chronotope — the single night that must be survived until dawn, "dead by dawn" in the phrase *Evil Dead II* made its subtitle — is the chronotope of *Maqlû*, reversed. In the ancient rite the night is the time in which the human community burns evil; in the cycle it is the time in which evil consumes the human community, until the survivor's counter-rite restores the ancient logic: the Book thrown into the fire at the end of *The Evil Dead*, the bodies purified by burning in 2013, the crematorium at which *Evil Dead Burn* opens its family's ordeal. That the franchise's most recent title should translate, word for word, the name of the Mesopotamian nocturnal ritual against sorcery is a convergence that no documented influence explains and that the logic of the mythos makes almost inevitable.

Abusch's reconstruction adds a detail that tightens the homology beyond anything the cycle's makers could have known. The ceremony was performed at the end of the month Abu, in July or August, when the spirits of the dead were thought to move back and forth between the netherworld and the world of the living. Its two night-time divisions burned and doused figurines of the witches and protected the patient's house; its dawn division washed the patient; and its incantations drove the witches out with the command to be gone and never return (Abusch 1974; Abusch 2015). The witch, moreover, was not to be buried: her image was given to the fire. *Maqlû* is thus a nocturnal rite, performed in the season when the dead walk, in which the evil is burned and refused a grave and the patient is cleansed at dawn. The echo in the franchise's latest title has been noticed in popular commentary on *Evil Dead Burn* (Chan 2026). The argument

here is that the convergence is not confined to a title: the cycle's whole chronotope is *Maqlû*'s, reversed.

2.7 Conclusion: Pan-Performativity

The automatic word is the first order of Kandarian Automatism. Its principle may be stated as follows: *every utterance acts; no utterance requires a subject; and the failure of an utterance is merely another utterance.* The horror of Knowby's tape and the comedy of Ash's flub are structurally identical: in each, speech persists and acts beyond and against intention. The difference lies only in the affective sign under which the identity is perceived — the threat of a voice that survives its speaker, the absurdity of a clerk whose mumble raises the dead. This is the first instance of the thesis that Chapter Eight will generalise: that horror and laughter in the cycle are two apprehensions of a single automatism. What the word releases is the Force. The next chapter turns to the mode in which that Force perceives.



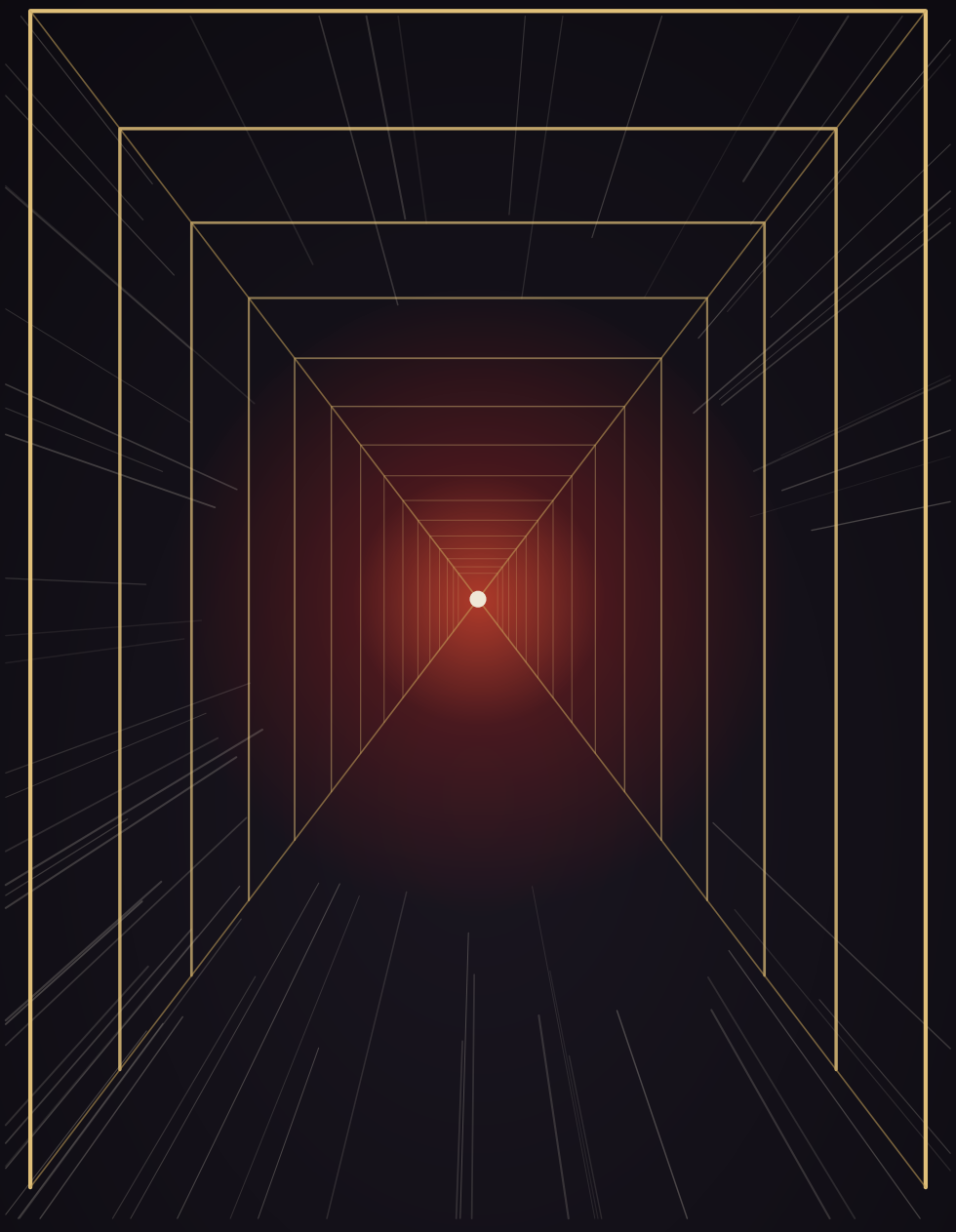
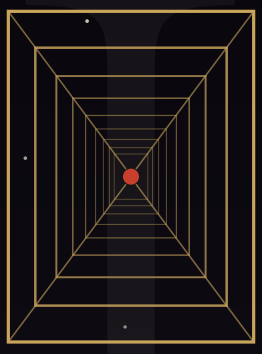


FIGURE 5 *The automatic eye: a velocity without a body, rushing through doorway after doorway toward the dwelling (§3.1).*



CHAPTER THREE

The Automatic Eye

The Unseen Force, the Hostile Wood, and the Daemonic Apparatus

The Force is never seen; it sees. Across the cycle it is rendered not as a figure but as a velocity — the camera skimming low over black water, threading between trunks, circling the cabin, smashing through windows and doors, accompanied by a roar that seems to issue from the landscape itself. This chapter argues that the Force is perception without a perceiver; that its rendering makes the cinematic apparatus itself the cycle's demon; that the spectator's primary identification with the camera becomes, in consequence, a complicity with possession; and that the forest through which the Force moves is the medium of an agency that Mark Fisher would call *eerie*. The automatic word releases a gaze that belongs to no one.

3.1 A Velocity Without a Body

The cycle's signature image was born of penury. Unable to afford the Steadicam, introduced only a few years earlier, Raimi's crew mounted the camera on lengths of timber carried at a run by two operators, and devised rigs by which it could be slid along greased boards or driven through glass; the production's own facetious nomenclature for these contraptions entered the lore of independent filmmaking (Campbell 2001). The contrast with the most prestigious horror film of the same moment is instructive. Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980) deployed the Steadicam to produce a gliding, frictionless, disembodied gaze that floats through the corridors of the Overlook Hotel — the ghost as aristocratic spectator, serene and inexorable. *The Evil Dead* (1981) produced its disembodied gaze with a plank: lurching, convulsive, low to the ground, colliding with what it pursues. Two near-contemporaneous films thus invented two technical idioms for the haunting gaze, and their difference is one of class. Kubrick's ghost glides; Raimi's demon *runs*.

The Force recurs in every entry and is the cycle's most reliable signature. It opens *The Evil Dead* skimming the surface of a fog-bound swamp toward the students' car; it closes the film by hurtling through the woods, the cabin's front door, and a sequence of interior doors toward Ash, who turns and screams as the image cuts to black. *Evil Dead II* lets it chase Ash through the cabin and, at last, into his body. The 2013 film unleashes it across the forest at Mia's back. *Evil Dead Rise* opens with the signature rush only to reveal it as the feed of a drone piloted by a bored young man — the demonic gaze disclosed as a consumer device before the true Force arrives — and *Evil Dead Burn* restores the growling demonic point of view as an act of fidelity to the franchise (Li 2026). *Evil Dead: The Game* (2022) completes the trajectory by making the Force a playable position: the player who takes the demon's role navigates the map as a disembodied rushing viewpoint, possessing bodies and objects. The spectator's identification with the demon, implicit since 1981, becomes in the game a matter of explicit agency.

The drone deserves more than a footnote. Teresa, reading *Wuthering Heights* on the dock — Emily Brontë's novel of a dead beloved at the window — is interrupted by the counterfeit Force; minutes later the possessed Jessica seizes the device, and its owner, Caleb, is killed with it. The

consumer apparatus that impersonated the demon's gaze becomes the demon's instrument. Chapter Six notes that this prologue is also the film's chronological ending.

The Force's sonic correlate is equally significant. Its roar, layered from animal and mechanical sources, merges with the nocturnal soundscape of the wood — insects, wind, creaking limbs. Lovecraft's fictional Arabic title for the *Necronomicon*, *Al Azif*, designated exactly this sound: the nocturnal noise of insects taken for the howling of demons. The Force's soundtrack is *Al Azif* realised: a nature whose noise is indistinguishable from demonic speech.

3.2 The Numinous Arrested: Otto's Daemonic Dread

Rudolf Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) analysed the experience of the sacred as the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*: a mystery that is wholly other, that inspires awe and dread, that overpowers by its majesty, and that manifests an urgent, restless energy — even as it fascinates and attracts. Otto located the primitive origin of this experience in what he called "daemonic dread" (*dämonische Scheu*), the uncanny shudder before ghosts and spirits from which, he argued, the higher apprehension of the holy gradually developed (Otto 1923 [1917]).

The Force is the numinous arrested at its daemonic stage. It possesses every formal attribute of Otto's *tremendum* — it is wholly other, invisible, overpowering, and above all energetic; Otto's element of urgency, the numen's sheer vitality and impetus, is precisely the quality the shaky-cam renders. It is also fascinating, as the exhilaration of the rush attests: the viewer *enjoys* being the Force. But it never matures into the holy. There is no God in the *Evil Dead* cycle, no priest whose office can oppose the demon, no sacrament that answers it; when clergy appear, in the backstory of *Evil Dead Rise*, they appear as recorded victims. The cycle thus presents religion frozen at its origin, the shudder that Otto believed would be sublimated into reverence remaining forever a shudder. Where *The Exorcist* restaged the Catholic drama of the holy's victory over the demonic, the *Evil Dead* cycle presents a cosmos in which the daemonic is the only numinous there is.

3.3 Kino-Eye, Gaseous Perception, and the Free Indirect Demon

In his manifesto "Kinoks: A Revolution" (1923), Dziga Vertov announced a camera emancipated from human immobility — an eye that could climb, fall, dive, and race alongside galloping horses, constructing a perception of the world no human body could achieve (Vertov 1984 [1923]). The Force is Vertov's kino-eye turned demon. The emancipation of the camera from the limits of the human body becomes, in the cycle, the emancipation of perception from the human altogether.

Gilles Deleuze's *Cinema 1* offers the conceptual apparatus for this emancipation. Deleuze distinguished, within the "perception-image," a solid perception centred on a subject, a liquid perception that flows, and a "gaseous" perception — associated above all with Vertov — in which the eye is placed in matter itself, perception becoming molecular, distributed, freed from any

centre (Deleuze 1986 [1983]). He also adopted Pier Paolo Pasolini's notion of the "free indirect subjective," the cinematic analogue of free indirect discourse, in which the camera adopts a quasi-subjective vision that hovers between a character's point of view and an autonomous perception of the film itself (Pasolini 1988 [1965]). The Force-image occupies a position neither of these concepts anticipated. It is not a character's point of view, since it has no body; it is not objective, since it pursues, desires, and strikes; and it is not the film's own neutral perception, since it is manifestly malevolent. It is a free indirect subjectivity *without a subject* — a perception whose "I" has been subtracted, leaving only the movement, the appetite, and the sound. If the automatic word was speech without a speaker, the automatic eye is vision without a seer.

3.4 Primary Identification as Possession

The apparatus theory of the 1970s argued that the cinema's basic ideological operation lies in the spectator's "primary identification" with the camera — prior to and more fundamental than any secondary identification with characters. For Jean-Louis Baudry, the apparatus positions the viewer as a transcendental subject, the unseen centre from which the world is seen; for Christian Metz, the spectator identifies with himself as pure act of perception, an all-perceiving subject absent from the screen (Baudry 1974 [1970]; Metz 1982 [1977]).

The *Evil Dead* cycle literalises this theory and turns it against its own premise. If the spectator identifies with the camera, and the camera is the Force, then the spectator identifies with the demon. The "unseen centre" from which the world is seen is the demon's position, and the transcendental subject of the apparatus is revealed as an invisible, predatory, and possessing agency. The final shot of *The Evil Dead* makes the point with brutal economy. The Force rushes toward Ash; Ash turns to face the camera; he screams; the screen goes black. What kills Ash — or possesses him; the film declines to specify — is the spectator's own gaze, advancing on him at the speed of the apparatus. Spectatorship is possession.

Lamberto Bava's *Demons* (*Dèmoni*, 1985), produced by Dario Argento, made the same proposition its plot. Spectators summoned to a free screening in a Berlin cinema are possessed one by one as the film they are watching — a horror film in which young people open the tomb of Nostradamus and one of them is cut by a mask found there — passes its demonic contagion into the auditorium, beginning with a woman scratched by a matching mask displayed in the lobby. Bava literalises in narrative what the *Evil Dead* cycle enacts in form: the cinema is a medium of possession, and its audience are its first hosts.

Carol Clover's analysis of the horror film's "eye" refined apparatus theory by distinguishing an *assaultive* gaze — the gaze of the killer, often rendered as the "I-camera" — from a *reactive* gaze that registers terror and victimisation, and by arguing that horror's spectators identify far more with the latter than the former, so that the I-camera is less an invitation to sadism than a rendering of threat as experienced from within it (Clover 1992). The cycle confirms and complicates the distinction. Its montage alternates the purest assaultive gaze in the genre — one detached from

any killer's body — with Campbell's face in extreme close-up, the reactive gaze at its most theatrical. The viewer occupies both positions in alternation, possessing and possessed, predator and prey. The cycle's characteristic pleasure is the oscillation itself: the spectator rides the Force and then is struck by it.

The Force's gaze is not, in the first instance, gendered; it is the gaze of a landscape. Yet its first act of possession in the founding film is a rape. In a sequence Raimi wrote and directed, the possessed forest's vines and branches seize Cheryl (Ellen Sandweiss), the first character to be taken, pin her down, and rape her; her possession follows from it. Feminist criticism has rightly identified the scene as the most troubling in the cycle, and the record of its makers' responses is specific. Raimi expressed regret as early as 1988, in an interview with Jonathan Ross for *The Incredibly Strange Film Show*, calling the scene "unnecessarily gratuitous and a little too brutal" and conceding that his judgement had been wrong at the time (San Diego Reader 2012; Sims 2021). *Evil Dead II* removed Cheryl and the rape, keeping only an attack by vines on Bobby Joe that stops short of it. The 2013 remake reinstated the rape and inflicted it on Mia. Its director, Fede Álvarez, said that the producer Robert Tapert had asked for the scene, that Raimi had neither wanted nor written it, and that it was meant to be more terrible than the original (San Diego Reader 2012; Sims 2021). Its structural function is nonetheless significant for the argument. The cycle's narrative of possession begins with the rape of a woman's body by an inhuman agency; the possession of Ash, and his long ordeal of what Clover would call "opening up," is founded upon this prior rape of a woman. The 2013 film's reinstatement of the rape, inflicted on Mia at its producer's request, preserves this foundation, while the matrilineal entries examined in Chapter Seven may be read as an extended attempt to work through it.

The founding film also stages a second sexual assault, with the genders reversed. After Ash has beheaded the possessed Linda with a shovel, her headless body, bleeding over him, straddles him in what the standard plot summaries describe as an attempted rape. The episode complicates the gendered asymmetry without cancelling it. The woman's violation opens the cycle's demonology and makes her the first host; the man's is one more humiliation in his ordeal, survived and absorbed into the masochistic spectacle examined in Chapter Five.

The classical tradition measures the inversion. In the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Daphne, fleeing Apollo's attempt to rape her, prays to her father, the river Peneus, and is turned into a laurel: the tree is her refuge from sexual violence and the form in which her body escapes the god. *The Evil Dead* reverses the myth exactly. The tree is not the woman's refuge but her rapist, and the transformation it effects — possession — does not preserve her body from violation but completes it. Where Virgil and Dante gave the tree a wounded soul, the cycle gives it the will to wound.

3.5 The Hostile Wood: A Comparative Silva

The Force moves through, and appears to emanate from, the forest. The *Evil Dead* wood belongs to a long tradition of malevolent and animate forests, and its specificity emerges only by comparison.

Dante's *Commedia* opens in a dark wood, the *selva oscura* in which the straight way has been lost. In Canto XIII of the *Inferno* that wood returns as the forest of the suicides, whose souls are imprisoned in gnarled trees that bleed and speak when a branch is broken — an episode modelled on the bleeding myrtle of Polydorus in the third book of the *Aeneid*. In Dante and Virgil the trees are the punished dead; in the *Evil Dead* cycle they are the punishers of the living. The bleeding, speaking tree is inverted into the seizing, striking tree. Ovid's Erysichthon, who cuts down Ceres's sacred oak and is afflicted with a hunger so insatiable that he ends by devouring his own body, supplies a further inversion: the wood's revenge as autophagy, the violator of the sacred grove consuming himself. The cycle's protagonists, who repeatedly sever their own limbs, re-enact Erysichthon's self-consumption without his sacrilege — they are punished, as it were, in advance.

The American wood has its own theology. For the Puritans of New England the wilderness was the devil's territory; Cotton Mather's *The Wonders of the Invisible World* (1693) treated it as the domain from which diabolical assault upon the godly community was launched. Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown" (1835) distilled that theology into the narrative template the *Evil Dead* cycle most closely reproduces: a young man walks into the forest at night and discovers, at a diabolical communion among the trees, that the people he loves — his wife, aptly named Faith, among them — belong to the devil. Brown returns to the village unable ever again to trust the faces of his neighbours. This is the *Evil Dead* ordeal precisely: the beloved revealed as demonic, the survivor emerging into daylight with his faith in faces destroyed.

The British weird supplies the third lineage. Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907), which Lovecraft ranked among the finest weird tales ever written, locates on a Danubian island the visible frontier of an alien order indifferent and hostile to human beings, whose presence is registered through the movement and murmuring of the willows (Lovecraft 1927); "The Wendigo" (1910) makes the forest itself a voice that calls its victims to a terrible velocity. Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) imagines a pagan power beneath the English landscape whose contact destroys the mind. The *Evil Dead* wood inherits from Blackwood the forest as frontier of the alien, and from Machen the pagan substrate beneath civilised space. It adds what neither possessed: speed. Blackwood's willows murmur; Raimi's trees *lunge*. And Macbeth's prophecy — that he shall not be vanquished until Birnam Wood comes to Dunsinane — supplies the cycle's dramatic premise in a single image: the forest that moves is the forest of fate.

3.6 The Eerie Exterior and the Weird Interior

Mark Fisher distinguished the *weird*, defined by the presence of that which does not belong — the intrusion of an outside that our categories cannot accommodate — from the *eerie*, defined by a failure of absence or a failure of presence: something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something. The eerie, Fisher argued, is fundamentally a question about agency: what kind of agent is acting here, and is there an agent at all? Its privileged sites are landscapes, ruins, and empty spaces in which the traces of an unseen agency are legible (Fisher 2016).

The Force is the eerie made cinematic. It is agency where there should be none — in water, in mist, in trees — and its invisibility keeps the question of its nature permanently open. The cycle's spatial dramaturgy, moreover, maps Fisher's distinction onto the boundary of the dwelling. Outside, in the wood, the Force is eerie: an agency suffused through landscape. When it breaches the cabin, the register shifts to the weird: the interior fills with things that do not belong — a corpse in the cellar, a hand that is no longer one's own, furniture that laughs. The cabin's walls are the membrane at which the eerie becomes the weird. Each entry relocates that membrane — to the castle walls of *Army of Darkness*, the apartment door of *Evil Dead Rise*, the mansion of *Evil Dead Burn* — but never abolishes it. The structure of the cycle is the structure of a breached threshold.

3.7 The Camera as Stooge

In the comic entries the automatic eye undergoes a transformation as significant as the transformation of the word into the flub. It becomes a participant in the routine. The camera whip-pans to catch a reaction, crash-zooms into a face for a double take, spins around Ash in the laughing room, and slams him against trees and walls as if it were a third Stooge delivering the slap. Tom Gunning's account of the "cinema of attractions" — the exhibitionist early cinema that addressed its spectator directly with spectacle rather than absorbing him in narrative — describes this mode exactly (Gunning 1986). The Raimi camera is a performer, and its performances are aggressions.

The sequel contains the cycle's most reflexive joke about the eye. An eyeball, dislodged from a Deadite's skull, flies across the cellar and into the open mouth of a screaming woman, who swallows it. The founding avant-garde assault on the spectator's eye — the razor drawn across an eye in Buñuel and Dalí's *Un Chien Andalou* (1929) — and Georges Bataille's contemporaneous *Story of the Eye* (1928), in which the eye becomes an obscene object exchanged among bodies, are recapitulated as slapstick. The eye, organ of the apparatus and of the spectator's sovereignty, is reduced to a projectile and ingested. The gaze returns to the body as food.

3.8 Conclusion: The Daemonic Apparatus

The automatic eye is the second order of Kandarian Automatism. Its principle may be stated thus: *perception persists without a perceiver, and the cinematic apparatus that renders it is indistinguishable from the demon it renders.* The cycle's audiences have intuited this throughout its reception history. The midnight screenings that made *The Evil Dead* a cult object gathered spectators to inhabit the Force's gaze collectively; *Evil Dead: The Musical* designates its first rows a "splatter zone" in which spectators are drenched in stage blood, so that the gaze which identified with the Force is answered, at the climax, by the liquid of its victims; and *Evil Dead: The Game* lets the player become the Force outright. What the camera sees, it possesses; what it possesses, it ruins. The following chapter turns to the ruined body that the word and the eye together produce.



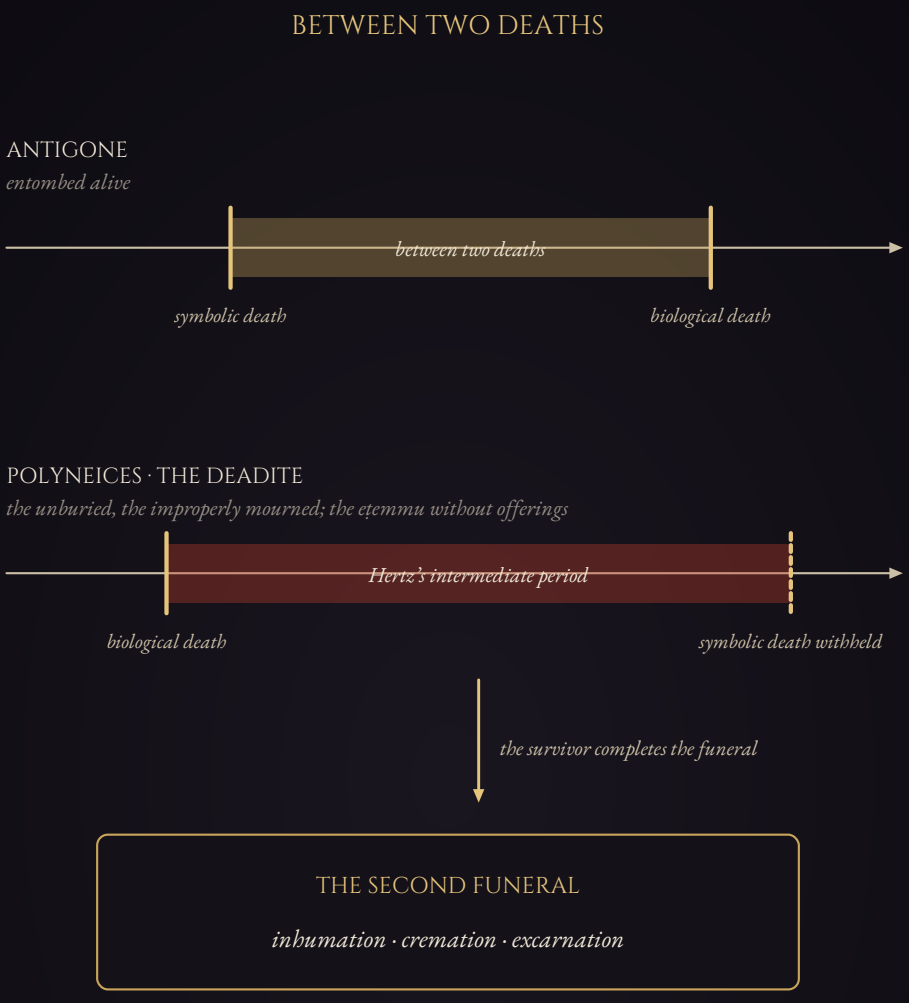
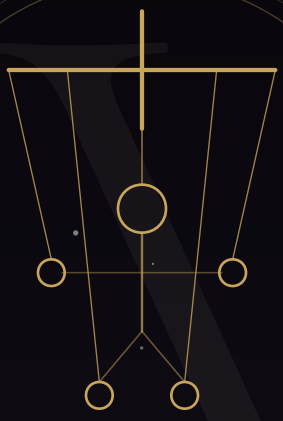


FIGURE 6 *Between two deaths: Antigone's symbolic death precedes her biological one; the Deadite's biological death awaits the symbolic death a funeral should have given it (§4.5).*



CHAPTER FOUR

The Automatic Body

The Deadite Between Two Deaths

The Deadite is a body that continues to operate after its person has been evacuated. It speaks in the beloved's voice and with the demon's malice; it pleads, mocks, sings, levitates, and dances; and it can be stopped, according to the founding film's recorded commentary, only by bodily dismemberment — or, in the 2013 film's expanded doctrine, by live burial, dismemberment, or fire. This chapter argues that the Deadite realises the Cartesian automaton without its soul and answers Spinoza's challenge concerning what a body can do; that its uncanny grace fulfils Kleist's paradox of the marionette; that its specific horror is the beloved replaced by an impostor of itself; that its ontological location is the interval Lacan named "between two deaths," the zone of the improperly buried dead whom Mesopotamian religion called the *eṭemmu*; and that the remedy the cycle prescribes — dismemberment — is the hyper-literal performance of a funeral in a culture that has forgotten how to bury. That performance is what this dissertation calls the *liturgy of dismemberment*.

4.1 What the Deadite Is Not

The Deadite is not a zombie in George A. Romero's sense. Romero's ghouls are mute, slow, collective, and cannibalistic; they transmit their condition by the bite; they have no individuality and no speech; and their allegorical vocation, made explicit in the shopping mall of *Dawn of the Dead* (1978), is the critique of mass consumption. The Deadite, by contrast, is articulate, swift, theatrical, and individualised; it acquires its condition by possession rather than infection, at least in the founding films; and its speech is its most terrible attribute.

Nor is the Deadite a demon in the Catholic sense. *The Exorcist* requires a named adversary, a victim whose soul can be saved, and a priest whose office, codified in the *Rituale Romanum* of 1614, authorises the expulsion. The Deadite has no name but its provenance — it is a "Kandarian demon" — and no priest opposes it. Its victims' souls are not contested but consumed; "I'll swallow your soul" is the cycle's recurrent threat, and the threat is apparently fulfilled. There is accordingly nothing to save. Exorcism, which in the Christian rite expels the demon and restores the person, is replaced by dismemberment, which destroys the body because there is no longer any person to restore.

Nor, finally, is the Deadite a ghost. The ghost is spirit without body; the Deadite is body without spirit. It is the inversion of the spectral tradition: not the immaterial persistence of a person after the body's death, but the material persistence of a body after the person's death. Its proper name, in the conceptual vocabulary of this dissertation, is *automaton*.

4.2 The Cartesian Automaton and Spinoza's Challenge

Descartes's physiology conceived the human body as a machine on the model of the hydraulic automata in the royal gardens at Saint-Germain-en-Laye, whose figures moved as water flowed through their pipes; animals, he argued in the fifth part of the *Discourse on Method* (1637), are automata of this kind, lacking the rational soul that in humans is joined to the machine at the

pineal gland. In the *Meditations* (1641) he entertained, as the limit of methodical doubt, the hypothesis of an evil genius, supremely powerful and cunning, who devotes all his energy to deceiving him about everything that appears.

The Deadite fuses these two Cartesian nightmares. It is the human body reduced to the animal-machine, its rational soul removed; and it is that machine piloted by an evil genius whose chief pleasure is deception. The Kandarian demon does not merely counterfeit appearances from outside the mind, as Descartes's hypothetical deceiver does; it seats itself where the soul once sat and drives the body from within. Its deceptions, moreover, are precisely those that would most torment a Cartesian subject. The possessed Cheryl, Linda, and Henrietta all at some point resume the voice and manner of the person they were, pleading for help or release, before the counterfeit dissolves into cackling. The evil genius does not falsify the world; it falsifies the beloved.

Spinoza, rejecting Descartes's dualism, observed in the scholium to the second proposition of the third part of the *Ethics* (1677) that no one has yet determined what the body can do by the laws of its own nature alone, without direction by the mind; he cited the sleepwalker, who performs in sleep feats he would not dare when awake, as evidence that the body is capable of much that astonishes its own mind. The Deadite is the cycle's answer to Spinoza's challenge. Freed from the mind, the body levitates, contorts, distends, survives decapitation, and dances. Henrietta's neck stretches to grotesque length; Linda's headless corpse waltzes in moonlight; Mia, in the 2013 film, scalds herself in the shower; Ellie, in *Evil Dead Rise*, contorts beyond the limits of human anatomy. Each is a demonstration of what a body can do once no one is home. The Deadite is Spinoza's sleepwalker raised to the power of the demonic.

4.3 Kleist's Marionette and the Dancing Corpse

In "On the Marionette Theatre" (1810), Heinrich von Kleist's narrator meets Herr C., the principal dancer of the opera, who astonishes him by claiming that a marionette can dance with more grace than any human dancer. The marionette, Herr C. explains, is free of affectation, the displacement of the soul from the body's true centre of gravity that self-consciousness produces; its limbs obey only the law of gravity and the pendulum swing of its strings. Grace, he concludes, appears most purely in the body that has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one — in the puppet, or in the god. The human being, having eaten of the tree of knowledge, is stranded between these poles; paradise is barred behind us, and we must travel around the world to see whether it is open somewhere at the back (Kleist 1972 [1810]).

Evil Dead II contains a scene that reads as a gloss on Kleist. Ash, having decapitated his possessed girlfriend and buried her, watches from the cabin as her headless body rises from its grave and dances a ballet among the moonlit trees. The sequence was animated in stop-motion — that is, the dancing corpse is literally a marionette, moved by hands outside the frame, one increment at a time — and it is, by common consent, the most graceful passage in the cycle. Then the head rejoins the dance, cackling, and the ballet becomes an assault. The corpse, which has no con-

sciousness, achieves a grace that Ash never achieves. Ash is the human being between the poles: self-conscious, affected, clumsy, a body that collides, slips, falls, and is struck — precisely the body of slapstick, whose mechanical misadventures Bergson would have recognised as the comic par excellence. Between the puppet's grace and the god's (the Force's frictionless velocity), the human being stumbles.

Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) supplies the dark complement to Kleist. For Ligotti, the puppet is the central figure of supernatural horror: the puppet that moves of its own accord is uncanny, and the human being who discovers that he is himself a puppet — that consciousness is a malignant superfluity mounted upon a mechanism it does not control — confronts the ultimate horror (Ligotti 2010). The Deadite combines Kleist's grace and Ligotti's horror in a single figure: the puppet whose strings are visible to everyone but itself.

The dancing corpse has a long iconographic pedigree. The medieval *danse macabre*, which spread across Europe in the century after the Black Death and is preserved in Holbein's woodcuts of 1538 and in innumerable church murals, depicted the dead seizing the living of every estate — pope, emperor, merchant, child — and drawing them into a dance whose leveling egalitarianism was its moral. Its invitation is the Deadite's refrain: *join us*. Saint-Saëns's *Danse macabre* (1874) and Ub Iwerks's *The Skeleton Dance* (1929) carried the image into modern music and animation. *Army of Darkness*, set in the year 1300, half a century before the plague that would make this iconography ubiquitous, stages its skeleton army in the comic idiom of Harryhausen and Iwerks; the film's dead dance, march, mock, and fall apart, and their egalitarian invitation is extended with particular relish to the film's lords and knights.

Sergei Eisenstein, writing on Disney, praised the animated body's "plasmaticness": its refusal of a form allotted once and forever, its capacity to stretch, compress, and metamorphose — the elongating neck being his signal example — which he read as a utopian protest against the rigidity of industrial life (Eisenstein 1988). Henrietta's elongating neck in *Evil Dead II* is plasmaticness in a horror key. The Deadite body has the infinite deformability of the cartoon, but where Eisenstein saw in that deformability a dream of liberation, the cycle shows the nightmare of a body liberated from its owner.

The founding film ends with the cycle's most radical image of the body. When Ash throws the Book into the fire at dawn, the possessed bodies of Cheryl and Scott do not simply die. In an extended stop-motion sequence animated by Bart Pierce and Tom Sullivan, they decompose through every state of matter — flesh liquefying, forms sprouting and collapsing, fluids of every colour — until nothing recognisable remains. Georges Bataille's entry "Formless" in the critical dictionary of *Documents* (1929) proposed that the *informe* is not a concept but an operation that declassifies, bringing things down in the world as one crushes a spider or an earthworm, and suggested that the universe resembles nothing and is only formless (Bataille 1985 [1929]). The decomposition at dawn is the *informe* made cinema. The Deadite's final state is not death but the abolition of form, the body returned not to dust but to the indeterminate.

4.4 The Beloved Replaced

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) located the uncanny in the return of the familiar in estranged form, and enumerated among its sources the double, the repetition of the same, the omnipotence of thoughts, and the confusion of the animate with the inanimate. It also contains a sentence that reads, in retrospect, as an inventory of *Evil Dead II*: Freud observes that dismembered limbs, a severed head, a hand cut off at the wrist, and feet that dance by themselves have something peculiarly uncanny about them, especially when they are credited with independent activity (Freud 1955 [1919]). The severed hand, the severed head, and the dancing body all appear in the sequel, and all are credited with independent activity. Freud referred the effect to castration anxiety; the cycle refers it to automatism.

The Deadite's deepest horror, however, lies not in its parts but in its face. Possession in the cycle strikes, with almost liturgical regularity, at kin and lovers: a sister in 1981 and 2013, a girlfriend in 1981 and 1987, a wife and mother in the Knowby cellar, a mother in 2023, a husband in 2026. The Deadite is the beloved's body without the beloved. The condition has a clinical name. In 1923 Joseph Capgras and Jean Reboul-Lachaux described a patient convinced that her family had been replaced by identical impostors; later neuropsychological accounts have explained the delusion as a dissociation between the recognition of a familiar face and the affective response that normally accompanies it, so that the patient recognises the face but feels nothing, and concludes that it belongs to a double (Capgras and Reboul-Lachaux 1923; Ellis and Young 1990). The Deadite is the Capgras delusion made veridical: the face is the beloved's, and the beloved is truly gone. And the Deadites know it. They exploit the survivor's recognition, pleading in the familiar voice, before revealing the absence behind it in a burst of laughter.

Kierkegaard had described this voice. In the fourth chapter of *The Concept of Anxiety* he defines the demonic as *det Indesluttede og det ufrivilligt Aabenbare*, the inclosed and the involuntarily disclosed, and illustrates it from the Gospels, where the possessed recoil at the approach of Christ — among them the demoniac of Luke 8, whose demon gives its name as Legion (Kierkegaard 1980 [1844]). The disclosure, he writes, may come in words, in looks, in *den ufrivillige Telegraphering*, an involuntary telegraphy — a metaphor taken, in the year of Morse's first public line, from the signalling technology of the day — and when its content is petty it can be almost comic. The history of ventriloquism supplies the rest. From late antiquity into the eighteenth century, as Leigh Eric Schmidt has shown, the voice that seems to speak from a body not its own belonged to Christian discourses of demon possession and necromancy, before the Enlightenment turned it into a stage amusement (Schmidt 1998; Connor 2000). The Deadites' characteristic pronoun is Legion's: *we're going to get you*; *join us*; *one by one we will take you*.

Science fiction had already imagined the beloved replaced. In Jack Finney's *The Body Snatchers* (1954) and Don Siegel's film of it (1956), the inhabitants of a small town are replaced by duplicates grown from seed pods, indistinguishable from the originals except for an absence of feeling — the Capgras experience made epidemic, with the vegetable world, as in the *Evil Dead*

wood, the medium of replacement. In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the ocean of an alien planet sends a scientist a "visitor" in the form of the wife whose death he blames on himself: the beloved returned by an intelligence that does not understand what it returns. In Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969), the dead held in "half-life" are devoured from within by Jory, a half-lifer who consumes the residual vitality of the others — a predator of souls in a precise sense, as the Deadites promise to be when they threaten to swallow the souls of the living.

The production history supplies an unexpected corroboration. When cast members departed during the protracted shoot of *The Evil Dead*, their roles were completed by friends and crew filmed from behind or in shadow — "Fake Shemps," named for the stand-in who completed the Three Stooges' contracted shorts after Shemp Howard's death in 1955 (Campbell 2001). The Fake Shemp is a role continued by a body that is not its owner's, originating in the necessity of finishing the work of a dead man. It is the industrial counterpart of possession. In the Stooges' shorts and in the Tennessee cabin alike, a body performs a person after the person has gone, and the audience is invited not to notice. The ontology of the Deadite is the ontology of the stand-in.

Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) offers the deepest account of why the beloved should return as a demon. Examining the widespread belief among the peoples studied by the anthropology of his day that the dead — even, and especially, the beloved dead — become hostile demons, Freud traced it to the ambivalence of the survivors' feelings: the unconscious hostility that coexists with love for the deceased is projected onto the dead, who are then feared as malevolent (Freud 1950 [1913]). The cycle stages this projection and then licenses its discharge. The beloved returns as a demon, and the survivor is not merely permitted but compelled to express against the beloved's body a violence that mourning ordinarily represses. In 1981 Scott hacks his possessed girlfriend Shelly apart with an axe and Ash turns a shotgun on his possessed sister Cheryl; in 1987 Ash beheads Linda with a shovel; in 2013 David buries his sister alive; in 2023 a possessed mother turns on her own children. The splatter is ambivalence externalised.

4.5 Between Two Deaths

In his seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis (1959–1960), Lacan distinguished between natural death and a second, symbolic death, taking the phrase from a speech that Sade, in *Juliette*, places in the mouth of Pope Pius VI, imagining a crime that would annihilate not merely life but the cycle of nature itself. Antigone, entombed alive for having buried her brother, occupies for Lacan the space *between two deaths*, her symbolic death preceding her biological one; Polyneices, denied burial, occupies the converse interval, biologically dead but symbolically unfinished (Lacan 1992 [1986]). Slavoj Žižek drew the consequence for popular culture: the dead return, in ghost story and horror film alike, because they were not properly buried — because something went wrong with their obsequies — and they return as collectors of an unpaid symbolic debt (Žižek 1991).

The Deadites are exactly such collectors, and the cycle is scrupulous about the irregularity of their interment. Linda, in both of the first two films, is buried in haste and in a shallow grave by a

single exhausted mourner, and rises from it. Henrietta Knowby lies not in a grave but in the fruit cellar beneath the floorboards, where, like the walled-up wife of Poe's "The Black Cat" (1843), she announces herself from below. William Price, in *Evil Dead Burn*, is released from his coffin by his own father at the very threshold of the crematorium, and kills the cremator, at the instant the funeral was to be completed. The cycle's dead are uniformly those whose funerals have been interrupted, improvised, or refused.

Stephen King, the cycle's earliest patron, published in 1983 — the year of *The Evil Dead*'s American release — a novel built on the same premise. In *Pet Sematary*, a father buries his small son in an ancient burial ground beyond the town's pet cemetery and receives him back altered and murderous; the novel's refrain that sometimes dead is better states, in the vernacular, the lesson of improper burial. King's ground is a Micmac burial ground, another instance of the device through which, as Chapter One noted after Bergland, American fiction relocates its guilt onto Indigenous dead, and its power is attributed to the Wendigo, the forest spirit Blackwood had made a figure of the hostile wood (King 1983).

Robert Hertz's classic study of double burial (1907), based above all on the mortuary practices of the Dayak of Borneo, demonstrated that in many societies death is not an instant but a process, extended over the interval between a provisional disposal of the corpse and a final ceremony in which the cleaned bones are reinterred and the deceased is admitted among the ancestors. During this interval the corpse is polluting, the soul homeless and dangerous, and the living vulnerable (Hertz 1960 [1907]). Arnold van Gennep generalised the structure as a rite of passage with its liminal phase, and Victor Turner made liminality — the state of being "betwixt and between" — a category of social analysis (van Gennep 1960 [1909]; Turner 1967). The Deadite is the corpse stranded permanently in Hertz's intermediate period. Its second funeral never comes, unless the survivor performs it.

Hegel, in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), identified burial as the ethical act par excellence of the family. Left to itself, he argued, the dead body would be handed over to the operation of natural forces and to the appetites of lower creatures; the family's act of burial interrupts that process, transforming death from a merely natural event into a spiritual one and wedding the kinsman to the earth (Hegel 1977 [1807]). In *Evil Dead Rise*, the possessed mother taunts her children with the announcement that "Mommy's with the maggots now." The line is a precise negation of Hegel's family: the mother's body has been handed over to the worms, and the family that should have buried her is now her prey.

The Mesopotamian materials toward which the cycle gestures confirm this reading with striking specificity. The *eṭemmu*, the ghost of the deceased, required both proper burial and the regular funerary offerings known as *kispu*, presented by a designated descendant who invoked the name of the dead; deprived of either, it became restless, wandered, and afflicted the living with illness, possession, and terror, and the exorcistic texts treat a whole class of ailments as ghost-induced (Scurlock 2006). The Akkadian twelfth tablet appended to the *Epic of Gilgamesh* has the shade of Enkidu report the fates of the dead in the netherworld: the one whose corpse lies unbur-

ied in the open finds no rest below, and the one who has no one to make offerings subsists on scraps from the pot and crusts thrown into the street. The goddess Ishtar, enraged in the sixth tablet of the same epic and in the *Descent of Ishtar*, threatens to break open the netherworld and raise up the dead to devour the living, so that the dead will outnumber the living — the earliest literary formulation of the scenario that the cycle's apocalyptic entries realise. The Kandarian demonology is thus, in its deep structure, genuinely Mesopotamian: the dead return as consumers of the living when the funerary order fails, and their invitation to "join us" is the demand that the dead come to outnumber the living.

Two modern theorists complete the diagnosis. Nietzsche, in the second essay of the *Genealogy*, argued that early communities experienced their relation to their ancestors as a debt that grew with the community's power until the ancestor, out of fear, was transfigured into a god. Jean Baudrillard argued that modernity has expelled the dead from symbolic exchange — relocating cemeteries beyond the city, segregating dying in institutions, treating the dead as non-persons — and that this exclusion is the prototype of every other exclusion on which the social order rests (Baudrillard 1993 [1976]). The Deadites are creditors returning to collect an ancestral debt in the currency of souls, and their return is the return of an exchange that modernity tried to abolish. Geoffrey Gorer's essay "The Pornography of Death" (1955) had predicted the cultural form such a return would take: death, he argued, had replaced sex as the unmentionable subject of modern Anglophone culture, and, banished from decent discourse, it would reappear as a pornographic fantasy of violent death in mass entertainment (Gorer 1955). The splatter film, and the moral panic it provoked, fulfilled Gorer's prophecy almost to the letter.

4.6 The Liturgy of Dismemberment

The cycle's remedies for possession now acquire their meaning. The 2013 film's Book prescribes three means of purifying a possessed body: live burial, bodily dismemberment, and fire. These are not arbitrary torments. They correspond exactly to the three great families of human mortuary practice: inhumation, cremation, and excarnation — the defleshing and dismemberment of the corpse practised in Tibetan sky burial, in Zoroastrian exposure, and in the late-medieval European custom of dividing and boiling the bodies of the elite dead so that their bones might be carried home. That last practice was condemned by Pope Boniface VIII in the bull *Detestande feritatis*, issued under pain of excommunication on 27 September 1299 and reissued in February 1300 (E. A. R. Brown 1981) — the very year in which *Army of Darkness* deposits Ash among the dead. The franchise's purifications are funerals. Its survivors are improvised morticians, and its weapons — the shovel, the axe, the chainsaw, the fire — are the tools of the three ancient ways of disposing of the dead.



FIGURE 7 *The three remedies as the three families of mortuary practice, with the deaths of the 2013 film among them (§4.6).*

The 2013 film performs the correspondence on its own cast. Its prologue shows a father burning his possessed daughter before shooting her. Its Book names the three purifications. And its deaths fall among them. Natalie, who has cut off one arm to stop the possession spreading, has the other shot away by David; the demon leaves her as she bleeds to death, and she dies herself again, not understanding why he has hurt her. Eric and David burn with the cabin. Mia is buried and brought back. Only Olivia, bludgeoned, dies outside the rites. The film does not merely name the three mortuary families; it carries out each of them.

This is what the present study terms the *liturgy of dismemberment*: the performance, by amateurs, in frenzy, and without priest, of the funerary labour that the culture has ceased to perform for itself. Jessica Mitford's *The American Way of Death* (1963) described an industry devoted to presenting the embalmed corpse as lifelike — asleep, cosmeticised, posed for viewing — and to removing from the bereaved every material contact with the dead. The Deadite is the anti-embalmed corpse. Where the American funeral makes the dead look alive, the Deadite is the dead truly animate who look unmistakably dead; and where the funeral industry outsources every contact with the corpse, the cycle forces its survivors to handle, cut, bury, and burn the bodies of those they love with their own hands. The gore is the return of the repressed labour of the funeral.

It is also, finally, the return of the labour of mourning. In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) Freud described the work of mourning as a process in which the libido is detached from the lost object not all at once but bit by bit, each memory and expectation that bound the

survivor to the dead being called up and painfully relinquished in turn, at great expense of time and energy (Freud 1957 [1917]). The liturgy of dismemberment is that work externalised and accelerated into a single night. The survivor takes the beloved apart piece by piece because the beloved must be relinquished piece by piece. Dismemberment is *Trauerarbeit* performed with a chainsaw.

4.7 Conclusion: The Body Without a Person

The automatic body is the third order of Kandarian Automatism. Its principle may be stated thus: *the body persists and operates after the person is evacuated; it returns as the beloved's form without the beloved; it lingers between two deaths because its funeral was not completed; and its destruction is the funeral, performed at last.* The Deadite is grotesque in Bakhtin's sense — a body that protrudes, gapes, and spills beyond its limits — and abject in Kristeva's, the corpse being for her the utmost of abjection, death infecting life (Bakhtin 1968 [1965]; Kristeva 1982 [1980]). It is impure in Mary Douglas's sense, matter out of place, and horrifying in Noël Carroll's, an interstitial being that violates the categories of living and dead, person and thing (Douglas 1966; Carroll 1990). But beneath all of these descriptions lies the structure that unifies the cycle: the Deadite is a mechanism wearing a face. The question that remains is what becomes of the one who must take the mechanism apart. The next chapter turns to the survivor.



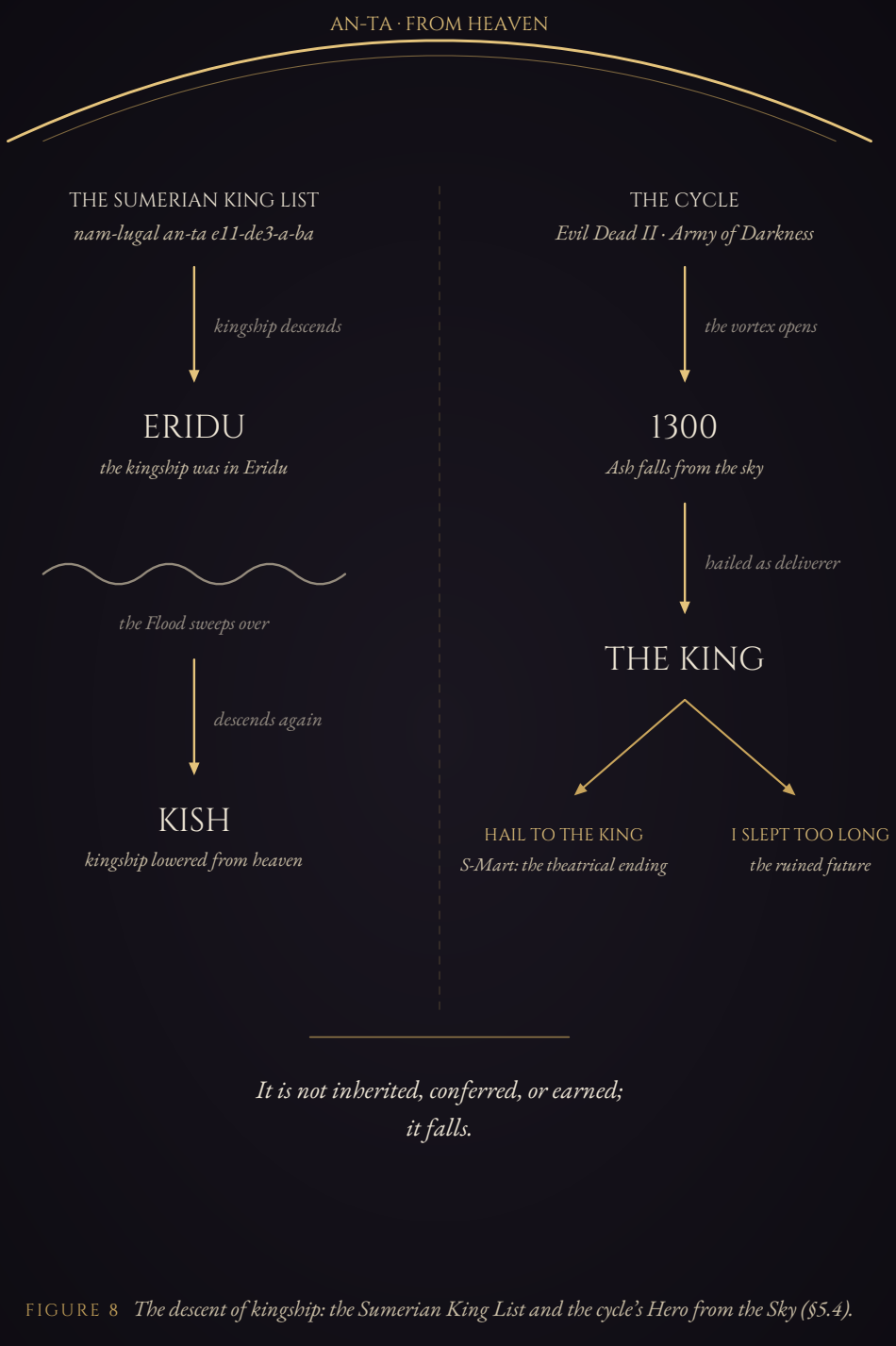


FIGURE 8 *The descent of kingship: the Sumerian King List and the cycle's Hero from the Sky (§5.4).*



CHAPTER FIVE

The Augmented Body

Ash Williams and the Prosthetic Sovereign

Ash Williams survives by becoming a machine. In *Evil Dead II* his right hand is possessed; he pins it to the floor, severs it with a chainsaw, and, after a night of combat with the escaped hand, fits the chainsaw to his stump and pronounces the cycle's most famous word: "Groovy." In *Army of Darkness* he forges a mechanical hand, brandishes a shotgun he calls his "boomstick," converts his Oldsmobile into a war machine, manufactures gunpowder from a chemistry textbook, and is hailed as the prophesied hero who descends from the sky. This chapter reads Ash as the fourth order of Kandarian Automatism: the *augmented body*, which answers the evacuation of the person not by restoring the soul but by accepting the machine. His sovereignty is prosthetic, Promethean, Epimethean, and comic; it is founded on a mispronounced word and sustained by survival alone; and it parodies, with an exactness the films could not have intended, the Sumerian doctrine that kingship descends from heaven.

5.1 The Rebel Hand

The sequence in which Ash's hand turns against him is the hinge of the entire cycle, the moment at which possession migrates from the beloved's body to the survivor's own. Bitten by his girlfriend's severed head, the hand becomes an independent agent. It smashes crockery over Ash's skull, drags him across the floor toward a cleaver, and must be pinned with a knife before he can saw it off. Severed, it escapes into the walls, mocks him with obscene gestures, and is trapped beneath an upturned bucket weighted with a stack of books crowned by Hemingway's *A Farewell to Arms*. "Who's laughing now?" Ash asks the bucket. The answer, within minutes, is the entire room.

The hand is the organ of agency par excellence, and the philosophical tradition has treated it accordingly. Heidegger, in his lectures *What Is Called Thinking?* (1951–1952), reserved the hand to the being that speaks and thinks: the ape has grasping organs, but only the human has a hand, and every motion of the hand carries itself through the element of thinking (Heidegger 1968 [1954]). Derrida's "Geschlecht II: Heidegger's Hand" (1985) interrogated the singular, humanist, essentialising *hand* that Heidegger opposed to the animal's organs (Derrida 1987 [1985]). Maurice Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology made the lived body the subject of perception and action — the body as an "I can" rather than an "I think" — and found in the hand that touches the other hand the reversible chiasm of flesh, touching and touched at once (Merleau-Ponty 1962 [1945]; 1968 [1964]). *Evil Dead II* stages the collapse of each of these accounts. The hand ceases to carry itself through thinking; it becomes a grasping organ in the service of another will. The "I can" becomes an "it does." And the chiasm of touching and touched becomes a brawl: the reversibility of flesh turned into combat within a single body.

Neurology furnished the figure before cinema did. In 1908 Kurt Goldstein — whose clinical work Merleau-Ponty would later make central to his phenomenology — described a patient, a woman of fifty-seven, whose left hand acted with apparent autonomy and attempted to strangle her; as she put it, *das sind ja zweierlei Menschen, der Arm und ich* — the arm and I are two differ-

ent people (Goldstein 1908). The condition, now known as alien hand syndrome, acquired a popular eponym from Stanley Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964), whose title character's gloved hand salutes and throttles him against his will. Literature had anticipated both: Nerval's "La Main enchantée" (1832), Maupassant's "La Main" (1883), in which the severed hand of a murdered man strangles its owner, W. F. Harvey's "The Beast with Five Fingers" (1919), and the European folklore of the Hand of Glory, the severed hand of a hanged man employed by thieves to stupefy a sleeping household. Oliver Stone's *The Hand*, released in the same year as *The Evil Dead*, and Mike Mignola's Hellboy, whose stone "Right Hand of Doom" is the key to the apocalypse, extend the lineage on either side of the cycle. The rebel hand recurs throughout the modern fantastic because it figures the revolt of agency against the agent — the discovery that the instrument of one's will has a will of its own.

Ash vs Evil Dead carries the rebel hand into writing. In its second season Pablo's hand begins, without his volition, to sketch the face on the Book's cover, and Ruby uses Ash's long-severed hand as a dowsing instrument that points the way to the Book. The automatic hand and the automatic word converge in automatic writing, a practice with two modern histories. Spiritualism made the medium's hand the instrument through which the dead wrote. André Breton's first *Manifesto of Surrealism* (1924) defined Surrealism itself as pure psychic automatism, thought dictated in the absence of any control by reason (Breton 1924). The cycle sides with the Spiritualists against Breton. Its automatism liberates nothing in the writer; it lends his hand to someone else. Kandarian Automatism is Surrealist automatism with the unconscious replaced by the dead.

The most striking parallel, however, is mythic. In the Winnebago trickster cycle recorded by Paul Radin, the trickster Wakdjunkaga, skinning a buffalo, finds that his left arm has seized the carcass and will not release it; his two arms fight, and the right arm cuts the left so badly that he cries out at the suffering he has inflicted on himself. Elsewhere he instructs his own anus to stand guard while he sleeps, punishes it with fire when it fails, and carries his penis in a box on his back (Radin 1956). Jung, commenting on Radin, read the trickster as a figure of an undifferentiated consciousness in which the body's parts have not yet been unified under the sovereignty of an ego (Jung 1956). Ash is this trickster restored to a mechanised modernity: a culture hero who brings fire and fights his own limbs, vain, greedy, lecherous, self-harming, and indestructible.

Henri Bergson defined the comic as "something mechanical encrusted upon the living": we laugh when a human being behaves like a thing, when rigidity or automatism intrudes upon the supple attentiveness of life (Bergson 1911 [1900]). The rebel hand is the purest Bergsonian object ever devised — a part of the living body that has become a mechanism and acts against the life it belongs to. The same object is, in Freud's essay, the purest instance of the uncanny. The hand thus anticipates the dissertation's central claim: horror and laughter in the cycle are two apprehensions of one automatism.

The comic genealogy of dismemberment is nearer to hand. In *Monty Python and the Holy Grail* (1975), the Black Knight loses both arms and both legs to King Arthur while insisting that each loss is a mere scratch — a body subtracted limb by limb while the will that animates it re-

fuses to register the subtraction. The joke is Bergson's: a will running on like a mechanism after the body that should support it has been removed. *Army of Darkness* inherits the Black Knight's Arthurian setting, and *Evil Dead II* his logic: the body may be taken away piece by piece while the speaking subject goes on talking.

5.2 Auto-Amputation and the Prosthetic God

Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964) proposed that every technological extension of the body is simultaneously an "autoamputation." Drawing on the stress physiology of Hans Selye and on medical speculation that the nervous system protects itself under intolerable stimulation by isolating the overstimulated organ, McLuhan argued that media extend our faculties by severing them from us and numbing us to the operation; he read the myth of Narcissus accordingly, not as self-love but as numb fascination with an extension of oneself that one fails to recognise as oneself (McLuhan 1964). Ash's sequence enacts McLuhan's thesis in literal flesh. The overstimulated organ — the possessed hand — is amputated, and the technological extension — the chainsaw — is fitted to the stump. The numbing follows: Ash's affect flattens into catchphrase, and his "Groovy" is the narcosis of a man who has replaced a limb with a power tool and found the arrangement satisfactory. And *Army of Darkness* supplies McLuhan's Narcissus exactly: a double that grows out of Ash's own body, which he fails to recognise as himself and destroys.

In *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930), Freud described modern humanity as having become a kind of "prosthetic God": magnificent when it puts on all its auxiliary organs, but troubled by them, since they have not grown onto it and still give it much trouble at times (Freud 1961 [1930]). Ash is the prosthetic god in miniature, a deity of the hardware aisle. His auxiliary organs — chainsaw, shotgun, metal gauntlet, armoured Oldsmobile — make him magnificent, a hero worshipped by medieval knights; and they give him much trouble, sputtering, misfiring, and requiring endless maintenance. Donna Haraway's cyborg, a hybrid of organism and machine that confounds the boundaries on which Western dualisms rest, finds in Ash a comic proletarian instance (Haraway 1985). It is worth noting that *Evil Dead II* appeared in the same year as Paul Verhoeven's *RoboCop* (1987). The two films propose two cyborgs: the corporate cyborg, rebuilt by a conglomerate as police property, and the hardware-store cyborg, who rebuilds himself from tools bought on sale.

Bernard Stiegler's *Technics and Time* (1994) supplies the deepest account of this prosthetic condition. Rereading the myth of the *Protagoras*, Stiegler recalls that Epimetheus, charged with distributing qualities among the creatures, exhausted them on the animals and forgot humankind, leaving it naked, unshod, and unarmed; Prometheus, to compensate, stole fire and technical skill from the gods. The human being is thus constituted by an originary *default* — a lack of qualities — supplemented by technics, which externalises memory into tools and inscriptions (Stiegler 1998 [1994]). Ash is Epimethean and Promethean at once. Epimetheus is the god of af-

terthought and forgetting, and Ash's defining failure is a failure of memory: he forgets the incantation. Prometheus is the bringer of fire and technical knowledge, and Ash's defining success is a technical one: he brings gunpowder to the fourteenth century from a textbook in the trunk of his car. What fails is living memory, the recitation of the sacred words by heart; what succeeds is externalised memory, the printed chemistry manual. Plato's *Phaedrus* had condemned writing as a mere aid to memory — *hypomnesis* rather than *anamnesis* — that would breed forgetfulness. The cycle reverses the verdict. Ash forgets what he was told to remember and saves the castle with what he did not need to remember because it was written down.

5.3 Boomstick and Textbook: The Promethean Clerk

The scene that consecrates Ash's sovereignty in *Army of Darkness* is a sales pitch. Confronted by the lords who have enslaved him, he displays his shotgun, names its make, and recites its retailer and department, as if addressing customers in the housewares aisle of S-Mart. "This is my boomstick" is the formula of a clerk turned prophet. Arthur C. Clarke's third law — that "any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic" — describes the medieval reception of the weapon exactly (Clarke 1973). Ash's power derives from technology misrecognised as magic, just as, in the Book, magic operates as mechanism. The two halves of the cycle mirror each other: the demon's magic works like a machine; the hero's machine is worshipped like magic.

The literary genealogy of the scene is precise. Twain's Hank Morgan, the Connecticut machinist transported to Camelot, wins power by predicting an eclipse, introduces gunpowder, the telegraph, and the newspaper, and calls himself "the Boss"; the novel ends with the Battle of the Sand Belt, in which Morgan's electrified fences and Gatling guns slaughter the chivalry of England, after which he and his followers are trapped among the corpses, sickened by the air of the dead. Morgan is then cast into a sleep of thirteen centuries by Merlin and awakens in the nineteenth century, a stranger to his own time (Twain 1889). *Army of Darkness* preserves Twain's comic premise and suppresses his catastrophe, except in its original ending, in which Ash, required to drink one drop of a sleeping potion for each century he must traverse, miscounts, oversleeps, and awakens in a ruined, post-apocalyptic London — Twain's ending relocated from the past to the future.

The chivalric tradition had already pronounced on firearms. In the eleventh canto of Ariosto's *Orlando Furioso* (1532), Orlando hurls the arquebus into the sea, cursing it as an infernal invention that has destroyed the glory of arms. In the sixth book of *Paradise Lost* (1667), it is Satan who invents cannon and gunpowder during the war in heaven, deploying what Milton calls his "devilish enginry" against the loyal angels. The Christian epic and the chivalric romance thus agree that gunpowder is diabolical. The Hero from the Sky brings the devil's invention to the defence of Christendom; the cycle's salvation arrives by Satan's technology.

The historical year of Ash's descent sharpens the irony. The Franciscan Roger Bacon, who died around 1292, was credited by later tradition with the first European description of gun-

powder, and by popular legend with the fabrication of a brazen head that could speak. In Robert Greene's *Friar Bacon and Friar Bungay* (c. 1589), the head finally speaks while Bacon sleeps, uttering in succession "Time is," "Time was," and "Time is past," before shattering; the servant set to watch fails to wake his master, and the moment is lost. The world into which Ash falls in 1300 is Bacon's world: gunpowder, magic, a talking severed head, and a fatal oversleeping. The legend of Friar Bacon reads, in retrospect, as a gloss on Ash.

The year's two halves meet at the papal court. Agostino Paravicini Bagliani's history of the medieval papal body links Boniface VIII's horror of the divided corpse to the curia's interest in prolonging life, an interest served by treatises on delaying old age, among them one attributed to Roger Bacon (Paravicini Bagliani 2000 [1994], chap. 9 and part IV). Ash descends into a Christendom that forbade the dismemberment of the dead while its scholars sought to postpone death: the integrity of the corpse and the indefinite survival of the body, the two projects that the cycle's liturgy of dismemberment and its prosthetic hero turn inside out.

Umberto Eco's essay "Dreaming of the Middle Ages" (1986) distinguished ten "little Middle Ages" that modernity has imagined, among them the Middle Ages as pretext, as object of ironical revisitation, as barbaric age, and as the expectation of the Millennium (Eco 1986). *Army of Darkness* inhabits three of these at once: its fourteenth century is a barbaric age of mud, pits, and gibbets, revisited ironically by a modern clerk and poised on the edge of an apocalypse. The date has its own resonance. In February 1300 Pope Boniface VIII proclaimed the first Christian Jubilee, promising plenary indulgence to pilgrims who visited Rome, and Dante set his descent into hell in the spring of the same year. The year of Ash's descent was the year Latin Christendom imagined as a threshold of pardon; Ash arrives in it as a deliverer who wants nothing but to leave.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) argued that modern technology reveals the world as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, inventory on call for further ordering, under the dispensation he named *Gestell*, enframing (Heidegger 1977 [1954]). S-Mart is enframing as a retail format. Ash's heroism is the heroism of inventory: his powers are stock items, his catchphrases are advertising copy, his weapon has a price and an aisle. Heidegger closed his essay with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos" — *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*, "But where danger is, grows / the saving power also" — and the cycle stages that dialectic with unwitting precision: the technology that replaced Ash's hand is the technology that saves him. The comparison with Romero is equally revealing. In *Dawn of the Dead* the shopping mall is where the dead congregate; in *Army of Darkness* the big-box store is where the hero comes from and to which, in the theatrical ending, he returns. Romero's consumers are zombies; Raimi's consumer is the saviour. The film's class politics, moreover, are unambiguous: the retail clerk holds the aristocracy in contempt, addresses the assembled nobility as "primitive screwheads," and is crowned anyway.

5.4 Hero from the Sky: The Descent of Kingship

Evil Dead II ends with Ash hurled through the vortex, with his chainsaw and his car, into a medieval landscape; he blasts a winged Deadite out of the sky, and the knights who witness it kneel and hail him as the one who has come from the skies to deliver them, fulfilling a prophecy illustrated in the Book. Ash screams in refusal. *Army of Darkness* concludes, in its theatrical version, with his self-coronation in the aisles of S-Mart: "Hail to the king, baby."

The vortex that carries Ash and his car to the fourteenth century has a domestic antecedent in the cyclone that carries Dorothy's house to Oz in L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* (1900). Both protagonists fall from the sky; both are hailed as deliverers for having killed a local evil on arrival — Dorothy's house lands on a witch, Ash's shotgun brings down a winged Deadite; and both want nothing but to go home, which requires the right words or gestures. "Klaatu barada nikto" is the cycle's equivalent of the 1939 film's "There's no place like home": a formula of return, which Ash, unlike Dorothy, cannot say properly.

The Sumerian King List, the chronographic text that organised Mesopotamian history into a succession of dynasties, opens with a formula: after kingship descended from heaven (*nam-lugal an-ta e11-de3-a-ba*), the kingship was in Eridu — a line some copies omit, beginning instead with Kish. After the Flood swept over the land, kingship descended from heaven a second time, to Kish (Jacobsen 1939; Black et al. 1998–2006, composition 2.1.1). Kingship, in this ideology, is not a human institution but a thing that falls from the sky upon a city. The cycle's pseudo-Sumerian mythology thus contains, without knowing it, a parody of the most venerable Sumerian political theology. Ash's kingship literally descends from heaven, through a vortex opened by a Sumerian book, upon a besieged medieval city. It is not inherited, conferred, or earned; it falls.

James George Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* with another king: the priest of Diana at Nemi, the *rex Nemorensis* or King of the Wood, a runaway slave who held his office by slaying his predecessor and who prowled perpetually, sword in hand, around a sacred tree, awaiting the man who would slay him in turn. His sovereignty was contingent on perpetual combat and would end the moment his vigour failed (Frazer 1922 [1890]). Ash is the King of the Wood. He keeps watch in a clearing among hostile trees; his title — "Hail to the king" — is held only so long as he can defend it; and in *Ash vs Evil Dead* his vigour is visibly waning, the paunch and the reading glasses of late middle age announcing the Frazerian moment at which the old king must be supplanted. Chapter Seven will argue that the franchise's turn to female protagonists performs precisely this Frazerian succession.

The protagonist's name extends this arboreal kingship into Norse myth. In the *Völuspá* and in Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning*, the gods fashion the first man, Askr — "ash tree" — from a tree found on the shore, and the cosmos is held together by the world-ash Yggdrasil. Whether by design or by the overdetermination of myth, Ash Williams bears the name of the first man made of wood and spends his life fighting a forest. Norse eschatology supplies the rest of his career. In Valhalla the Einherjar, the chosen dead, fight one another every day, fall, and rise every evening to

feast and fight again — an eternal recurrence of combat that is Ash's condition exactly — and at Ragnarök the ship Naglfar, built from the uncut nails of the dead, is loosed for the last battle: the oldest army of darkness in the Germanic imagination, setting out at the end of the world.

Peter Worsley's study of Melanesian cargo cults, *The Trumpet Shall Sound* (1957), documented movements that awaited the arrival from the sky of manufactured goods and of the ancestors or the deliverers who would bring them. *Army of Darkness* inverts the colonial scene: it is medieval Europeans who revere the cargo of a modern American — a shotgun, an automobile, a chemistry book. Released in the season of the first Gulf War's televised celebration of "smart" munitions, the film's slogan, "Shop smart," is difficult not to hear as a satire, conscious or not, of a technological triumphalism in which deliverance falls from the sky.

The messianic structure is, however, ultimately a structure of mistiming. Walter Benjamin's theses "On the Concept of History" (1940) imagined every second of time as the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter, and the angel of history as a figure facing backward toward a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet (Benjamin 1968 [1940]). Kafka, in an aphorism, imagined a Messiah who would come only when no longer necessary — not on the last day but on the very last. The original ending of *Army of Darkness* is the comic realisation of both thoughts: the Hero from the Sky oversleeps the moment of deliverance and awakens upon the wreckage. Behind this ending stands the long tradition of the sleeping king who will wake in the hour of need — Arthur in Avalon, *rex quondam rexque futurus*; Barbarossa beneath the Kyffhäuser — and, more distantly, Gilgamesh, who fails Utnapishtim's test of staying awake for six days and seven nights and thereby forfeits immortality, and Rip Van Winkle, who sleeps through a revolution. Ash belongs to this lineage as its parodic terminus: the once and future king who sets the alarm wrong.

5.5 The Double: Mirror, Shadow, and the Guy with the Gun

In *Evil Dead II* Ash's reflection leaps from the mirror, seizes him by the collar, and informs him that he is not, in fact, fine. Lacan's account of the mirror stage (1949) proposed that the infant jubilantly assumes its specular image as a unified *Gestalt* that anticipates a bodily coherence it does not yet possess, so that the ego is founded upon an alienated image; prior to this unification lies the fantasy of the body in pieces, the *corps morcelé*, which returns in dreams and aggression and which, Lacan remarked, Hieronymus Bosch painted (Lacan 2006 [1949]). The cycle reverses the mirror stage. The mirror image refuses to remain the ego's unifying imago and asserts its autonomy, while the body regresses to the *corps morcelé*: a hand that acts alone, a head that bites, limbs that dance. *Army of Darkness*, whose skeleton army and Deadite grotesques are among cinema's most Boschian images, completes the regression.

In *Army of Darkness* the mirror of a windmill shatters, and from its shards spring miniature Ashes who pin their original to the floor in the manner of Swift's Lilliputians; one of them enters his body through his mouth and grows out of his shoulder as a complete double, which Ash

shoots, dismembers, and buries, and which rises, after the flubbed incantation, to command the army of the dead. The double has a distinguished lineage — Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815), Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846), Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) — and Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) traced its transformation from an archaic insurance against death, the soul as double, into a harbinger of death (Rank 1971 [1914]). Jung named the double the Shadow and made its integration a moral task. Shakespeare gave that task its most famous formulation when Prospero, at the close of *The Tempest*, acknowledges Caliban: "this thing of darkness I / Acknowledge mine."

Ash refuses Prospero's acknowledgment. Confronted with Evil Ash's claim to moral distinction, he replies: "Good, bad, I'm the guy with the gun." The line is the cycle's most compact ethical statement. It declines the moral binary that the double was invented to dramatise and substitutes a technical one: what distinguishes the hero from his shadow is not virtue but armament. This is Hobbes's sovereign, not Jung's integrated self. "Covenants, without the sword, are but words," Hobbes wrote in *Leviathan* (1651); Ash's covenant with the medieval city is guaranteed by a twelve-gauge. The ethics of the augmented body is the ethics of the weapon.

5.6 The Survivor

Elias Canetti's *Crowds and Power* (1960) contains a chapter on the survivor that might have been written for Ash. The moment of survival, Canetti argued, is the moment of power: the satisfaction of standing upright amid the fallen, of having outlived the dead, is the root of the sense of invulnerability that heroes accumulate through repeated survival, and of the ruler's paranoid wish to survive everyone. The survivor's triumph is secret, shameful, and intoxicating; it feeds on the deaths of others (Canetti 1962 [1960]). Canetti also described the dead as the oldest of the "invisible crowds," the multitude that every culture imagines surrounding the living (Canetti 1962 [1960]). Ash, who has outlived his sister, his girlfriend, his friends, his allies of three centuries, and the better part of his hometown, is the survivor in Canetti's sense, and the army of darkness is Canetti's invisible crowd made visible. *Ash vs Evil Dead* registers the survivor's structural guilt with unexpected acuity: returning to his Michigan hometown, Ash discovers that its residents have long believed him the murderer of the friends who died in the cabin and have nicknamed him "Ashy Slashy". The community's suspicion is Canetti's insight in sitcom form. The survivor is always, in some sense, the one who killed the dead.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of a man who may be killed without his killing counting as homicide, yet who may not be sacrificed: a life excluded from both human and divine law and exposed to death without juridical consequence (Agamben 1998 [1995]). Within the films' logic the Deadite occupies exactly this position. It bears a human face and a human name, yet anyone may destroy it, and its destruction is not murder but rescue. Outside that logic, in the law of the town, the same act is homicide. *Ash vs Evil Dead* stages the collision: the residents of Ash's hometown, Elk Grove, Michigan, remem-

ber the dead of 1981, his friends and his sister among them, as his victims, and taunt him with a rhyme, as children once taunted the memory of Lizzie Borden, because the only evidence they ever had was the bodies, and the bodies were human. The liturgy of dismemberment is lawful only inside the rite. Seen from outside it, the survivor is the man who killed his friends.

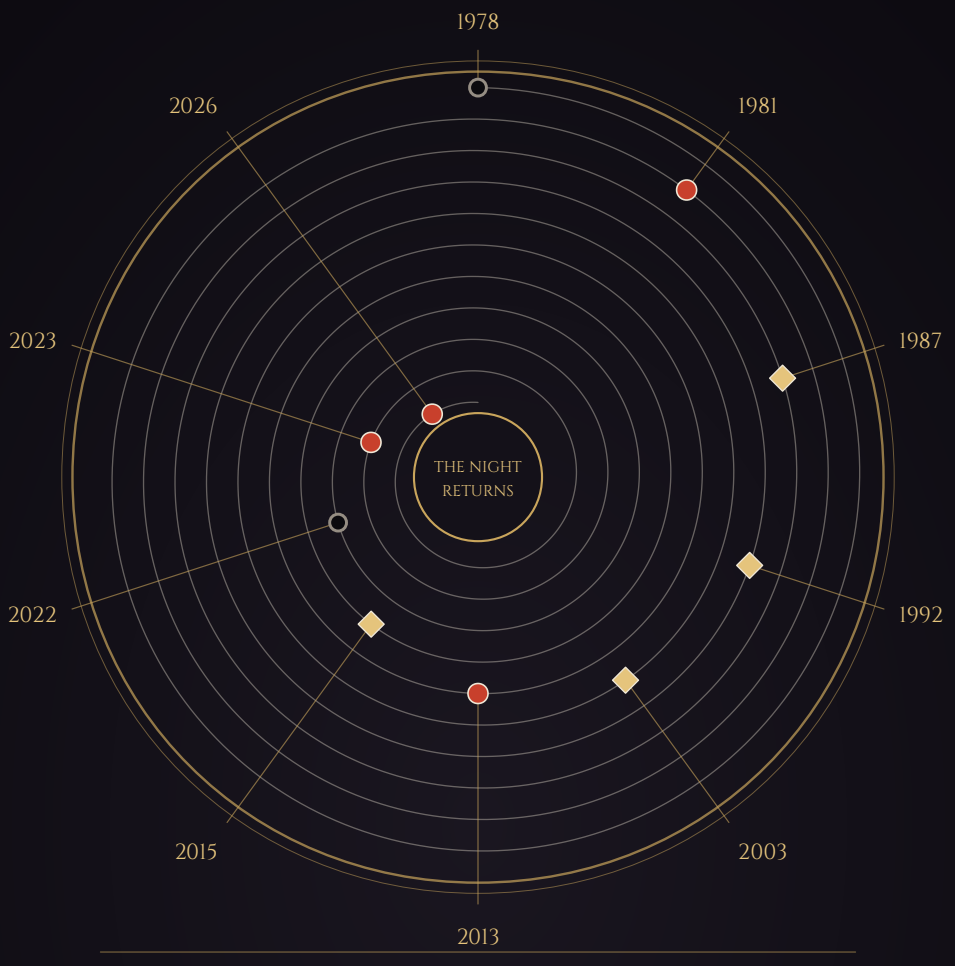
Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) argued that heroism is humanity's fundamental response to the terror of mortality, the attempt to become the cause of oneself and to transcend death through a cultural "hero-system" (Becker 1973). Ash's heroism is a comic hero-system: a repertoire of formulas — "Groovy," "Come get some," "Hail to the king" — through which mortality is not transcended but shrugged off. Joseph Campbell's monomyth, which Christopher Vogler codified for Hollywood screenwriters in *The Writer's Journey* (1992), is parodied station by station in *Army of Darkness*, released the same year: the call and its refusal ("No!"), the supernatural aid of the Wise Man, the belly of the whale in the Deadite pit, the meeting with the goddess in the person of Sheila, the boon of the Book, and the return to the ordinary world in the form of a cash register (Campbell 1949; Vogler 1992). What the monomyth promises above all is transformation; what Ash refuses above all is to be transformed. He returns from his ordeal unchanged, the anti-hero of an anti-*Bildung*.

Critics have long noted that Ash is a rare male survivor in the era of the Final Girl, and Carol Clover argued that the male protagonist of the occult film undergoes an "opening up" — a penetration, a feminisation, an exposure to emotion and the body — that the slasher reserves for women (Clover 1992). Campbell's performance renders the masculine body as a masochistic spectacle: struck, drenched, bitten, impaled, possessed, humiliated, and — in the founding film — sexually assaulted by his girlfriend's headless corpse, his celebrated jaw the target of every assault. The chin becomes the emblem of a masculinity that is heroic only in its capacity to absorb punishment. The cycle's later turn to women, examined in Chapter Seven, does not abandon this body; it bequeaths it.

5.7 Conclusion: The Prosthetic Sovereign

The augmented body is the fourth order of Kandarian Automatism and the human answer to the first three. Its principle may be stated thus: *the human being survives automatism not by recovering the soul that the Force evacuates but by consenting to become a mechanism among mechanisms — prosthetic, technical, forgetful, armed, and comic — and its sovereignty is founded on survival, guaranteed by the weapon, and inaugurated by a mispronounced word.* "Groovy" is the word with which Ash ratifies the arrangement, pronounced at the precise moment the chainsaw is fitted to the stump. The arrangement, however, must be ratified again and again, in film after film, night after night. The next chapter turns to the structure of that repetition.

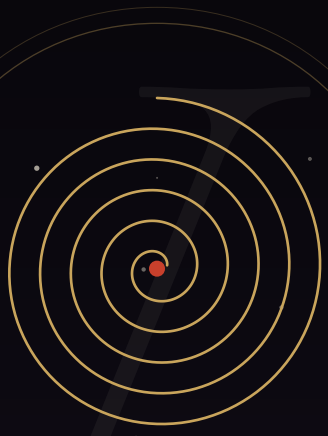




○	1978	*Within the Woods*	●	2013	*Evil Dead*
●	1981	*The Evil Dead*	◆	2015	*Ash vs Evil Dead*
◆	1987	*Evil Dead II*	○	2022	*Evil Dead: The Game*
◆	1992	*Army of Darkness*	●	2023	*Evil Dead Rise*
◆	2003	*Evil Dead: The Musical*	●	2026	*Evil Dead Burn*

"Groovy": from in the groove — a needle tracking a record that returns upon itself.

FIGURE 9 *The groove of recurrence: each entry one turn further in, from 1978 at the rim to 2026 near the centre (Chapter Six).*



CHAPTER SIX

Recurrence

Remake, Return, and the Ontology of the Cabin

The *Evil Dead* cycle has, in nearly half a century, told only one story. A short film told it in 1978; a feature told it again in 1981; a sequel retold it in its first minutes and then told it a third time in 1987; a reboot told it in 2013; a television series returned its aging hero to the scene of the original telling in 2015; and two further features relocated it to a condemned tower in 2023 and a family mansion in 2026. The franchise's defining formal property is return. This chapter argues that recurrence is its formal metaphysics: that its remakes, recaps, and returns enact the eternal recurrence that Nietzsche placed in the mouth of a demon; that Ash's "Groovy" is that recurrence affirmed; that the cabin is the place where recurrence happens, a dwelling whose uncanniness Heidegger and Bachelard illuminate; and that the cycle's afterlives in catchphrases, games, and midnight screenings extend the recurrence into the lives of its audience. The remake is not the franchise's commercial afterthought. It is the rite reperformed.

6.1 The Recap That Lies

Evil Dead II begins by repeating its predecessor, and the repetition is false. Unable to license footage from the first film, whose distribution rights Irvin Shapiro had sold piecemeal to distributors around the world, the production restaged its events in a compressed prologue that reduces the five students to a couple, recasts Linda, and arrives within minutes at the moment of possession from which the sequel continues. The audience that knew *The Evil Dead* watched it remembered wrongly; the audience that did not watched a past that never quite occurred. Popular criticism has since coined the portmanteau *requel* for such hybrids, and Constantine Verevis has shown that the remake is at once an industrial category, a textual relation, and a critical construction, never simply a copy (Verevis 2006).

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) offers a more exacting vocabulary. Its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, distinguishes recollection, which is repeated backward, from repetition, which is recollected forward: recollection retrieves what has been, while repetition moves toward what is to come, and repetition alone, if it is possible, gives a life its earnestness. Constantius tests the hypothesis by returning to Berlin to relive a former visit and finds that nothing repeats; the book's young man finds repetition only in a Job-like restoration that he receives rather than achieves (Kierkegaard 1983 [1843]). The prologue of *Evil Dead II* is a repetition recollected forward. It does not preserve the past; it revises it in the direction of what the sequel requires, as though the first night had always already been the beginning of the second. Every subsequent entry repeats the founding night in the same manner: forward, with differences, toward a future that needs the past to be retold.

Evil Dead Rise builds the recurrence into its structure. Its prologue at a lake cabin, in which a possessed young woman kills her companions, is revealed at the end of the film to take place the day after the main action: she is a neighbour in the tower, leaving for the lake. The film's first scene is its last, and its form is a loop.

6.2 The Demon of Eternal Recurrence

In section 341 of *The Gay Science* (1882), headed "The greatest weight," Nietzsche introduced the thought of eternal recurrence as a nocturnal visitation. What if, he asks, some day or night a demon were to steal after you into your loneliest loneliness and tell you that this life, as you now live it and have lived it, you will have to live once more and innumerable times more, with nothing new in it, every pain and every joy returning in the same succession? Would you throw yourself down, gnash your teeth, and curse the demon who spoke thus? Or have you once experienced a tremendous moment in which you would answer him that he is a god and that you have never heard anything more divine? (Nietzsche 1974 [1882]).

The Kandarian demon is Nietzsche's demon. It comes at night, in the loneliest loneliness of an isolated dwelling, and its message is recurrence: the dead will return, the night will return, the possession of the beloved will return, and the survivor will be required to live it all again. The franchise distributes the two Nietzschean responses across its protagonist's career. The Ash of 1981 gnashes his teeth; the film ends on his scream. The Ash of 1987, hailed by medieval knights as the prophesied deliverer, screams "No!" at a prophecy that condemns him to repeat the ordeal in another century. But between these screams lies the moment at which the chainsaw is fitted to the stump and Ash, regarding his new body, pronounces it "Groovy." In *Ecce Homo* (1888) Nietzsche gave his formula for greatness in a human being as *amor fati*: to want nothing to be different, not forward, not backward, not in all eternity — not merely to bear what is necessary, still less to conceal it, but to love it (Nietzsche 1967 [1888]). "Groovy" is *amor fati* in the vernacular of the American 1970s, the word with which a man who has just sawed off his own hand declares that he wants nothing to be different.

Thus Spoke Zarathustra (1883–1885) gives the affirmation of recurrence a physical image that the cycle reproduces with uncanny fidelity. In "On the Vision and the Riddle," Zarathustra sees a young shepherd choking on a black snake that has crawled into his throat; at Zarathustra's cry, the shepherd bites off its head, spits it out, and springs up — no longer shepherd, no longer human, but transfigured, radiant, laughing as no human being has ever laughed (Nietzsche 1954 [1883–1885]). The snake is the nausea of recurrence, the thought that everything returns, the small and the contemptible included. The laughing room of *Evil Dead II* is the shepherd with the snake still in his throat: Ash's laughter there is hysterical and convulsive, a nausea that has taken the form of mirth. The fitting of the chainsaw is the bite. And "Groovy" is the transfigured laughter on the far side — no longer quite human, a laughter partly mechanical, issued by a man who is now partly a machine. Zarathustra declared that he would believe only in a god who knew how to dance (Nietzsche 1954 [1883–1885]). The only being in the cycle who dances with divine grace is a headless corpse.

6.3 Fort-Da with the Book

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) confronted phenomena of repetition that the pleasure principle could not explain: the traumatic dreams of soldiers, which return them compulsively to the scene of their shock, and the game of an eighteen-month-old boy who threw a wooden reel on a string out of his cot with a long "o-o-o-o" — *fort*, gone — and drew it back with a joyful *da*, there. The child, Freud suggested, was mastering his mother's departures by repeating them actively. From such evidence Freud inferred a compulsion to repeat that overrides the pleasure principle and speculated that it expresses a drive more fundamental than the drive toward pleasure: an urge inherent in organic life to restore an earlier state of things, the inorganic condition from which life arose. The aim of all life, he concluded, is death (Freud 1955 [1920]).

The franchise's relation to its Book is a cosmic *fort-da*. The Book is thrown into the fire at the end of the first film — gone — and lies on the table at the beginning of the second — there. It is lost through a portal, recovered from a graveyard, wrapped in barbed wire in a cellar, sealed in a vault beneath a parking garage, and announced anew in a dead grandfather's recordings. Each entry stages the Book's disappearance and return; each repeats the trauma of the founding night in order, perhaps, to master it, and fails. *Ash vs Evil Dead* makes the compulsion explicit by returning its protagonist, more than three decades after 1981, to the very cabin in which his friends died, to reenact a night that his hometown remembers as a crime. The Deadites' perpetual invitation — *join us* — is the death drive's own voice, the call to return to the inanimate collectivity from which life emerged; and their sadism illustrates Freud's later contention that the death drive, silent in itself, becomes perceptible chiefly when it is turned outward as aggression against others.

6.4 Ritual Time and the Terror of History

Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) argued that archaic societies abolished profane, irreversible time by periodically repeating the archetypal acts of creation in ritual, thereby regenerating time and protecting themselves from what Eliade called the terror of history — the experience, characteristic of modernity, of an irreversible succession of events devoid of archetypal meaning (Eliade 1954 [1949]). Eliade's privileged example was Mesopotamian: the Babylonian New Year festival, the *akītu*, during which the *Enūma eliš* was recited and Marduk's victory over the chaos-monster Tiamat ritually renewed (Bidmead 2002).

The *akītu* preserves a detail of singular relevance to the cycle. According to the surviving ritual text, on the fifth day of the festival the king entered the temple of Marduk, where the high priest stripped him of his regalia, struck him on the cheek, and pulled his ears; the king knelt and declared his innocence before the god, and if the blow drew tears, the omen was favourable and his kingship was renewed (Bidmead 2002). Mesopotamian royal ideology required that the king be ritually slapped in order to remain king. The franchise's sovereign is a man repeatedly struck in the face — by Deadites, by his own hand, by the camera — and then crowned. The slapstick of

kingship is not, in the cycle, a degradation of the archetype but its unwitting restoration: the king renews his sovereignty by being hit.

The ritual text, a late first-millennium copy, is more exact than this summary. The high priest strikes the king twice: once on removing his insignia, and again after returning them, when the second blow is read as an omen — if tears flow, Bēl is content; if they do not, an enemy will arise and bring about the king's downfall. Between the blows the king recites a negative confession, swearing among other things that he has not struck the cheek of those under his protection (Linssen 2004; Mirelman 2022). The sovereign receives the blow he swears he has never dealt. *Evil Dead II* fuses priest and king in one body: Ash's own hand, possessed, slaps his face and breaks crockery over his head, so that the king is struck by himself and the rite of humiliation becomes a solo act.

The cycle's structure oscillates between Eliade's two temporalities. The cabin is ritual time: the same night, the same Book, the same dawn, returning without development. Whenever the franchise leaves the cabin for history — 1300 in *Army of Darkness*, the ruined future of that film's original ending and of the final episode of *Ash vs Evil Dead* — it encounters the terror of history: irreversible catastrophe, apocalypse, a world that cannot be restored. Ash's desperate wish throughout *Army of Darkness* is not to save the medieval world but to go home: to return from historical time to the ritual time of the store, where every day is the same day. S-Mart is the cycle's profane analogue of Eliade's sacred repetition.

6.5 Difference and Repetition

Gilles Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) reread Nietzsche's eternal return as the return not of the same but of difference: what returns is never identical, repetition is the very production of the new, and the eternal return is selective, admitting only what affirms (Deleuze 1994 [1968]). Linda Hutcheon's account of parody as repetition with critical difference, and her later account of adaptation as repetition without replication, translate Deleuze's ontology into the vocabulary of textual relations (Hutcheon 1985; Hutcheon 2006). The franchise is a sustained experiment in selective return. Certain elements always return — the Book, the recording, the Force, the possession of the beloved, the dismemberment, the chainsaw, the dawn — while others return intermittently or not at all: the laughter, the hero, the cabin itself. What the eternal return of the *Evil Dead* selects is the rite; what it allows to vary is everything else.

Drew Goddard's *The Cabin in the Woods* (2012), co-written with Joss Whedon, made this selectivity its subject. Five young people travel to a remote cabin; in its cellar one of them reads aloud a Latin incantation from a dead girl's diary, summoning a family of zombified torturers. The film then reveals that the cabin is a stage managed by a technocratic organisation that engineers the ordeal as a ritual sacrifice, prescribing archetypal roles — the Whore, the Athlete, the Scholar, the Fool, the Virgin — whose deaths in proper order appease ancient gods sleeping beneath the earth. When the last survivors refuse to complete the sacrifice, the gods rise and the

world ends. *The Cabin in the Woods* is the most acute critical reading the cycle has received, and it was delivered as a film. It recognises that the cabin-in-the-woods scenario is a rite, that the horror film is its liturgy, that its roles are archetypal and its sequence fixed, and that its purpose is to propitiate powers whose waking would end the world. The morphology of the Kandarian rite proposed in Chapter One is, in this sense, the scholarly prose of what Goddard and Whedon dramatised.

6.6 The Ontology of the Cabin

In section 40 of *Being and Time* (1927), Heidegger argued that anxiety discloses the fundamental condition of human existence as *Unheimlichkeit*: uncanniness, or, literally, not-being-at-home. Everyday familiarity is a flight from this condition, and anxiety returns Dasein from its absorption in the world to the recognition that it is never truly at home in it (Heidegger 1962 [1927]). In "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951) Heidegger proposed dwelling as the basic character of human being, offering as his exemplar a farmhouse in the Black Forest, built by the dwelling of peasants, which gathered earth, sky, divinities, and mortals into a single place (Heidegger 1971 [1951]). Heidegger himself thought and wrote in a mountain hut at Todtnauberg and explained, in a short text of 1934, why he chose to remain in the provinces.

The *Evil Dead* cabin is the anti-Todtnauberg. It is a hut in the forest in which dwelling becomes impossible, in which *Unheimlichkeit* is not an existential mood disclosed by anxiety but an ontological fact enforced by the house itself. Its walls bleed, its lamps convulse, its trapdoor imprisons the dead, its mirror attacks; the dwelling turns upon its dweller. The real cabin, as its makers recall, had to be cleared of manure before filming and offered no shelter from the Tennessee winter (Eisenberg 2023). Heidegger's hut was the site of authentic thought; Raimi's cabin is the site at which thought is replaced by mechanism.

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) supplies the cabin's vertical psychology. The house, Bachelard argued, is a vertical being polarised between the rationality of the roof and attic, where thoughts are clear, and the irrationality of the cellar, the dark entity of the house, which partakes of subterranean forces and in which even a dweller with electric light carries a candle in imagination (Bachelard 1964 [1958]). The cycle's cellar is Bachelard's cellar raised to the condition of a demonology. It is where the Book and the recorder are found in 1981, where the possessed sister is confined beneath a trapdoor, where Henrietta lies, where the 2013 Book waits among the hanging carcasses of cats. *Evil Dead Rise* extends the vertical axis into the urban tower: the earthquake that opens the parking garage reveals a sealed vault beneath the building, the cellar of cellars, and the elevator that connects its strata becomes the conduit of possession and, in an homage to *The Shining*, a vessel brimming with blood. J. G. Ballard's *High-Rise* (1975), in which the residents of a luxury tower regress floor by floor into tribal violence, supplies the precedent; *Evil Dead Rise* replaces Ballard's affluent residents with a precarious family in a building already condemned. *Evil Dead Burn*'s decaying mansion completes the series with the

oldest Gothic architecture of all, the family seat in which, as in Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839), house and lineage are a single body collapsing together.

Mikhail Bakhtin's essay on the chronotope identified in Dostoevsky a "chronotope of the threshold," in which time is the time of crisis and decision and space is the space of doorways, staircases, and corridors (Bakhtin 1981 [1937–1938]). The cycle's chronotope is the threshold chronotope extended across a single night. Its drama transpires at doors, windows, trapdoors, and the edge of the clearing; its time is the crisis-time that ends at dawn. The cabin is less a building than a threshold given walls.

6.7 Relics and Respawns

Recurrence does not end at the borders of the films. In Umberto Eco's account of cult cinema, a cult object is loved not as a whole but as a collection of detachable parts: it must be, in some sense, ramshackle, so that its fragments can be quoted, remembered, and exchanged by devotees independently of the whole (Eco 1986 [1984]). The cycle's reception is the purest instance of this disassembly. "Groovy," "This is my boomstick," "Klaatu barada nikto," and "Hail to the king, baby" circulate as detachable fragments, recited at screenings, printed on merchandise, quoted in other works. In 1981, the year of *The Evil Dead*, Peter Brown published *The Cult of the Saints*, which showed how the late-antique Church distributed the divided bodies of the holy dead across the Mediterranean world, each fragment a relic charged with the whole saint's power (Brown 1981). Cult reception is a liturgy of dismemberment practised upon the films themselves: the devotee carries home a fragment of the body, and the fragment is potent.

The cult's patron, in this respect, is Titivillus. The verse that describes his labour takes its terms from John 6:12, the command to gather up the fragments so that nothing be lost (Chapter Two). The devotee who collects the cycle's fragments — catchphrases, props, single frames — performs Titivillus's office in reverse: not to accuse the speakers at the Judgment, but to keep a film's dropped words from being lost.

The franchise's ludic afterlife literalises recurrence still further. The first-person shooters of the 1990s borrowed its weapons and its words: *Doom* (1993), which John Carmack conceived as a game about using technology to fight demons — the prosthetic sovereignty of Chapter Five made into a genre — by crossing *Aliens* with *Evil Dead II* (Kushner 2003), armed its marine with a chainsaw and, in its sequel, a double-barrelled shotgun, while *Duke Nukem 3D* (1996) put Ash's catchphrases — "Groovy," "Hail to the king, baby," "Come get some" — into its hero's mouth. Campbell called the game's makers "rip-off artists" (MobyGames n.d.): the relic had been carried off by another cult. *Evil Dead: The Game* (2022) closes the circuit. In the video game, death is not an end but a reset; the player dies, respawns, and the same night begins again. The game is eternal recurrence as an industrial format, and its player's only freedom is the Nietzschean one: to affirm the night once more. Ash, the hero who cannot die because his story always restarts, is the patron saint of the respawn.

6.8 Conclusion: The Form Is the Metaphysics

The franchise's recurrences — the recap that lies, the remake, the return to the cabin, the circulation of fragments, the respawn — are not symptoms of commercial exhaustion. They are the form in which the cycle's metaphysics exists. A demon announces recurrence; a survivor affirms it; a cabin houses it; a rite is reperformed; its fragments are venerated; its night is played again. What remains to be asked is who performs the rite once its first officiant has retired. The next chapter turns to the heirs.



1978 · WITHIN THE WOODS

a woman left standing

ASH WILLIAMS

the sovereign survivor, 1981–2018

MIA

2013 · the addict

BETH

2023 · the guardian

ALICE

2026 · the wife

INHERIT



THE STUMP · THE CHAINSAW · THE DOUBLE · THE RITE



~~THE LAUGHTER~~

not inherited — or not yet

From sovereignty to care: the heirs inherit guardianship, not kingship.

FIGURE 10 *Inheritance: what passes from the sovereign survivor to his heirs, and what does not (§7.5).*



CHAPTER SEVEN

The Matrilineal Turn

Addiction, Motherhood, and the Inheritance of the Chainsaw

From 2013 the cycle's survivors are women, its possessed are increasingly kin, and its ordeal has moved from the bachelors' weekend to the family's crisis: an addicted sister's detoxification in 2013, a single mother's household in 2023, a wife's marriage and in-laws in 2026. This chapter argues that the matrilineal turn is not a belated concession to the era of the Final Girl but the completion of the mythos' own logic. It returns the cycle to the configuration of its prototype; it works through the rape of a woman's body with which the founding film began; it transforms the sovereign survival of Chapter Five into inheritance and guardianship; and it brings possession home, so that what the demon now possesses is the family itself — the addicted sibling, the devouring mother, the abusive husband. The liturgy of dismemberment becomes, in these films, the dismemberment of the family. And one element of the patrimony is conspicuously not inherited: the laughter.

7.1 From Final Girl to Final Heir

Carol Clover's Final Girl — the watchful, resourceful, sexually reticent young woman who alone survives the slasher's massacre and turns the killer's weapon against him — became the decisive concept of feminist horror criticism. Clover argued that the Final Girl functioned for the genre's predominantly young male audience as a congenial double, a figure through whom male viewers could experience abjection and terror at a safe remove of gender, while the occult film subjected its male protagonist to an "opening up" that the slasher reserved for women (Clover 1992). Ash occupied the Final Girl's structural position as a man, and critics have noted the rarity, in the era that defined that figure, of a male protagonist still alive at the credits (Eisenberg 2023).

The matrilineal turn restores the position to women but transforms it. Mia, Beth, and Alice are neither virginal nor boyish nor watchful in Clover's sense. They are defined by their relations to the institutions of kinship — sister, mother, wife — and by their capacity to survive those relations. They are, in the vocabulary this dissertation proposes, not final girls but *final heirs*: inheritors of a wound, a weapon, and a rite. The turn is also a return. In *Within the Woods* (1978) Bruce Campbell played the possessed and a woman was the last left standing, though the final shot leaves her fate open; the feature of 1981 reversed the configuration, and the later films reverse it back. Recurrence, here as everywhere in the cycle, returns with a difference: what was a prototype's casting becomes, decades later, a programme.

7.2 Mia: Addiction as Possession

Fede Álvarez's *Evil Dead* (2013) brings Mia, a heroin addict, to her family's cabin to quit cold turkey, supervised by her estranged brother David, his girlfriend, and two friends, one of them a nurse, who have pledged to keep her there however she pleads. When the possession begins, it is read as withdrawal. Mia's terror, her flight, her account of an assault in the woods, her insistence that something is in the cabin are interpreted, by the nurse's clinical knowledge and her friends'

resolve, as the symptoms of dependency. Her warnings, like Cassandra's in Aeschylus's *Agamemnon*, are true and disbelieved.

Tzvetan Todorov defined the fantastic as the hesitation, experienced by a reader who knows only the laws of nature, between a natural and a supernatural explanation of apparently supernatural events; when the hesitation resolves toward the natural, the text passes into the uncanny, and when it resolves toward the supernatural, into the marvellous (Todorov 1973 [1970]). The cycle's earlier entries are marvellous from the first reel. The 2013 film is the only entry to sustain a Todorovian hesitation — withdrawal or possession? — before collapsing into the marvellous, and the hesitation is its argument. Addiction is possession: a craving that inhabits the body, speaks with the beloved's voice, lies, pleads, and turns upon those who try to help. The cabin as rehabilitation, an isolation undertaken for therapy, becomes the isolation of the siege.

The history of possession has always been a contest of discourses over the possessed body. Michel de Certeau's study of the possessions at Loudun (1634) showed how the speech of the possessed nuns — a speech of the other, in which no proper name could be stabilised — was contested by theologians and physicians, each claiming the authority to name what spoke through them (de Certeau 2000 [1970]). Jean-Martin Charcot and Paul Richer's *Les Démoniaques dans l'art* (1887) completed the medical appropriation by rereading centuries of artistic depictions of demoniacs as clinical images of hysteria (Charcot and Richer 1887). The 2013 film inverts Charcot. What medicine names as illness is in truth possession; the nurse's diagnosis is the Book's alibi. I. M. Lewis's comparative study of ecstatic religion argued that peripheral possession allows subordinated persons, frequently women, to voice grievances their social position otherwise silences (Lewis 1971). Mia's possessed speech is in this sense also the speech of grievance: the demon, speaking through her, exploits the siblings' history of abandonment, saying through her what she had not said.

The film's remedies make it the cycle's theological turning point. Its Book prescribes purification by live burial, dismemberment, or fire, and David chooses burial. He buries his sister alive — the punishment Creon decreed for Antigone, the figure Lacan placed between two deaths — and then exhumes her and restarts her heart with an improvised defibrillator. The scene fuses the oldest and newest technologies of the boundary between life and death: Antigone's living tomb, and the galvanic resurrection that Luigi Galvani's experiments on frogs inaugurated, that Giovanni Aldini performed in 1803 upon the corpse of a man hanged in London, and that Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) made the founding myth of modern science fiction. Mia returns purified, herself again. For the first time in the cycle, possession is reversed and a Deadite saved — not by grace, prayer, or exorcism, but by ritual and electricity, and by the sacrificial death of a brother who does not survive the night. Redemption re-enters Kandarian Automatism, but it enters as technique.

David's burial of his sister has a literary antecedent in Poe's "The Premature Burial" (1844), whose narrator, obsessed with the dread of being interred alive, fits out his family vault with devices that would let him signal and escape. The 2013 film converts that dread into a rite: a buri-

al undertaken deliberately, by a brother, so that its victim can be dug up again purified. Poe's nightmare becomes the cycle's sacrament.

Then the inheritance is enacted. Pinned by her hand beneath an overturned vehicle, Mia tears the hand away and meets the Abomination — a creature in her own likeness, risen from the earth in a rain of blood — with a chainsaw. Two elements of the patrimony pass to her in a single sequence: the stump and the saw. A third, the double, is reconfigured. The Abomination that wears Mia's face is the addicted self that recovery must destroy, a double that the survivor, like Ash before her, refuses to acknowledge as her own. Ash appears only in a post-credits coda, pronouncing his word — a patriarch's benediction, or a ghost's.

The 2013 film also distributes Ash's self-mutilation across its whole cast. Natalie, David's girlfriend, bitten on the hand by the possessed Mia and feeling the possession climb her arm, cuts the arm off herself with an electric carving knife; Olivia, the nurse, once possessed, slices her own face with a shard of broken mirror. The instruments are domestic — a kitchen appliance, a bathroom mirror — and possession turns the household's equipment against the bodies it serves, as *Evil Dead Burn* will later turn a family's heirlooms into weapons. The hand that Ash severed in 1987 becomes in 2013 a general condition: every body in the cabin is a body that must cut itself.

7.3 Ellie: The Devouring Mother

Lee Cronin's *Evil Dead Rise* (2023) relocates the rite to a decaying Los Angeles apartment tower slated for demolition. Beth, a guitar technician who has just learned she is pregnant and is uncertain whether she wants to be a mother, visits her estranged sister Ellie, a tattoo artist raising three children alone. An earthquake opens the floor of the building's garage onto a sealed vault; Ellie's son Danny retrieves the Book and a set of old records and plays them; and Ellie is possessed. The film's ordeal is the siege of a family by its mother.

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) argued that horror's monstrous women — the archaic mother, the monstrous womb, the possessed girl of *The Exorcist* — figure the abjection of the maternal body from which the subject must separate in order to become a subject, building on Kristeva's account of the mother as the first abject (Creed 1993; Kristeva 1982 [1980]). Ellie is Creed's archaic mother in her most extreme form: the mother who devours. Her possessed body contorts, mocks, bites, and announces its own decomposition; she possesses her children and fuses with them until the family becomes a single composite creature — a mother-and-children body that recalls the giants assembled from bound citizens in Clive Barker's "In the Hills, the Cities" (1984) and the fused flesh of John Carpenter's *The Thing* (1982). The family, in *Evil Dead Rise*, is literally a body, and it is a monster.

The mythic antecedents are precise. In Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE), Agave, possessed by Dionysus, leads the women of Thebes in tearing apart her son Pentheus and carries his head home believing it a lion's; only when the possession lifts does she recognise what she has done. *Evil Dead Rise* is the *Bacchae* without the recognition: the possessed mother never returns to know

her act and must be destroyed instead. Greek legend knew Lamia, the queen whose children Hera destroyed and who became a devourer of the children of others — the name Raimi gave to the demon of *Drag Me to Hell* (2009). Mesopotamia knew Lamashtu, daughter of the sky god Anu, a demoness who attacked pregnant women, caused miscarriage, seized newborns, and afflicted nursing mothers; amulets bearing the image of the demon Pazuzu were worn to repel her (Wiggermann 2000; Farber 2014). Pazuzu is, of course, the demon of *The Exorcist*. In Mesopotamian practice, then, the antagonist of Friedkin's film was the protector of mothers and infants against the devouring maternal demon. *Evil Dead Rise*, in which a possessed mother threatens her children and her pregnant sister, arrives at last in the authentic domain of Mesopotamian maternal demonology — the domain of Lamashtu — toward which the franchise's pseudo-Sumerian mythology had always gestured. The figure of Lilith, the first wife turned child-killing demon in the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, belongs to the same transcultural type.

Beth's arc answers Ellie's. The film divides the maternal in two: the possessed mother, whose motherhood has become predation, and the elective mother, whose motherhood is chosen under siege. Beth ends the night as the guardian of her surviving niece, having taken a chainsaw to the composite body in which her sister and her sister's children are fused. Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* (1989) defined mothering as a practice organised around preservation, the fostering of growth, and training for social acceptability, independent of the biological fact of birth (Ruddick 1989). Beth's night is maternal thinking reduced to its first imperative, preservation, and performed with the tools of the liturgy of dismemberment. To preserve the child, the guardian must dismember the family.

7.4 Alice: The Marriage That Outlives the Husband

Evil Dead Burn (2026) carries the rite into marriage. Its protagonist, Alice, is a Frenchwoman married to William Price, a volatile chef; flashbacks reveal that she has survived his abuse, and she is held at a distance by his family, whose patriarch, Edgar, is openly hostile to her foreignness (Li 2026). William's death in a drunken crash does not free her. Possessed in the wreck, he rises from his coffin at the crematorium, and the family's descent into slaughter at its decaying mansion is driven by a dead husband whose violence has survived him (Li 2026).

The legal history of marriage supplies the film's deepest intertext. William Blackstone's *Commentaries on the Laws of England* (1765) summarised the common-law doctrine of coverture in terms that read, after *Evil Dead Burn*, as a definition of possession: by marriage husband and wife are one person in law, and "the very being or legal existence of the woman is suspended during the marriage," incorporated and consolidated into that of the husband (Blackstone 1765). Coverture was juridical possession, the wife's personhood occupied by her husband's. The marriage service of the Book of Common Prayer bound the spouses "till death us do part." *Evil Dead Burn* imagines the failure of that limit. Death does not part; the husband's will continues to occupy the marriage after his death, as possession continues to occupy a body after the person has

left it. Evan Stark's analysis of coercive control as the abuser's colonisation of the victim's life-space, rather than a series of discrete assaults, describes the structure the film renders supernatural (Stark 2007). The Deadite husband is coercive control outliving its agent.

The film's other elements confirm the reading. The interrupted cremation repeats, in an industrial crematorium, the interrupted funerals of Chapter Four, and the film's title translates that of the Mesopotamian anti-sorcery ritual *Maqlû*, "Burning": the rite that must be completed is a burning. The curse is released by the reel-to-reel recordings of a patriarch, the grandfather professor, so that the matrilineal heir must survive a patrilineal archive. And the house's inventory becomes an armoury. Reviewers noted that the film plants a series of domestic objects — a weed trimmer, a candlestick, a bottle opener, a dinner fork, kebab skewers, an expensive fountain pen, the grandmother's wooden prosthetic foot — each later employed in some grisly exchange, before the chainsaw the franchise requires appears at its conclusion (Li 2026). The S-Mart inventory of *Army of Darkness* returns as the family's heirlooms, and the prosthesis passes, at last, to the oldest woman in the house. Julia Kristeva's *Strangers to Ourselves* (1988) argued that the foreigner reveals the strangeness every community harbours within itself (Kristeva 1991 [1988]). Alice, the stranger in the family, is the one through whom the family's demons become visible.

The film's treatment of gendered violence marks the end of a trajectory begun in 1981. The founding film's possession began with the rape of a woman by the forest; the 2013 remake reinstated it at its producer's request; *Evil Dead Burn*, by its reviewers' account, contains domestic violence but no sexual assault (Li 2026). Across the matrilineal turn the founding violation recedes, and violence relocates to the domestic sphere, where, the later films imply, it was all along. *Evil Dead Burn* also completes the inversion of the prototype: its driving possession passes from a woman to a man, and the woman's ordeal is to survive what the demon has made of her husband.

7.5 Inheritance and Care

Ash's survival was sovereign. In Canetti's terms he was the survivor standing upright among the dead, his power the residue of their deaths; in Hobbes's, the guy with the gun; in Frazer's, the King of the Wood, holding his title by perpetual combat. The heirs survive differently. Mia survives through her brother's sacrifice; Beth survives as the guardian of a child not her own; Alice's ordeal is the survival of a marriage. The matrilineal turn performs the Frazerian succession that Chapter Five anticipated — the waning king supplanted — but the successors do not claim the crown. There is no "Hail to the queen." The heirs inherit guardianship, not kingship.

The feminist ethics of care, from Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) through Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) to Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993), described a moral orientation grounded in relationships of responsibility and in practices of attending to particular others rather than in abstract rights and sovereign autonomy (Gilligan 1982; Noddings 1984; Tronto 1993). The heirs' liturgy of dismemberment is performed in the service of such responsibility: to

save a niece, to end a family's possession, to survive a husband. The weapon is the same; its ethical orientation has changed from sovereignty to care.

What the heirs do not inherit is as significant as what they do. They inherit the stump, the chainsaw, the double, and the rite. They do not inherit the joke. No heir says "Groovy"; the matrilineal entries are, by broad critical consent, the franchise's grimmest, and a reviewer of *Evil Dead Burn* found it lacking the charm and goofiness of the Raimi films (Li 2026). The turn from sovereignty to care has been, so far, a turn from laughter to endurance. Whether this marks the end of the Groovy Sublime or its transformation is the question with which the next chapter concludes.

7.6 Conclusion: Possession Comes Home

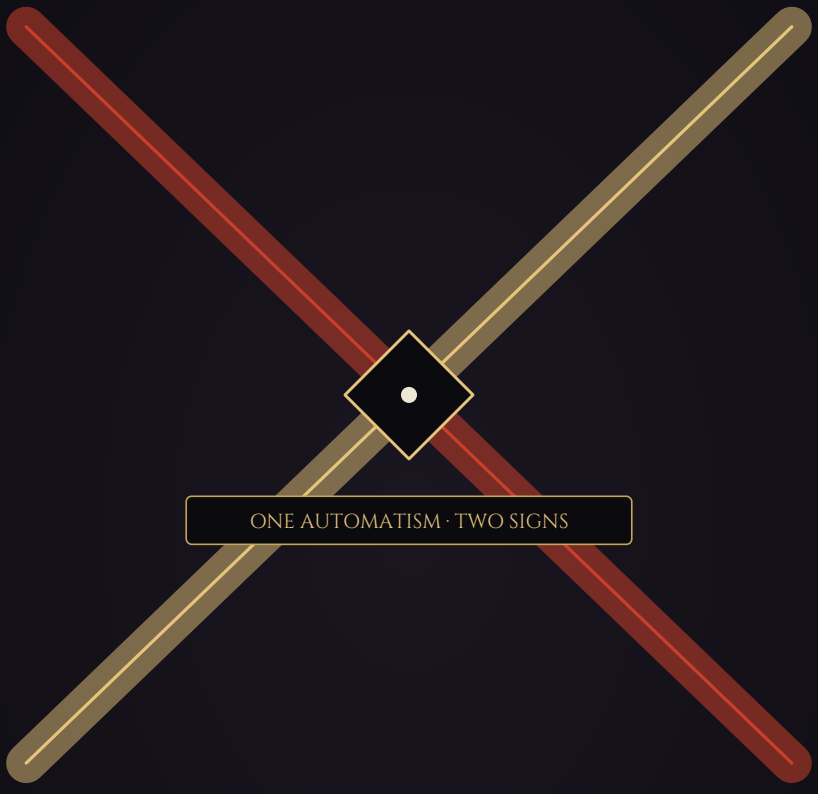
The matrilineal turn completes the mythos. Possession, which began in a stranger's cabin, has come home: into the addicted body, the maternal body, the marital bond. The survivor, who began as a king, has become an heir and a guardian. The liturgy of dismemberment, which began as the destruction of a beloved's body, has become the dismemberment of the family itself, performed so that something of the family can survive. The chainsaw has been handed down. The laughter has not — or not yet.

COMEDY

IN THE PLACE OF THE MECHANISM

the chainsaw fitted to the arm

THE MECHANISM



Linda's body dancing without Linda

IN THE PLACE OF THE HUMAN

THE HUMAN

HORROR

Bergson: "something mechanical encrusted upon the living."

FIGURE 11 *One automatism, two signs: the chiasmus of horror and comedy (§8.2).*



CHAPTER EIGHT

The Groovy Sublime

Toward a Necro-Comic Metaphysics

The preceding chapters isolated four orders of automatism and traced their recurrence and inheritance. This chapter assembles them. It states the metaphysics of Kandarian Automatism as a set of theses; it proposes, on that basis, a theory of horror-comedy that explains how the cycle can pass from scream to slapstick without changing its world; it situates the cycle within the Western tradition of comic demonology; and it defines the Groovy Sublime — the aesthetic and ethical posture the cycle elaborates in response to its own metaphysics — against the classical sublime, the carnivalesque, and the pessimism of contemporary philosophy of horror. It closes by asking whether the matrilineal turn's abandonment of laughter marks the Groovy Sublime's end or its migration.

8.1 Six Theses of Kandarian Automatism

The cycle's immanent metaphysics may be reconstructed as six theses.

1. **Evil is plenitude, not privation.** Augustine resolved the problem of evil by denying it substance: evil is the privation of good, as darkness is the absence of light (*Confessions* VII; *Enchiridion* 11). The cycle's evil is the opposite of an absence. The Force is pure presence, energy, velocity, and pressure; it fills bodies as water fills a vessel. Nor is the cycle Manichaean, since no principle of light opposes its darkness. It is a monism of the demonic in which the good has no metaphysical standing at all — only the improvised resistance of human beings.
2. **The person is an occupant, not an essence.** A body is a dwelling that may be vacated and reoccupied. The cycle's ontology of the person is homologous with its ontology of the house: both are structures whose inhabitants can be expelled and replaced.
3. **Language, perception, and embodiment operate without subjects.** The incantation works without understanding, the gaze sees without a seer, the body moves without a mind. These are the automatic word, eye, and body of Chapters Two to Four.
4. **The dead are creditors.** The relation between the living and the dead is an economy of debt regulated by funerary rites; when the rites fail, the dead return to collect.
5. **Time is recurrence.** The night returns. History, when the cycle enters it, is catastrophe.
6. **The only available sovereignty is technical and comic.** The human being survives not by recovering the soul but by becoming a mechanism, and endures that becoming by laughing at it.

These theses invite comparison with ancient Gnosticism, in which the cosmos is governed by malevolent archons and salvation comes through a saving knowledge, *gnosis*, from beyond it (Jonas 1958). The cycle's Dark Ones resemble archons, but its Book is an anti-gnosis: a knowledge from beyond that damns rather than saves. Where the Gnostic escapes the cosmos by knowing, the cycle's survivor endures it by doing — sawing, shooting, burning — and the only knowledge that helps him is the knowledge printed in a chemistry textbook.

8.2 One Automatism, Two Signs: A Theory of Horror-Comedy

Noël Carroll's "Horror and Humor" (1999) argued that the two genres share a structure: both trade in the transgression of categories, concepts, and norms, the monster and the comic grotesque alike being incongruous, interstitial beings. What distinguishes them is affective framing. In horror the incongruity is accompanied by threat and disgust; in comic amusement it is enjoyed because, for the moment, it threatens no one we care about (Carroll 1999). Bergson had made the complementary point: laughter, he argued, requires a momentary anaesthesia of the heart; it addresses the pure intelligence, and its object is always some rigidity, some mechanism, encrusted upon the supple life of a human being (Bergson 1911 [1900]).

The cycle permits a more specific formulation. What is incongruous in it is always the same thing — the mechanical in the living, the automatism of word, eye, and body — and what determines the affective sign is the position of the human in relation to the mechanism. The rule may be stated as a chiasmus: *horror is the mechanism in the place of the human; comedy is the human in the place of the mechanism.* When the automatism occupies the beloved — when Linda's body dances without Linda, when the Force rushes upon a defenceless subject — the mechanism has taken a human place, and the effect is horror. When Ash fits a chainsaw to his arm, when his body is struck and flung and drenched like a stuntman's dummy, when he recites the merits of his shotgun like a salesman, the human has taken the place of a mechanism, and the effect is comedy. The passage from the scream of 1981 to the "Groovy" of 1987 is a passage from one position to the other within an unchanged world. Bergson supplied the bridge himself: among the comic devices he analysed was the dancing-jack, the puppet on strings, which becomes comic whenever a character seems moved by another's hands (Bergson 1911 [1900]). The marionette that Kleist found graceful and Ligotti found horrifying, Bergson found funny. The Deadite is all three, according to where the spectator stands.

Freud's essay "Humour" (1927) adds the dynamic that Bergson's account lacks. Humour, Freud argued, is the triumph of narcissism: the ego refuses to be distressed by the provocations of reality and insists that the traumas of the external world cannot touch it, while the superego speaks kindly to the frightened ego, telling it that the world which seems so dangerous is only a game for children, worth no more than a jest. His example is the criminal led to the gallows on a Monday who remarks that the week is beginning well (Freud 1961 [1927]). Ash's catchphrases are gallows humour in Freud's precise sense: formulas through which the ego, facing its own dismemberment, declares the catastrophe a game.

Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) offers the deepest account of why terror and delight belong together. Following Schopenhauer, Nietzsche described the tremendous horror — *das ungeheure Grausen* — that seizes a human being who suddenly loses faith in the cognitive forms of experience, when the principle of individuation seems to suffer an exception; and he added that if we join to this horror the blissful ecstasy that rises from the innermost ground of the human being at the collapse of that same principle, we glimpse the essence of the Dionysian (Nietz-

sche 1999 [1872]). Possession is the collapse of the principle of individuation: the beloved's person dissolves into the anonymous "we" of the Deadites, whose refrain — *join us* — is the Dionysian invitation to dissolve. The cycle's horror is Nietzsche's *Grausen*; its splatter-carnival is his *Verzückung*. The Groovy Sublime is the Dionysian in the age of the chainsaw.

The Athenian festival of Dionysus presented, in each tetralogy, three tragedies followed by a satyr play in which a chorus of satyrs — part human, part beast, comic, obscene, grotesque — burlesqued the matter of myth. The cycle's history arranges itself as such a festival: grim entries (1981, 2013, 2023, 2026) alternate with satyric ones (1987, 1992, the stage musical, 2015–2018), reconstituting a unity of tragedy and satyr play that Western drama long ago dissolved. Plato's *Symposium* closes on the same unity. At daybreak, after a night of drinking and speeches, the narrator wakes to find Socrates compelling the tragedian Agathon and the comedian Aristophanes to agree that the same man should know how to compose both tragedy and comedy; the poets, too drowsy to follow, fall asleep in turn, and Socrates departs at dawn (*Symposium* 223c–d). The *Evil Dead* cycle is that argument concluded: a vigil that ends at dawn, in which the same hand has written both.

8.3 The Comic Demonology of the West

The cycle's union of the demonic and the comic is not a postmodern novelty but the recovery of a medieval institution. In cantos XXI and XXII of the *Inferno*, Dante and Virgil are escorted along the bolgia of the grafters by a troop of devils, the Malebranche, whose names — Malacoda, Barbariccia, Alichino, Calcabrina, Cagnazzo, Farfarello, Graffiacane, Libicocco, Draghignazzo, Ciriatto, Rubicante — are themselves jokes. They lie about a bridge, squabble, are outwitted by a sinner, and tumble into the boiling pitch, and their leader gives the signal to march by making a trumpet of his backside (*Inferno* XXI.139). The episode is the first great sequence of demonic slapstick in European literature, and its comedy does not mitigate the horror of hell but belongs to its order. Dante's journey is dated to the spring of 1300. The Malebranche and the Deadites of *Army of Darkness* are, by the internal chronologies of their works, contemporaries.

The medieval stage institutionalised the comic devil. The mystery cycles built hell-mouths that belched smoke and noise and populated them with clowning fiends, and the morality play *Mankind* (c. 1470) made Titivillus, the collector of mumbled syllables encountered in Chapter Two, a comic tempter whose entrance the play's vices make conditional on a collection taken from the audience (Jennings 1977). Mikhail Bulgakov's *The Master and Margarita*, written between 1928 and 1940, revived the tradition for the twentieth century: Woland's retinue of prankster demons, among them a giant cat, stages a black-magic show at a Moscow variety theatre in which the audience's own greed becomes the spectacle. The "splatter zone" of *Evil Dead: The Musical* is that variety theatre restaged: the audience comes to watch the demons and is itself drenched.

Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980), set in 1327, turns on a book. The lost second book of Aristotle's *Poetics*, devoted to comedy, survives in the library of a Benedictine abbey, and the blind monk Jorge of Burgos has poisoned its pages, so that its readers die as they lick their fingers to turn them. Jorge's motive is theological: laughter, he believes, frees the simple from the fear of the Devil, and without that fear there can be neither faith nor order; a world that laughs at the Devil will cease to obey (Eco 1983 [1980]). The *Evil Dead* cycle is Jorge's nightmare realised. Its deadly book is not the book of comedy but the Book of the Dead, and laughter is the human answer to it. Jorge was right that laughter kills fear, and the cycle confirms him; he was wrong that a world which laughs at the Devil must cease to fight him. Eco's library ends in fire, as the first *Evil Dead* film does: two burning books, one of laughter and one of the dead, which the cycle has spent forty-five years binding into a single volume. Ray Bradbury's *Something Wicked This Way Comes* (1962), in which a father defeats a sinister travelling carnival and its witch by laughing at them, belongs to the same tradition: laughter as the weapon against the demonic.

8.4 Defining the Groovy Sublime

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) founded the modern theory of the sublime on terror: whatever is fitted to excite the ideas of pain and danger is a source of the sublime, provided the danger does not press too nearly, and among its sources Burke listed obscurity, power, privation, vastness, and suddenness (Burke 1757). The Force is a Burkean object — obscure, powerful, sudden. Kierkegaard, in *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), had made suddenness the mark of the demonic itself, illustrating it with August Bournonville's Mephistopheles in the ballet *Faust*, who leaps in through a window and holds the position of the leap; the demonic, he concluded, is essentially mimical, and should walk as little as possible (Kierkegaard 1980 [1844], 131–132); the Force is suddenness as camera movement. Kant's dynamical sublime located the sublime in the mind's discovery, before the overwhelming might of nature, of a supersensible vocation that nature cannot touch, so that the experience ends in reason's triumph — again from a position of safety (Kant 1987 [1790]). Ann Radcliffe distinguished terror, which expands the soul and awakens its faculties, from horror, which "contracts, freezes, and nearly annihilates them" (Radcliffe 1826).

Kierkegaard's analysis fits the cycle closely. The Force never walks: it waits, still, and then rushes. The Deadite's horror is gestural before it is verbal — contortion, leap, freeze. And because the demonic is mimical, its natural counterpart is the comic mime. Campbell's slapstick and the Deadites' contortions are performed in the same medium, which is why the cycle can pass from one to the other without changing its means.

The Groovy Sublime departs from each of these at a decisive point. It belongs to horror rather than terror, in Radcliffe's sense: it is a sublime of proximity, of blood on the lens and stage blood on the audience, not of the distant storm. Yet it expands rather than freezes, and the agent of its expansion is laughter. It ends not in the triumph of reason over nature, as Kant's does, but in the

triumph of a prosthetic body over a demonic one, and its consolation is not a supersensible vocation but survival until dawn. Its affect is neither Burke's delight in danger at a distance nor Kant's respect for reason, but the convulsive, bodily exhilaration of a being that has accepted its own mechanism.

Mikhail Bakhtin supplies its social form. Carnival laughter, in *Rabelais and His World*, is festive, universal, and ambivalent; it degrades in order to regenerate; its body is the grotesque body, open at mouth and anus, protruding, merging with the world. And carnival, Bakhtin insisted, was a victory over fear — over the medieval fear of the sacred, of authority, of hell — won by converting cosmic terrors into comic monsters (Bakhtin 1968 [1965]). The Deadites are such monsters: terrors converted into carnival figures that nevertheless remain terrible. Georges Bataille supplies its economy. *The Accursed Share* (1949) argued that every system produces an excess of energy that must be expended without return — gloriously, in festival, sacrifice, and luxury, or catastrophically, in war (Bataille 1988 [1949]); Marcel Mauss's potlatch, the ceremonial destruction of wealth, was its anthropological paradigm (Mauss 1990 [1925]). The cycle's blood — the geyser of *Evil Dead II*, the blood-rain of 2013, the elevator of *Evil Dead Rise* — is the accursed share spent in potlatch, a lavish expenditure of effects budget and stage gore that serves no purpose but its own glorious waste.

The expenditure can be measured. For *Evil Dead Rise*, Lee Cronin publicised 6,500 litres — some 1,717 gallons — of blood cooked in a hired industrial kitchen, which he said he wanted to function as a character (Variety 2023); reports put the 2013 film's total at tens of thousands of gallons, most of it spent in the closing blood-rain, and the franchise's publicity has long treated quantities of blood as a boast — the way a host at a potlatch announces the wealth he is about to destroy.

The pessimist tradition supplies the Groovy Sublime's adversary. Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933) argued that humanity's overdeveloped consciousness confronts it with a cosmos that cannot satisfy its demand for meaning, and that human beings survive only through four mechanisms that limit consciousness: isolation, anchoring, distraction, and sublimation, the last of which converts despair into art (Zapffe 2004 [1933]). Thomas Ligotti built upon Zapffe a philosophy of horror in which consciousness is a malignancy and the proper conclusion is the cessation of the species (Ligotti 2010); Eugene Thacker's "horror of philosophy" finds in the genre a thought of the world-without-us that undoes the human claim to meaning (Thacker 2011). Ash's catchphrases are, in Zapffe's terms, distraction and sublimation; his job at S-Mart is anchoring; his cabin is isolation. The pessimist reads the Groovy Sublime as a defence mechanism; the Nietzschean reads it as an affirmation. The thesis of this dissertation is that in the cycle the two readings coincide: "Groovy" is the point at which a defence becomes indistinguishable from an affirmation, at which the mechanism that protects the ego is also the formula by which the ego wills its fate.

Ernesto de Martino provides the anthropological ground for that coincidence. Studying magical practices in southern Italy and beyond, de Martino identified a *crisi della presenza*, a crisis of

presence: the risk, in moments of extreme vulnerability, that the person will dissolve, cease to act, and be merely acted upon. Magic and ritual, in his account, are cultural techniques that rescue presence by placing the crisis within a protective metahistorical order (de Martino 1948). His study of Apulian tarantism, *La terra del rimorso* (1961), described women "bitten" by the tarantula and cured through days of ritual music and frenzied dance — possession treated by rhythm (de Martino 2005 [1961]) — and his posthumous *La fine del mondo* (1977) analysed apocalypse as a cultural and psychopathological experience. The Deadite is the absolute crisis of presence, the person wholly acted upon; the survivor's liturgy — shotgun, chainsaw, formula — is a ritual technique by which presence is reconquered. Tarantism's cure by music is the ancestor of the cycle's: rhythm, repetition, and frenzy as therapy.

The posture's name is apt to a degree its first speaker could not have intended. "Groovy" descends from the jazz idiom *in the groove*, current from the early 1930s, which described a musician playing fluently and effortlessly, like a phonograph needle tracking the groove of a record. To be groovy is to run in the groove: to perform smoothly as a mechanism playing back a recording. The word with which Ash affirms his prosthetic body is a phonographic metaphor — and the cycle's demon is summoned by phonography, by tape and vinyl, by a voice running in its groove after its speaker's death (Chapter Two). The record's groove, moreover, is a spiral that returns upon itself, and a damaged record repeats a single phrase forever. The Groovy Sublime is the affirmation of running in the groove of recurrence: of being a needle in the record of the eternal night.

The definition may now be stated. *The Groovy Sublime is the aesthetic-ethical posture in which the human being, confronted with a cosmos of automatism — an evil that is plenitude, a person that is occupancy, a word, an eye, and a body that operate without subjects, and a time that recurs — affirms its own becoming-mechanism in a laughter that is at once defence and affirmation, enacts that affirmation in a ritual technique for restoring presence, the liturgy of dismemberment, and shares it in a collective vigil that ends at dawn.*

8.5 The Vigil

The Groovy Sublime has a ritual form, and its form is the vigil: a night kept awake in the presence of danger, ending at dawn. The form is transcultural. *Maqlû*, in Abusch's reconstruction, was performed through a single night and concluded with purifications at daybreak (Abusch 2015). The *Symposium* is a vigil that ends at dawn with the argument for the unity of tragedy and comedy. Dante's *Inferno* is a descent through a single night that ends as the poets emerge to see the stars again on the threshold of an Easter dawn — *e quindi uscimmo a riveder le stelle*. The Christian Easter Vigil, the oldest night-liturgy of the Church, begins with the kindling of a new fire and culminates in the proclamation of the resurrection of the dead. It is difficult, after this genealogy, not to notice that the franchise's two most recent titles name the Vigil's two defining acts: *Rise* and *Burn*.

The cult screening is the vigil's modern form. J. Hoberman and Jonathan Rosenbaum's *Midnight Movies* (1983) documented the late-night screenings at which films such as *Night of the Living Dead*, *Pink Flamingos*, and *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* became occasions of participatory ritual, attended again and again by communities of devotees (Hoberman and Rosenbaum 1983). *The Evil Dead* entered this circuit almost at once, and its stage musical formalised the ritual's climax by baptising its front rows in blood. The splatter zone is the vigil's aspersion: where the Easter Vigil sprinkles the faithful with the water of new life, the musical sprinkles its congregation with the blood of the dead.

8.6 Laughter Lost?

Chapter Seven observed that the heirs inherit the rite but not the laughter. Two readings of this loss are available. The first is pessimistic. The grim entries of 2013, 2023, and 2026 belong to a period in which the horror genre, under the rubrics of "elevated" and trauma-centred horror, has largely exchanged carnival for grief; on this reading the Groovy Sublime was a historically specific posture — American, masculine, late twentieth-century — and the heirs' endurance marks its end.

The second reading, which this dissertation prefers, is dialectical. The laughter has not vanished; it has migrated from the protagonist to the audience. Writing of the founding film, one critic observed that its gore is so excessive that it becomes hilarious with enough viewings (Eisenberg 2023). The observation contains a theory. Bergson identified repetition as a fundamental device of the comic: the jack-in-the-box that springs up each time it is pressed down becomes funny precisely by recurring (Bergson 1911 [1900]). Repeated viewing mechanises the scare; what horrifies the first time is, on the tenth, a routine anticipated and savoured. Recurrence, the formal metaphysics of Chapter Six, is thus the engine of the Groovy Sublime itself: it transmutes horror into comedy over time by making the mechanism visible as mechanism. The cult audience that returns to the night again and again is the alchemist of this transmutation. The heirs need not say "Groovy"; the congregation says it for them, on the tenth viewing, at midnight.

The reception of *Evil Dead Burn* suggests a further refinement. Where one reviewer found the film humourless, a survey of other notices reported comic interludes built around Polly, the grandmother with dementia and a wooden prosthetic foot (Li 2026; Chan 2026). If so, the laughter the heirs do not inherit has passed, like the prosthesis, to the oldest woman in the house. The comic body of the cycle has moved from the hero to the grandmother, and with it the Bergsonian mechanism — a failing memory, a wooden limb — on which laughter depends.

8.7 Conclusion: A Necro-Comic Metaphysics

The *Evil Dead* cycle proposes a world in which evil is plenitude, the person an occupant, the word, the eye, and the body automatic, the dead creditors, and time a recurrence. To that world it responds neither with theodicy, which would require a God, nor with despair, which would re-

quire a soul to despair, but with a posture — the Groovy Sublime — in which the human being consents to become a machine among machines, and laughs. The posture has a liturgy, the dismemberment of the beloved dead that completes their funeral; a chronotope, the vigil that ends at dawn; and a congregation, the audience that returns to the night until its terror becomes a joke. This is the necro-comic metaphysics of the cycle. The Conclusion considers what it implies.



A night kept awake in the presence of danger, ending at dawn.

FIGURE 12 *The vigil: five nights kept awake until dawn (§8.5).*



CONCLUSION

Dead by Dawn

Implications and Horizons

The *Evil Dead* cycle is a philosophy of automatism that has found, in horror-comedy, the form adequate to its thought. That has been the claim of this dissertation, and the preceding chapters have sought to make it good across the franchise's word, eye, body, and survivor, and across its remakes and its heirs. This conclusion recapitulates the argument, draws its final and most general consequence — that Kandarian Automatism is a name for the automatism of cinema itself — and weighs its implications, its limits, and the horizons it opens.

C.1 The Argument Recapitulated

Chapter One reconstructed a mythos conceived as a funerary text: a Book modelled on the Egyptian *Book of the Dead*, named after Lovecraft's phantom grimoire, relocated to an imagined Sumer, financed in part by a stranger met at a discount store, and transmitted from its American founder to Uruguayan, Irish, and French officiants, each of whom reperforms a fixed sequence of twelve functions. Chapter Two read the Book and its recordings as a theory of language in which every utterance acts, no utterance requires a subject, and failure is merely another act, and set that theory against the Mesopotamian incantation corpora whose authority it mechanises. Chapter Three argued that the Force is perception without a perceiver and that the cycle's demon is indistinguishable from its camera, so that spectatorship becomes possession. Chapter Four theorised the Deadite as the body without the person, lodged between two deaths, the improperly buried dead returning as creditors, and read the cycle's remedies as funerals and its gore as the work of mourning performed with a chainsaw. Chapter Five read Ash as the prosthetic sovereign — Freud's prosthetic god, McLuhan's auto-amputee, Stiegler's Epimethean, Canetti's survivor, Frazer's King of the Wood — crowned by a kingship that falls from the sky. Chapter Six showed that recurrence is the franchise's formal metaphysics, Nietzsche's demon announcing the night's return and Ash's "Groovy" affirming it. Chapter Seven followed the matrilineal turn, in which possession comes home to the addicted body, the maternal body, and the marital bond, and the survivor becomes an heir who inherits the chainsaw but not the laughter. Chapter Eight assembled these findings into six theses, proposed a chiastic theory of horror-comedy — horror as the mechanism in the place of the human, comedy as the human in the place of the mechanism — and defined the Groovy Sublime as the laughter, at once defence and affirmation, with which the human being consents to its own mechanism in a vigil that ends at dawn.

C.2 Cinema's Own Automatism

The argument's final consequence returns it to the thinker invoked at its outset. In *The World Viewed* (1971), Stanley Cavell located the material basis of film in a mechanical *automatism*: photography satisfies the wish to reproduce the world by removing the human agent from the act of reproduction, so that the world is presented to us without our hand in its making. Cavell extended the term to name the forms — genres, types, conventions — that generate new instances of

an art, calling these, too, *automatisms*, and argued that the task of the modern artist is to discover the automatisms of a medium anew (Cavell 1979 [1971]).

Read through Cavell, the four orders of Kandarian Automatism are figures of cinema's own. The automatic word is the soundtrack: the recorded voice that speaks after its speaker has gone, the dead professor on tape. The automatic eye is the camera: perception without a perceiver, the kino-eye that the cycle names the Force. The automatic body is the filmed body: a body animated by stop-motion, prosthetic makeup, and the Fake Shemp, performing a person in the person's absence. And the augmented body is the performer whose body the apparatus extends, strikes, drenches, and multiplies. The cycle's horror is the horror of what cinema is: a machine that records voices after death, sees without seeing, and moves bodies without their owners. Its comedy is the comedy of what cinema does to those who submit to it. The morphology of the Kandarian rite, moreover, is an automatism in Cavell's second sense — a form that generates instances — which is why the franchise can be remade indefinitely and why each remake is a rediscovery of what the form can do. Kandarian Automatism is, finally, a name for the automatism of film itself, seen from inside a horror movie by filmmakers who discovered, in a Tennessee farmhouse with a camera lashed to a plank, that their medium was a demon, and decided that this was groovy.

C.3 Implications

For horror studies, the dissertation proposes that horror-comedy is not a hybrid of two genres but the apprehension, under two affective signs, of a single automatism, the sign being determined by the human's position relative to the mechanism. The chiastic rule of Chapter Eight is testable beyond the cycle — in *Re-Animator* (1985), *Braindead* (1992), *Shaun of the Dead* (2004), and the comic possession films that followed them — and suggests that incongruity theories of horror-comedy should be refined by a theory of automatism. The dissertation further proposes that the anthropology of death — Hertz's double burial, van Gennep's liminality, the Mesopotamian economy of the *eṭemmu* — is indispensable to the study of possession and undead cinema, whose returning dead are, with remarkable consistency, the improperly buried.

For the philosophy of film, the dissertation offers a demonstration, after Mulhall and Cavell, that a commercial horror franchise can philosophise, and that its seriality is part of its thought. It also proposes a revision of apparatus theory: primary identification with the camera, which Baudry and Metz construed as the spectator's assumption of a transcendental subjectivity, is construed in the cycle as possession, and the spectator's sovereignty as a demon's.

For comparative religion and Assyriology, the dissertation documents the persistence, within a popular franchise that never consulted its sources, of structures homologous to Mesopotamian funerary and exorcistic practice: the dead who return when offerings fail, the incantation spoken as citation, the night-long ritual of burning that ends at dawn, the devouring maternal demon, and the kingship lowered from heaven. It suggests that the West's imagined Mesopotamia — from the excavation that opens *The Exorcist* to the Kandarian ruins — deserves sustained study as

a chapter in the reception of the ancient Near East, conducted with the vigilance that Said's critique of Orientalism demands.

For media theory, the dissertation extends the archaeology of haunted media from the telegraph and the radio to the magnetic tape, the gramophone record, and the respawning video game, and proposes that "groovy" — a word of affirmation descended from the phonograph's groove — names the condition of a subject who has learned to live as a recording.

C.4 Limits

Three limits must be acknowledged. First, the dissertation reconstructs the cycle's immanent logic and claims no access to its makers' intentions; where it cites reception, it does so selectively and without the ethnographic methods a study of fan practice would require. Second, its comparisons with Mesopotamian, Greek, medieval, and modern materials are structural homologies, not genealogies, and its Assyriological claims rest on specialist editions and secondary scholarship rather than on independent work with cuneiform sources. The franchise's pseudo-Sumerian mythology remains an Orientalist construction, and the comparisons offered here are intended partly as a corrective to it, not a vindication. Third, the corpus is open. By the Lévi-Straussian principle adopted in the Introduction, every future variant will belong to the myth and may revise its reading; further installments are reported to be in development, and the conclusions of this study are accordingly provisional.

C.5 Horizons

Several lines of research follow. A comparative study of what might be called necro-media cinema — *Ringu*, *Pontypool*, *Videodrome* (1983), the cursed-recording film generally — would test the theory of phonographic necromancy beyond the cycle. The national inflections of the rite in the hands of its Uruguayan, Irish, and French officiants merit study in relation to their respective horror traditions. Game studies might examine the respawn as an industrial form of eternal recurrence. Reception ethnography might attend to the splatter zone and the midnight screening as contemporary vigils. And a history of horror cinema's imagined Mesopotamia, from *The Exorcist* to the present, would place the Kandarian mythology within the longer story of how modernity has dreamed the ancient Near East.

C.6 Coda: The Turn at Dawn

The Evil Dead ends at dawn. Ash, alone and drenched, steps out of the cabin into the first light; the Force gathers itself in the woods and rushes toward him through every door; he turns, and screams, and the screen goes black. The cycle has spent forty-five years extending that cut — into a sequel that begins by retelling it, a medieval war, a retail counter, a ruined future, a rehabilitation, a condemned tower, a marriage, and a game that restarts it at will. What it has discovered in

that darkness is that the scream and the laugh are a single sound heard from two positions, and that a human being who has become a machine among machines can still choose which of the two to utter. The dead do not stay dead by dawn; dawn is only the hinge on which the night turns over. The cycle's last word, like its first, is a scream that turns, if one keeps the vigil long enough, into a laugh.



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A NOTE ON VERIFICATION

NOVEMBER 2026

- **Corrected.** *Within the Woods*: the final shot leaves the surviving woman's fate open (previously given as survival). Lovecraft's etymology: sourced to his letter to Harry O. Fischer, late February 1937 (previously misattributed to Joshi 2001, now removed). *Detestande feritatis*: issued 27 September 1299 and reissued February 1300 (previously "at the turn of the year 1300"). *Evil Dead Burn*: critics divided over its comedy rather than finding it uniformly humourless. *Evil Dead Rise*: the drone's operator is a young man, not a teenager.
- **Confirmed against editions, scholarship, or plot records.** Abusch on *Maqlû* (one night into the following morning, month Abu); Geller on the Udug-hul closing rubric and the Marduk–Ea dialogue; the Akītu double slap, negative confession, and tear omen; Titivillus (John of Wales, c. 1285; Jennings 1977, *Studies in Philology* 74, no. 5: 1–95); Raimi's 1988 statement of regret and Álvarez's account of the 2013 reinstatement; the 2013 film's purification rites, deaths, and self-mutilations; Ruby Knowby's claim of authorship, Elk Grove, and "Ashy Slashy"; the drone prologue and looped structure of *Evil Dead Rise*; the release and plot of *Evil Dead Burn*.
- **Not re-checked in the first round (most since checked; see the second-round notes below).** Kierkegaard's illustration of the sudden by Mephistopheles' leap in a ballet; the ventriloquist simile, taken from a secondary summary of the Princeton edition; the opening formula of the Sumerian King List; Goldstein 1908's title and pages; Wiggermann 2000's series details; the influence of *Evil Dead II* on *Doom*; Stephen King's role in financing *Evil Dead II*; the 1,700-gallon blood figure for *Evil Dead Rise*.

SECOND ROUND (NOVEMBER 2026

- **Confirmed.** *Evil Dead II*: King's intervention with De Laurentiis, the budget of about $3.6 million, the condition that it resemble the first film (the medieval pitch deferred to *Army of Darkness*), the unrated release through Rosebud Releasing in March 1987, and the unlicensable footage behind the recap. *The Evil Dead*: Scott dismembers Shelly with an axe; Ash shoots Cheryl and beheads Linda with a shovel. Kierkegaard's Bournonville example (*The Concept of Anxiety*, Princeton edition, 131–132). The opening formula of the Sumerian King List (ETCSL; CDLI). Goldstein's 1908 case (*Journal für Psychologie und Neurologie* 11: 169–187). Wiggermann 2000 (pp. 217–252). The conception of *Doom* as *Aliens* crossed with *Evil Dead II*. Cronin's 6,500 litres of blood. Edison's 1878 "Family Record." The 1923 records, the Book's three volumes, and Bruce Campbell's voice cameo in *Evil Dead Rise*.
- **Corrected or added.** Goldstein's title ("Zur Lehre der motorischen Apraxie"). *The Evil Dead*'s second sexual assault, by Linda's possessed corpse upon Ash, now named in Chapter Three. The reason *Evil Dead II* restaged its recap. The Lovecraft letters entry moved to its alphabetical place.
- **Still unverified after the second round (all resolved in the third round; see below).** The ventriloquist simile in Kierkegaard, taken from a secondary summary of the Princeton edition that proved accurate on the Bournonville passage. Sterne 2003 on sound recording and embalming, cited from memory. The attribution to Paravicini Bagliani's *The Pope's Body* of the link between Boniface VIII and Roger Bacon's longevity writings; the link itself is reported in a 2025 review of his collected studies. *Duke Nukem 3D*'s borrowing of Ash's catchphrases.

THIRD ROUND (NOVEMBER 2026

- **Removed.** The ventriloquist simile previously attributed to Kierkegaard. Searches of the English translations and of the Danish text of *Begrebet Angest* did not locate it, so Chapter Four no longer attributes it to him. The paragraph now rests on passages located in the Danish text — the definition of the demonic as the inclosed and the involuntarily disclosed, the "involuntary telegraphy" of its disclosure, and the remark that such disclosure can be almost comic — and, for the history of the possessed voice, on Schmidt 1998 and Connor 2000. English renderings of the Danish are the author's.
- **Confirmed.** Sterne 2003: chapter 6, "A Resonant Tomb" (pp. 287–333), on sound recording and the post–Civil War technologies of preservation, embalming among them. Paravicini Bagliani 2000: chapter 9, "Prolongatio Vitae," and part IV on Boniface VIII; the treatise on delaying old age is now described as attributed to Roger Bacon, its authorship being debated. *Duke Nukem 3D*'s borrowing of "Groovy," "Hail to the king, baby," and "Come get some," and Campbell's public objection to it.
- **Outstanding.** None of the items listed after the second round remains unverified.

KEYWORDS

Evil Dead; Sam Raimi; Bruce Campbell; horror film; horror-comedy; splatstick; Kandarian Automatism; Groovy Sublime; liturgy of dismemberment; automatism; possession; Deadite; *Necronomicon*; grimoire; performativity; iterability; *pharmakon*; media archaeology; phonography; acousmêtre; apparatus theory; point-of-view cinematography; the weird and the eerie; numinous; uncanny; automaton; marionette; abjection; grotesque body; carnivalesque; between two deaths; funerary ritual; double burial; mourning; Mesopotamian demonology; *eṭemmu*; *Maqlû*; *Utukkū Lemnūtu*; Lamashtu; Sumerian King List; prosthesis; cyborg; auto-amputation; survivor; King of the Wood; eternal recurrence; *amor fati*; repetition compulsion; remake; seriality; chronotope; Final Girl; monstrous-feminine; matrilineal turn; ethics of care; coverture; sublime; Dionysian; gallows humour; comic demonology; cult cinema; midnight movies; video nasties; franchise studies; film-philosophy; comparative mythology; Norse mythology; Orientalism; sexual violence on screen; moral panic; homo sacer; the formless (informe).

SET IN EB GARAMOND, CINZEL & CORMORANT GARAMOND

